

DEVIL IN THE WATERS

Book Eleven



Immaculate Conception

KT MORRISON

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BOOK ELEVEN

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All characters are over the age of eighteen.

IMMACULATE CONCEPTION

A DEVIL IN THE WATERS Novel

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PINK LINES

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 21

The fan roared in the quiet tomb of their master bathroom. Alone and sitting on the toilet, elbows on knees, she stared at the marker, believing and disbelieving the story it told. *Two pink lines mean you're pregnant.* How was she pregnant? How on earth was it even possible? She'd been careful. In the time before she'd gone back on Ortho-Tri-Cyclen, Josh had worn condoms every time, hadn't he? But Josh's condom usage was not any kind of problem here. It would be a blessing of relief to remember a time where he had come inside her.

Why's that? She sighed and rubbed her forehead. *What if Devlin got you pregnant?*

But how? She'd gone on the pill again mid-July, maybe around the seventeenth. She shouldn't have had unprotected sex for six weeks after. She had unprotected sex with Devlin three weeks later in the Royal York. But there was no way she was ovulating. Her period would have been a few days after he'd come inside her.

The first missed period she'd chalked up to the renewal of her birth control pills. It was alarming, but not an emergency until she'd missed the second period.

Josh had to be the father. He had to be.

But there were what-ifs. *Terrifying* what-ifs. Like the time she and Devlin had messed around together in Devlin's Mercedes outside her gym. He'd worn a condom. He'd worn a condom, but she'd rubbed her bare sex up and down his bare erection, humping it, teasing herself with its arousing size. Devlin must have leaked pre-come. Did his pre-come contain just the

right amount of actual sperm to get pushed inside her and do its nasty business? Those condoms must have had a spermicidal. But what if he'd broken the condom? He could have torn the condom, and though he didn't ejaculate, his leaky urethra had pushed so deep inside her it spit his payload right into her cervical aperture, like a slippery watermelon seed, the spermicidal lubricant never planting its kiss of death.

Those early days with Devlin seemed now to have been the life of a different woman. She'd been so sexually amplified, so hungry, so horny. A tramp. A hussy. Could she blame rampant hormones? Some post-natal supercharging that had taken place after the miscarriage, some kind of sexual hyper-drive pumping out sex hormones, getting her hot and bothered and looking for insemination? It would be a wonderful explanation. Now she would need an expert witness to testify.

She gathered up the pregnancy test stick and its related packaging, bundled them in the plastic Shopper's Drug bag, and stuffed it all into the bottom of her purse, to be thrown into the trash bin on foreign territory.

His *humiliatrix* emerged from their bedroom, head down, looking tired and frail. And short. She wore a suit but just stocking feet, coming into the kitchen and opening the fridge. He said over his shoulder, "Good morning."

Kimmy's voice, quiet and low: "Morning."

This was how it was now. Still together, but miserable and distant. A vast divide between them. Kimmy, ashamed and damaged, admitting to some great sin she didn't know Devlin had cued him to, a mea culpa without punishment. Other than this disjointed purgatory they existed in.

But even meek and beaten, she drove his passion high into the clouds. She was bad. So bad. He'd used her as a lure to fish in his dark waters and Kimmy had let the big fish take her from him. Even if just for a moment.

He looked at her slender ass, her long legs. And, just like every time he'd spied her this weekend, he grew aroused. This perfect creature allowed Devlin to put his fingers inside her. To do it for pleasure. It felt good; he was sure. So good she'd betrayed him. Betrayed and lied.

He'd asked her if it turned her on when she'd humiliated him behind his back and she'd nodded. The pain drove him wild. The hurt had an exquisite, feathered edge. The sweetest, kindest, woman he knew had got her rocks off cheating on him with his bully. It had made their illicit encounter hot. He knew it had. Last night he'd laid sleepless in bed, hard as a rock, imagining how the encounter had come to be, picturing for the first time Kimmy as the instigator rather than the victim. Instead of Devlin pulling Kimmy's strings, it was Kimmy pulling Devlin's. Asking Devlin to finger her. Asking Devlin Stone to satisfy a sexual urge.

And maybe more than using his fingers.

But that wasn't something he was ready to discover. That was something not so easy to believe. Still just a fantasy, and still just one of Devlin's cruel taunts. If that was true, if Kimmy and Devlin had been fucking behind his back, Devlin would have presented those receipts the other night. He would have done it then, knowing he would *never* get Josh back to his apartment again, and sending videos would grow stale if Devlin enjoyed no responses.

Kimmy turned from the fridge, and he flinched like she'd seen his lusty imaginings, like he sat on the bed with a porn site open on his laptop. She snatched a clean spoon from the sink and peeled off the foil top on a cherry yogurt, and spooned a small amount past her pouting lips. Lips that wore no makeup, no blood-red color. Not anymore. Infidelity had robbed this pretty pheasant of her luster and fancy plumage. Kimmy was molting.

Eyes turned down, but head lifted now, she said, "I'm going to see him today."

Josh's stomach bounced and his balls hoisted like she'd faked flicking her fingers to smack them. Something Devlin would have done in the school halls so many years ago.

Him was Devlin. She would see Devlin Stone today because she still worked for the man who'd fingered her married pussy. He swallowed with difficulty, then said, "Okay," wanting to know more but too afraid to ask right now. Did she want a man who would forbid her? Did Kimmy want him to put his foot down and say no, she would never work at Stone Custom Brokerage again, no matter what? If he did, would her luster return? Did his lust drive her to Devlin, drive her away? Did his lust remain now?—excusing her loyalty to Devlin's employment because a man

shouldn't tell a woman where she could or couldn't work, when deep down he knew even no matter how awful this situation was, he'd grown hard watching Kimmy in meager misery, reduced to a fallen angel in his kitchen, her wings burned off after hot proximity to the man she knew she should never have trusted. But she couldn't help herself. Devlin was attractive, no matter how bad a man he was.

The urge to tell her she had to quit, she had to stay at home today and make cat baskets, withered on his tongue. He bowed his head like he had a hard task to do, but one that he must perform.

Even though she gripped the blade still lodged in his aching heart, love bloomed, and he crossed the kitchen and put his arms around her. She melted against him, light as paper, resting her head on his collar. He pushed his hard on into her stomach.

She and Devlin had a scheduled meeting after lunch with a company called Big New Harvest, a Chinese-Canadian, Chinese-nationals endeavor out of Agincourt, by way of Qingdao. Devlin wanted her at his side when they met with Benjamin Chan, an important meeting set before Josh's discovery of her indiscretion with Devlin Stone. Last week Devlin told her to meet him downtown for lunch, then they'd go to the meeting together, and now she sat waiting in Bonjoubar for him to arrive. A man who revolted her, but one who might be the father of the tiny life growing inside her. For a heart that weighed so heavy in her chest, its beat came so light and fluttering.

Devlin appeared in the doorway, coming into the restaurant off the alleyway from Cumberland to Yorkville Avenue. An alleyway she and Josh had passed by only a few weeks ago, the day she'd bought her husband a suit to wear out for his *fun night* with Devlin and some of Devlin's friends. She'd dressed her husband to walk into a trap set to humiliate him and to sink their marriage. The hostess pointed Devlin her way, but she didn't wave or acknowledge him. Devlin spied her and led the way through the restaurant while the hostess followed.

Devlin smiled as he sat in the leather chair across from her, but she only nodded, and neither of them spoke until after the host had left. Devlin laced

his big fingers together, combined hands near his cheek, elbows on the table, regarding her with sparkling mirth. Like the situation he'd put her in by humiliating Josh with her panties was only a small thing done so many days ago. "I hope you're not wearing sneakers with that suit."

She didn't answer right away, taking a moment to sip from her ice water first. "So what if I was?"

His head rocked with a silent chuckle, his eyes narrowing. "I really wish I was sitting with the Kimmy Chang I used to know."

"Kimmy Chang, as you call her," she said, "is a product of her environment."

"You're saying what, you're like a houseplant I've put in the wrong window?"

She looked away from him, over his head and around the luxurious Yorkville restaurant. "You can't have everything, Devlin."

He scoffed and looked away as well. "I hate such limiting speech."

She shook her head, exhausted. "Even one who conquers all knows there's nothing without nurturing."

He showed her a brief, unimpressed face, then looked around for a server. "Sun Tzu or something? Ooh, or some samurai, I bet. Five Rings?" He got the server's attention.

She said, "Common sense."

He said, "Let's have whiskey."

"I'm fine with water."

Devlin bowed his brows and showed a pout. "You won't even drink with me now?"

"Benny Chan doesn't drink. I don't want to smell like alcohol."

He grunted. "Qingdao has some great bars."

"That's the Bavarian influence," she muttered.

Devlin laughed it off like she'd been joking and asked the server for a bourbon. The man knew nothing of Qingdao. He looked her way and asked again, "Wine? A white wine?"

She told the server she'd like another Perrier with ice. When they were alone again, she said, "Do you like Chinese people, or are they just money to you?"

The question bothered him, and he said, "Everyone I do business with is money to me, and I don't care where they come from." Then he regarded

her through narrowed eyes. “And I don’t make money in this business without relationships. How am I going to make a relationship with someone I don’t like, especially for some dumb characteristic like their ethnicity? What a crazy question to ask me.”

She said, “You think you’re good at building relationships?”

“It sounds like you don’t think I am, which is insane, because you *know* I am.”

She sighed and rubbed her brow. “I don’t know anything anymore.”

“I hope you know everything about Benny’s contracts.”

She did, and she didn’t need to respond.

Now Devlin sighed, too, touching his brow, doing it in a purposeful imitation of hers. He regarded her from below his brows, his gaze amused and alluring.

She asked him, “What?”

And he said, “There are things I don’t know, too, Kimmy. It’s not just you.”

“Like what?”

He smiled and leaned closer. “Like what you got up to in my apartment last Friday afternoon.”

BONJOURBAR

Devlin revolted her. The snide look on his face showing the arrogant domination he played at. But what she hated most was how he'd beaten her. She'd gambled so much, risked it all—and *lost*. Losing the sanctity of her marriage and the vigor of her husband was only one component of her misery. She'd also lost the battle with this man she thought little of. The realization brought a chuckle to her throat, but it was quashed by the sudden horror that Devlin knew she had been in his apartment—not from the report of his cleaning service, but because he had cameras, and had watched her play around with a Devlin-sized dildo in his bed while he was away. Devlin would see that as a victory, as another folding over of his opponent. She was smarter than Devlin—so much smarter Devlin didn't even see it. And yet here she was, shame-faced and admonished. *Humiliated*. Humiliated by a man only good for one thing: sex.

Devlin laughed at her stony reaction. “Look at that face,” he taunted. “It makes you mad, does it? You don't have to be mad, Kimmy. You're welcome to my apartment, even when I'm not in it.”

She still showed him no expression, no reaction.

Devlin played with his napkin, touching the corner of the linen, thumbing it over like he was lost in thought. Then he looked up, not at her, but around at the busy restaurant. They sat at a booth, her with her back at a half-moon banquette, and Devlin seated in a chair across from her on the other side of the table. He lifted his muscular bulk from his chair and swung into the banquette crowding her to one side.

She regarded him as coolly as she could even though her mind scrambled to assemble a defense if he'd seen her in his bed, watched her masturbate with an oversized dildo on his laptop. He would probably masturbate as well, watching her do it, dick in his hand and watching his security camera playback. No retort or warning came to her lips, no taunt or superior display—she was too afraid he'd seen what she did. He didn't stare at her or smirk or anything she'd thought he would do. He ran his teeth over his bottom lip, still looking around the restaurant as if he was trying to find the right way to word something.

At last, he regarded her. "I want to hope there was a good reason for you to be there. A good reason for *my* sake. I'd like to think you miss me. Miss our time together."

She stayed firm, no smile, no facial tic, only lifting one eyebrow a centimeter. "You're nostalgic?"

Devlin stroked his face, his large hand pinching his cheeks and drawing down, contorting his handsome face into something harrowed for only a moment. Then he let his face go and smiled. "What terrible things did you get up to in my apartment, I wonder?"

Her nostrils flared, and she was sure he knew; sure he'd watched her fuck herself with a cock that imitated his. In his bed. In bed with his suit. Her eyes narrowed, and she grimaced, hating that she could give away something of her emotion, but helpless to it now, picturing what Devlin would have seen, remembering her self-humiliation: she'd put the enormous dildo through the unzipped fly of his empty suit and sucked it.

Devlin looked away, then looked at her again, his eyes showing some humor, not intimidation. "Did you molest my toothbrush, put it in the toilet?" He scrutinized her. "That doesn't seem like your style."

She lifted her napkin from the table and folded it into a triangular sail, her hands nervous and needing a task, putting the napkin on her lap with no purpose, flattening it on her thighs, looking down to avoid Devlin's dark gaze.

"Plus, you probably know you couldn't put that toothbrush into any hole in your beautiful body that my tongue hasn't already explored."

She muttered, "You're disgusting."

His hand went over both hers and her folded napkin. He said, "Hey," and she looked up to meet his gaze, any sort of defiance she wanted to show

cowering in shame. Now he said, “I’m trying to make you laugh, Kimmy. Not disgust you. I know I fucked up. Okay?”

Her eyes darted over his, looking for any tell that this was a manipulation, that he’d seen her play with herself in his bed, that this was a ruse meant to lower her guard so he could get the blade near her throat.

“I don’t always get it right.”

She said, “You did what I told you *not* to do. The one thing that I said was a deal breaker. *One* thing.”

He wanted to fight back, wanted to defend himself, inhaled a breath to arm his argument, but then exhaled. “I see it a different way. I see it your way too—but, yeah. I did what you said not to.”

She nodded her chin across the table. “Go back to your side.” His hand was still over hers.

“I was really... I was really hopeful when I heard you were in my apartment. Okay? I thought it might mean something. I know you don’t believe it, but I have feelings. Real human feelings.”

“You should can the sales pitch, Devlin. I will never fall for your bull shit ever again.” Now she looked his way and met his gaze with the strength she’d been missing before.

“You don’t believe I have feelings?”

No hesitation: “I don’t.”

Devlin was uninjured by her remark, still regarding her, those black shark-predator’s eyes trying to portray a man of deep and complicated emotion. “I can’t convince you if you don’t believe. But it’s true that I miss you. I miss seeing you. I miss being with you. When I heard you were in my apartment, I hoped maybe you missed me, too.”

“I needed a nap.”

“When you’re on the clock?”

She smiled a cold smile. “I like that you miss our time together, Devlin. I like that a lot.”

He smiled as well. “What if you’re the cruel one? You think it’s me and it’s really you.”

She showed mock sympathy. “Oh, am I cruel to you, Devlin? Do I make you miserable?”

He frowned, his thumb stroking her wrist. “Don’t tell me I make you miserable. Don’t make things up.”

She pulled her hands out from under his, and his hand remained on her lap. "If you hurt Josh, you hurt me. If you make Josh miserable, you make me miserable."

"And if I turn you on, I turn Josh on. If I make you come, I make Josh come."

She scoffed, disgusted by him. "Go back to your side, please."

He stayed where he was, his hand heavy, resting high on her thighs. "You're symbiotic. You and Josh are one thing. You think I don't know that?"

"We're not one thing, Devlin."

"You just said it yourself. One organism, one unit, sharing a life, sharing emotions. It's you who did the wrong. It's me doing the right."

That hurt. The wrongness he'd reminded her of weighed heavy now, dragging on her heart. "I'm going to make it up to him. I'm going to make him love me again."

"He loves you, Kimmy. He loves you more than anything. Maybe he loves you more now. The real you. Just give him what he wants. Don't deny him."

She grabbed his hand but didn't pull it away, didn't want to make a scene in the busy restaurant. "Go back to your side, Devlin."

His thumb hooked over hers, and his fingers parted. Her slim fingers worked between his, holding his hand, wanting to pull it away and wishing he hadn't pulled the plug on their devious fun.

He said, "If you stop what we were doing, explain to me how you aren't the cruel one?"

"I didn't say I'm not cruel."

"Are you careless?"

She nodded.

"If what we did was wrong, you're cruel. If what we did was wrong, Josh would be long gone."

"He doesn't know what we did."

"He knows, Kimmy. Trust me, he knows."

Josh knew but wouldn't face it, wouldn't ask her to come clean, wanted to shy away from the truth and live in some manufactured place of contrived peace.

"He knows, and he loves you more than ever."

“He hates me.”

“Hate isn’t indifference. Indifference is the opposite of love. Josh hates in you the part of *himself* that he hates. You’re giving him what he hates that he wants. You don’t want him to hate himself, do you?”

She shook her head no.

“Josh misses you. Not the woman he married—he loved that one, too, that one was his *buddy*—but you showed him you could also be the woman of his darkest, *wildest* fantasies.”

“I don’t ever want him to hurt.”

“It’s not up to you how he hurts. He hurts himself. He *likes* the hurt sometimes. Craves it. He likes how you scare him. . . . Kimmy, you make more money than he does. You’re taller than him. You’re beautiful. Your IQ is thirty points higher. You’re fucking savage. And you guys are one thing. A unit. It’s you who is fucking up the unity. It’s you denying your husband all the things he wants. And it’s crazy, because you want it, too. You have to miss what you became. For like six weeks in your life, Kimmy, you were on top of the world. You had everything you wanted. You miss that woman. Josh misses that woman. *I* fucking miss that woman.” He sighed with heavy lamentation and shook his head.

She scowled, her neck throbbing and her pulse pounding hot blood into her cheeks and temples.

He said, “Look, if I fucked that up, I’ll own it. You don’t have to listen to me. I don’t expect you to. I want you to consider a different perspective. You did nothing wrong. You never did a single thing wrong, Kimmy. It was fun to think it was wrong, fun to sneak around and play devious games, but that was a ruse to heighten our pleasure, to raise the stakes because the real stakes were low. Low because both of us know Josh isn’t allergic to what we were doing. Not one bit. Deep down you know it. You really do. That’s why I say *you’re* the cruel one. But I know you’re not cruel. I know everything you did you did with the hope your marriage could survive it. And here’s the truth: Josh knows everything and Josh will be home when you get home tonight, and you’ll eat dinner together and you’ll climb into bed together, and before you guys go to sleep you’ll both play a fantasy behind your sleepy eyes, one where Kimmy is in charge, Kimmy is kicking ass, Kimmy is making all the money, and her daddy loves her more than her sister, and she has the best sex of her life three or four times a week, and she

goes home and her husband orders takeout and rubs her feet, and they watch movies together and cuddle, and every ion in Kimmy Chang's life is humming along, vibrant and incandescent, and Josh is happy and Devlin is happy and—"

She whipped her hand out from under his, snatching the napkin along with it. Tears swelled, and she squeezed her eyes shut, pushing the napkin against them. She said, "Can we not do this now, please?"

Devlin removed his hand from her lap and rested it on the table. "I need you back, Kimmy."

"I'm here. I didn't go anywhere. What do you want from me?"

"Confidence."

She shot him a cold look. "I *am* confident." Then saw herself reflected in Devlin's obsidian gaze; wary and cornered, harassed, defending herself now like a hissing, cornered animal.

Devlin reached in his jacket and pulled out the money clip she'd seen on his dresser the day she'd snuck into his apartment to masturbate with a rubbery facsimile of his enormous penis. He plucked out two one-hundreds and tossed them to the center of the table. He held out his hand to her, assuming she would take it.

She frowned, unsure. "What are we doing?"

"Getting out of here."

For the longest moment she stared at him with her hands in her lap, hating him, hating herself. Her lips trembled, her head ached from resisting the urge to cry. She put her cold hand in his and he guided her out of the banquette, out of the Bonjoubar, and into the alley.

BLOOD RED

Devlin held her hand, and they marched westward on Yorkville, heading to Avenue Road and she resisted him at last, demanding to know where they were going. Devlin told her The Hazelton, the hotel where they were meeting Benny Chan, and she said, “It’s too early. We didn’t eat,” and stopped on the sidewalk, the high noon sun coming straight down on them.

Devlin didn’t let her hand go. “Early’s better than late,” he said, and she winced at the reminder of those two pink lines her urine lit up this morning.

“Devlin, where are we going?”

“I told you: The Hazelton.”

She wanted to argue and wanted to resist, but when he walked again, she followed along with him, both of them connected by grip, weaving around slower pedestrians, crossing the narrow street when they got a chance. They made their way to the entrance of the five-star hotel, striding under the cooler shade of the street-side honey locusts.

Devlin had purpose and vigor and they were an hour early for the meeting and she sensed, of course, something else was up. She pulled her hand from his in the lobby. “Why are we here so early?”

“We’re not early.”

“The meeting’s at two.”

Devlin said, “What meeting?”

She looked around the lobby, the cool and grim space, chilled with silent air conditioning, high ceilings, concrete and gray, bright blue fabric

and burnished gold accents. The incredible quiet, the solitude. And realized she'd been had. "The meeting with Benny."

Devlin's expression was stone serious, not amused, not playful. "I moved it."

"Why?"

"I have a staffing problem I have to deal with first."

She frowned, closed her eyes, and opened them again. She said nothing. She was the staffing problem. *She* wasn't wearing heels. *She* wasn't who he wanted her to be.

She snatched her hand away from his and scowled at him, her gaze burning hot and baleful. "I'm not *fucking* you," she hissed through gritted teeth.

He returned the venom. "Who wants to fuck you, Kimmy? That's not the only thing I care about."

"You brought me here."

Like she'd made a good point, he stilled, considering it. He said, "It's not what you think. Just follow me."

And like a good employee, like a dutiful worker, she did follow him. They loaded onto the elevator and rode to the fifth floor. A left turn out of the elevator cab and they faced a black door, which Devlin opened with a key card. He'd already checked in, already claimed this room. The room meant for the meeting with Benny Chan, but there would be no Benny Chan here today.

He ushered her inside like he was annoyed with her, and she entered the hotel room. No, a suite; she stood in foyer before a main room, a sedate and sophisticated space with muted, mushroom colors and pale gold accents, two couches, a bureau, a blank TV above the bureau; two black pocket doors slid open on the opposite wall, a glimpse into a bedroom.

Devlin said nothing about the space, but her reaction was autonomous. She missed this. Missed luxury spaces meant for sex, missed post-fuck room service, missed whisky, missed spending an afternoon in a place like this. But her hand protected herself, protected the unborn inside her, palm over the flat below her skirt's waist. Her lips trembled.

Devlin stepped past her, heading to one of the pocket doors. "Come with me."

She followed her employer into the bedroom, using the other pocket door, the one he hadn't used, arriving in the same room, standing on the opposite side from him. On Devlin's side of the bed, another pocket door was slid away to reveal a large bathroom, every surface clad in black marble with jade and ivory rivers traveling its landscape.

Spread on the bed between them were women's garments and a pair of beautiful shoes. Devlin wanted her to play dress up.

Her head bowed with a heavy sadness and her gaze fell on her simple gray suit and her scuffed brown loafers. Clothing suitable for work. But unsuitable for Devlin. And Devlin would tell her they were unsuitable for Kimmy Chang.

She wanted him to say it. Wanted him to whisper it in her ear.

But instead she bowed her head further, overwhelmed with a tidal swell of regret and shame and hurt.

"In here," Devlin said, and when she looked up, he'd moved into the bathroom, beckoning her to follow.

She trudged past the bed, her eyes roaming the fine clothing, looking for labels, admiring their luxurious fabric, recognizing the shoes as Louis Vuitton Blossom sandals in black patent, the four-inch heel a slender inverted tulip. Shoes she'd wanted. Sleek, minimal, barely there; a bright gold V on the ankle strap.

Devlin pointed to a stool with a gray padded seat, set between the huge marble tub and the marble vanity that ran the length of one side of the room. She stopped on the threshold of the bathroom, her hands gathered at her front and holding her pocketbook over her crotch, like a woman protecting herself before a purse snatcher or some other villain who wanted *more* than the valuables she carried on hand. "Devlin..."

"Have a seat, please." His tone was even and patient, but objection wouldn't be countered. Perhaps for the first time ever, Devlin seemed like her boss. Like someone whose requests were to be followed. She'd never seen him that way, hadn't ever considered him as a man who held a position over her. She'd always thought of him as *less-than*. As fun. As arrogant. But harmless before her own machinations. But things had changed. Today she was afraid. Not of the man's demands, but of his authority. How he could take from her the things she wanted. That she'd *earned*.

She approached the stool but didn't sit. There were cosmetics on the counter, expensive things; lipstick and hair gel and— A jealous hammer thumped her chest, the clawed end ramming between her ribs. Another woman had been here with him.

But, no. That wasn't the case.

With his hands on his shoulders, Devlin guided her to face the mirror, oversized and irregular shaped, like the shape of a hand-drawn circle. She regarded her reflection, Devlin, over her shoulder, handling her hair.

He said, "What do you see?"

"I don't want to do this, Devlin."

"I see a boring bureaucrat. A beige office dweller failing to thrive under fluorescent lights."

She shook her head, but not enough to shake her hair out of Devlin's stroking hands. "A bureaucrat?"

"Women make good bureaucrats. Not you, you *were* one, then you weren't. But look at you now. . . . Kimmy, I had unleashed you. I had revealed your true self, and you loved it."

Her hand came up to take her hair from Devlin, her eyes turning away from the reflection, uncomfortable emotions coming to the surface.

"You were one. A bureaucratic lawyer for the regime, a do-gooder, but the do-gooding didn't make your pussy wet."

She scoffed. "I didn't work for the government, Devlin."

"You know you did. You were an outside agent who understood the government's own tangled bureaucracy, and you helped those-in-need navigate it. Which is what the regime wanted you to do."

She said nothing, even when he stroked her hair again and guided her to look at the mirror once more. He gathered her hair back from her face, took away the shaggy locks that hid . . . Hid her what? Her *beauty*? She sniffled and rolled her eyes.

"You're afraid of that woman in the mirror. You don't see her when you're looking out her eyes, but you see her when you meet your own gaze."

"Metaphysical nonsense," she muttered.

He turned her around to face him. "You don't even deserve to see that woman."

It shamed her and she held her own lapels like she wanted to cover herself, like he'd arrived unannounced and found her lounging in her bathrobe, naked underneath.

He pushed her hands away and took hold of her lapels, his face close to hers. "Women can be vicious but are generally agreeable. They're agreeable because they hate chaos. They don't want anyone to disturb their nest. They sit in bureaucratic positions like a viper in a nest of vipers, ready to defend their tiny bureaucratic throne like a mother goose on her eggs. But you don't see them threading the network of that bureaucracy, or, god, creating something from nothing, giving life to wealth where none existed."

Creating life. She said, "For that, you need a man?"

He smirked. "Doesn't have to be. *You're* not a man. You're far from a man."

"Then what am I?"

He whispered, "A huntress."

Her gaze roamed away from his, moving to the tub behind him. Devlin unbuttoned her shirt. She didn't stop him. Button by button, he worked his way down the shirt, the shirt tucked in and blousing open, revealing her stomach, her bra, her collar. She still didn't stop him. Didn't stop him when he pulled the shirt out of her skirt's waistband and let it hang like her open jacket. She stepped back until her butt rested against the marble edge of the long vanity. Devlin followed. Followed, and opened her jacket and her skirt, peeling them back to reveal her bare shoulders. He was hard. His cock was big and aroused, hanging still, the meaty bulge touching her thigh as he disrobed her.

The discovery of Devlin's arousal didn't revolt her. Didn't anger her. She hated how it stirred heinous emotions and desire. Her neck craned like she would submit to him, but her body stayed rigid and non-compliant, letting this brutish rogue remove her shirt and jacket, taking her arms out now and tossing the clothing to the floor.

He looked down at them. "They don't even look good on that marble floor." Then he returned to regard her, his eyes stroking her bare skin, her shoulders, her covered breasts, her ribs and sternum. "They sure don't make a man wonder what's under them. Look what's under them. Look how incredible you are. You are perfection, Kimmy Chang." His huge warm hands went on her bare shoulders, and he stepped back, giving her space,

turning her to face the mirror again. “Don’t look in your eyes. Look at your skin. Your collarbone. Your long, beautiful neck.” His fingertips stroked under her hair, starting under her ear and traveling to her collar, raising her arms in gooseflesh.

She stared, her struggle to resist against his powerful command soft and feathery. She looked good naked next to him; her bare skin beside his expensive suit, his height, his masculine face. He unlatched her bra, and it slumped on her chest. He pulled it away to reveal her traitorous nipples, hard and swollen.

A small and satisfied chuckle rumbled behind her, Devlin pleased at the sight of her arousal. He unzipped her skirt and let it fall to the marble floor. She stood only wearing plain underwear and tights and loafers. His huge penis pressed against her backside and upper thigh.

Devlin reached past her to the cosmetics arranged on the counter, selected a stand-up tube, popped the cap and squirted something into his palm. He raked his fingers through her hair, pulling it back from her face, revealing her stark jawline, her long neck. Her hair gleamed like liquid with whatever he’d applied to his hand. He slicked her hair right back until it hung in heavy wet locks to her slim shoulders, and she admired herself a moment, turning her face one way, then the other, while Devlin wiped his hands dry on a crisp white towel.

“Turn around and face me,” he said.

While she turned, he selected something else from the cosmetics. She watched him twist the end on a lipstick, a Rouge Louboutin, the blood red stick rising from the black and gold tube.

He touched her lips with the velvety stick, spreading warm and soft on her sensitive flesh. She closed her eyes again and lifted her chin. Devlin held her throat and painted her lips red.

TWO LIPS

Once he'd painted her mouth, he admired her, admired his handiwork, his hand on her throat, soft but so big and strong. He tossed the expensive lipstick to the marble behind her. She watched him through narrowed eyes, wishing the way his gaze worked over her didn't turn her on so much. She closed her eyes, turned her face away from him, leaning back, leaning out of his reach, her butt touching the counter.

With her hands on the counter, she bowed her head, back to Devlin, eyes still closed, thoughts fleeting, mind empty, yet somehow battered with unspoken challenges. So much was wrong. So much was right. And she owned all of them. Wrong and right were her own things. They were things she'd crafted out of nothing with words and actions, and now she pretended to deaden in overwhelm, but the overwhelm was an engine she'd started.

Her eyes opened, and she regarded her wedding band. She raised her face to the mirror and looked into her own eyes. Her hair was slicked back and gleaming. Her lips were red and provocative. Devlin had done a good painting, but she would have done better. Her shoulders looked thin but strong. Her neck long and graceful. She stood with her shoulders back and admired her own sexual arousal, her swollen nipples, a shimmer on her skin. Devlin aroused her. A heavy wet sexual feeling sagged between her thighs, hot and aching.

Thumbs slipped under tights and underwear, she smoothed them down and over her hips, baring ass to Devlin, who watched, eyes dark and intent. Down to her knees, then feet stepped out of loafers and now she was naked. Naked in a bathroom in a swank hotel in the city with a masculine man.

They would eat fine things, and they would enjoy luxury. At home, another man would wait for her return.

Now she faced Devlin. He smiled. When he moved forward, she told him no by shaking her head, extending an arm to keep him at bay. "Take off your jacket."

Devlin remained where he was, like an invisible wall stood between them, two former lovers meeting through prison partition. He removed his suit jacket, slinging it to the tub edge, standing in pale blue shirt and dark tie, silk braces with leather straps buttoned into pants.

"Tie off. Unbutton," she said. And as he complied, she faced the mirror again, taking up a black hairbrush and running it through her hair in meaningful strokes, tidying looser locks wanting to tumble from her fine hairline and touch her face. In the mirror, over her shoulder, Devlin went topless, round shoulder muscles rippling as he lay the other items over the suit jacket, turning now, broad chest, hairy and masculine, silk bracers hanging down his thighs. Man of dreams and man of nightmares. But both states summoned. States of quantum effect big-banged in a timid mind that sometimes flexed strong and agile.

She sat on the padded gray stool, fingers curled over the edge, legs wide, heels on lower steel ring. "Touch your chest."

A broad smile spread on his devilish face, a man who adored corruption. She watched large hand she admired stroke through chest fur, grab muscle, sweep down to abdomen. He was strong, arms thick and bulged with muscle. The shape of his huge organ pressed out the fabric of his pants. He unbuttoned and unzipped, and she humped her pussy against the backs of her wrists, feeling the spread of wet. Devlin sat on the tub's edge with his pants down his thighs, his large penis engorged but not erect, bowed like a boomerang, the head resting on a thigh.

At the sight of his implement, her breath deepened and her skin prickled. Devlin's endowment was an incredible thing. It did things to her she never knew. It touched into deep pockets of forbidden pleasure. It stretched, it pummeled; pain and pleasure as one thing. Payload. A deep payload she craved.

She said, "Get it hard."

Devlin made a small sound in his throat like sound of protest, but complied. Devlin didn't like instruction, even when directing what he

already desired. He hefted his heavy meat and stroked. It bowed and waggled, but not for long. It went straight and thick. She pleased herself, both of them touching themselves while admiring the other. Devlin's big balls swayed and jostled with his movements. She loved watching them. Loved watching his penis transform, loved its astounding sexual power.

Then he stopped and let his cock stand upright, the size outrageous, slumping to one side under its own weight. He watched her hump her wrists, rocking on the chair like a long-limbed gargoyle, but flesh and blood.

He wanted to fuck. She wanted to fuck.

But she wouldn't.

So she slipped off the stool, standing over him, very close. She looked at his cock. It had looked good in his hand, but it looked better in hers. The juxtaposition of slender feminine and burly masculine satisfying, galvanizing. It also disgusted her. Devlin was a pig.

She said, "Finish."

He looked at her, mind forming a response, some *thing* that would put her in the place he wanted her, but knew he'd accomplished a lot today and didn't want to be pushed further back. Devlin had many wants. He took his cock in hand again and stroked. Did it like a show for her, trying to turn her on. And it did. A man in expensive suit, tall, foreboding, wealthy, muscles and horse cock, equaled perfection. The hardness she provoked was perfection.

But she left him to it, wandered out of the bathroom naked, gel-wet hair on her collar. Devlin jerked off while she examined the clothes he'd provided. Black Dolce & Gabbana suit. Size zero. Instead of separate undergarments, a sheer stretch-lace bodysuit with a thong back. Black poplin shirt with point collar. Made in Italy.

Devlin ejaculated. Chuffing breath and male grunts. She turned to the bathroom, see-through bodysuit in hands, and regarded him, bowed over, legs wide, braces hanging down the marble tub. His come splattered the marble floor, pearls and ivory and jade on black. He was catching breath, his hair out of its comb-back, one lock dangling on tanned brow. She wanted to fuck.

She stepped into the sheer bodysuit, loving expensive fabric on her skin. Pulled embroidered shoulder straps onto shoulders, tugged thong string in

place, adjusted hips. Devlin stood, brown elephant trunk hanging out of dark suit fly. He stepped around male evidence on marble and came to pocket door threshold. "You're dressing?"

"There's no meeting with Benny."

"Next Tuesday."

She stood straight and looked around the room, out into the suite's entrance and sitting room. Let Devlin see her body under the lace, nipples showing, still hard. "Same place?"

"Same place," he said, looking down behind her. "Same bed."

She ignored him and faced the bed, looking at the clothing again, and wanting her feet in those shoes.

"I want to touch you."

She said, "No."

"I'm going to touch your back."

"No."

"I already came. What's the harm?"

She told him to go ahead if he had to, unbuttoning the Italian shirt.

Devlin close behind her, body warm. His hand on her back, huge, above top trim of bodysuit, big enough to touch both shoulders. Strong. So strong. She held her breath. Shivered. Got the shirt open and shook it out.

His voice low and stone: "I want you back."

She put on the shirt, soft cotton sliding on skin, buttoned it right to throat. Devlin's hand off her skin. His naked cock touched her naked thigh, below scoop of tailored shirt. Skin hot and gummy. She looked down, saw its color against her color; tawny versus red-brown.

She said, "I'm going home."

"You don't have to. You can stay."

She said, "Rub it on my leg."

Short pause while Devlin determined her meaning. Then he held his half-hard cock and rubbed it up and down her leg in slow swipes, leaving her skin hot and tingling where his cock flesh touched. He rubbed his spongy flesh on her thigh, then up the back. Too high. Too close. Her stomach lit up like fireflies in the night and she swayed. Intense desire sought to burn a hole in her new lace undergarment. She almost fell to bed, but cleared her thoughts.

"Squeeze it," she said. "Squeeze it on me."

Another pause. Then Devlin squeezed just below his massive cock head, thumb pad indenting his shaft topside. A spool of silvery come-thread dangled from his urethra and she moved her thigh outward, wanting his semen on her skin. Wanting his wet, his hot seed. Devlin's breath trembled. She was bad. Evil. Dirty. He stroked his big member—growing hard and larger again—through his wet, spreading his seed across the flawless plain of her skin.

She leaned forward while he stroked his cock on her and removed the suit pants from the hanger. "That's enough," she said. "Step back."

Devlin complied, cock swinging before he stuffed it back in his pants and slung the braces over his bare chest and shoulders, fly open. She stepped into the pants and brought them up to her waist, clipped and zipped, shirt tucked in. Devlin watched her work, admiring her. He flashed a smile and raised one mean eyebrow. "The viper sheds its skin." He looked back to the bathroom where the clothes she'd worn in to the suite lay in unkempt heaps on the marble floor. "I think I came on your old suit."

She faced him, working her hands behind and above her head, arranging a tight bun. Face showed no expression.

He said, "You're going home?"

"Home. Home to my husband."

"Do you think I'm jealous of him?"

"No."

"I'm happy you're going home to him."

"Good."

"This is what I want." His eyes went up and down her, liking what he saw. Kimmy Chang. His white-man's exotic dragon lady. A possession.

"Trapping," she said. "You want display."

"You know you're more than that. I say it every day. If you looked like this and had trouble with long division, you wouldn't be in this room right now."

"Lucky me," she said, and slipped on the black jacket. She turned and sat on the bed, passed both shoes to Devlin. "Help me."

He took them, happy to have a task, getting close, taking her ankle and lifting her bare foot. He slipped the shoe on. Razor thin straps, barely a platform, just a wafer of leather, no toe cap. Her bare toes showing. She

should get another pedicure. She resisted strong urges to put her other bare foot against the column of hanging meat in his pant leg.

Both shoes on, she crossed one leg over the other. She eyed Devlin, devoid of emotion. "You're struggling to establish an acknowledgment of my great value, as you're framing it. What hurt the most when you fucked me over was crashing everything I thought I meant to you. You pulled the rug out from under me. I'll never trust you again."

"You will," he said, not begging, not pleading, just a simple statement of fact. "It will take some time, but when you see I'm right, you'll change your opinion."

"I told you not to do it."

"I was tired of waiting for you to do it."

"I don't want to talk in circles like this anymore, Devlin. I just want to work. I just want to make money. Are you happy I played dress-up?"

He raised his chin, standing over her while she sat. "That's not a costume, Kimmy. And I didn't ask you to wear them."

She nodded, stayed silent a moment. "I love Josh. You're not going to change how I feel. And before you say anything else, say how he *wants* this: Stop. Don't say it. I'm tired of the reactionary diatribe, tired of the patriarchal bull shit."

His mouth slimmed, eyes narrow. "Women created the Patriarchy to protect themselves, to give men the tasks that serve women better, and to puff men up, leave them to the pomp and vainglory they revel in. They just forgot to tell their daughters. Then the commies got a hold of them in the colleges and burned their faith in all the best books."

She raised her chin, narrowed her eyes. "Is that so?"

"Men do things for women," he said, emphasizing each word. "Do you know how much I risked on you? *Everything*. That's how much I wanted you. Don't shrink from me. Don't show up for work like that bureaucrat. I don't have you here to fuck you. I have you here because I want you here. I need you here. Commit yourself to me."

She sighed before she stood, and in the heels she stood almost level with Devlin. She felt renewed. Felt vibrant. Devlin demanded she return to her former statuesque command, but it had been toppled. She'd been on the floor like Venus de Milo, unable to stand with no arms attached to lift her body from the floor.

She disregarded his male beauty, his strong chest, his large shoulders. Kept her eyes on his. "I'm committed to Stone," she said. "The brokerage."

"And you're returned to me? Returned in spirit?"

"You have a dress code?"

"I do."

"And our fling?"

He sneered. "That was for you."

She chuckled. "And here I thought you missed me."

They both smiled and stared at each other, enjoying the moment, knowing there was much between them they pretended meant nothing. She hated smiling at him, but couldn't help it. And hated the effect of his smile. It would take one second to fall into bed with him, suck that huge cock, open her legs and let Devlin drive her into an orgasm at breakneck speed. But she would lose it all if she did, and she would be careful from now on.

Their eyes disconnected and right away it was like the buzz of some electric appliance stalling after pulling the plug. The room was tomb quiet. She left and Devlin followed her to the suite door.

She looked beyond him, back to the sitting room. "We'll be here next week?"

"We will. And you'll be Kimmy Chang?"

She shook her head, admonishing him for his childish mind games. "I'll see you, Devlin," she said, and opened the door, headed to the elevator.

Behind her, Devlin said, "Say hi to Josh for me, Kimmy."

SHEER

Someone familiar handled a head of lettuce, twenty feet away, far end of the produce department. It was Hyun, by herself, no Sophie.

A strange urge to flee bothered her. Why wouldn't she want to see Hyun? The urge to flee came clearer: the last time she'd seen Hyun was in the front hall of the apartment, after a fun night out together, dinner drinks and karaoke, then Josh coming home and presenting a pair of panties to her he shouldn't have. That's why. It had nothing to do with Hyun.

So she worked closer, zig-zagging through the produce aisles until she was behind her. Hyun looked adorable in cotton. Cotton sweats, white Reeboks, cotton sweater. Hair shaggy, the way Kimmy had worn it before she worked for Devlin. And before Devlin slicked it back today in a luxury suite at The Hazelton.

She whispered, "Stranger," and Hyun flinched, then turned. Her pretty face transformed from curious or alarmed to happy. Then faded to something more timid. Like Hyun remembered the odd moment between all three of them when Josh had come home that night. It had been obvious something was up. But then Hyun smiled again, happy to see her. Her eyes went from Kimmy's, down to what Kimmy was wearing, and then she performed some small action of self-consciousness: touching her hair, slumping against the edge of the Granny Smith apple display, putting one Reebok over the other.

Though she'd only popped into the big, suburban grocery store on her way home from work to grab some special items, she wasn't dressed like a normal shopper at the Ajax Loblaws. She attracted attention. She was out of

place. Six-feet tall in Louis Vuitton heels, black suit, black shirt; maybe eight-grand worth of clothing.

Hyun's lips wriggled, struggling with what to say, settling at last on, "You look *so* great."

"I'm just coming home from work. I wanted to make Josh dumplings for dinner and I'm missing a few things."

"Josh is back from Italy?"

They spent a few minutes catching up, and she told Hyun how she went to visit Josh in Rome for a few days when he was there, and Hyun said that was sweet, and she seemed to ease, thinking that whatever badness she'd witnessed that night Josh came home—and found them in bed together—everything was okay now. But, boy, it was *not* okay.

Hyun asked her, "Do you... would you want to get a coffee?"

And yes, she would. Really would. But she was pressed for time. Josh might get home before her and she had to change before then. How would she explain coming home in a different outfit, especially one like what she wore now? Well, of course she could say she went clothes shopping at lunch, but given the current state of her marriage and the suspicion of her husband, that answer would not suffice. She'd even told Josh this morning that she would be seeing *him* today. "I kind of have to get home. I want to make the dumplings before Josh gets back from work and I need to change before I cook. It's already almost five..."

Hyun's cute face showed dejection—and that wasn't what she wanted. They'd enjoyed their night out together. She'd realized something intimate about Hyun. That Hyun harbored romantic feelings for her. And while she didn't return the same feelings, Hyun's attraction flattered her and drew her closer to her former sister-in-law. She said, "What are you doing Thursday night?"

Kimmy came into the apartment moving fast, like she had to pee. Heels quick-clicking, keys tossed to the table, front door closed behind her with haste. Josh got up from the couch and went to meet her, the two of them facing each other in the front hall at the entrance to the kitchen.

But the woman in the hall wasn't who he expected, and he recoiled like in fright. The woman was clad in black, stood taller than him, hair gleaming, lips blood red. A specter had entered his apartment. The woman from his nightmares. From his dreams, too, the perverted ones. Devlin told him this woman was his fantasy. But this was the woman who cheated on him. The one who'd shattered him.

And she recognized his reaction, a blood red smile lifting to one side. But those black eyes showed sympathy. They showed affection. She lifted a cloth shopping bag, showing it to him like he'd caught her up to something and this bag was evidence of her innocence. "Aw, you're home already. I wanted to surprise you with homemade dumplings."

As she sidestepped him and entered the kitchen, he followed, scratching his chest, watching her, looking at those long legs in straight leg pants, those beautiful feet in beautiful shoes. "I booked it at quarter-to," he said, still studying her, loving what he saw but frightened of it, like the way a young child might eye a hot burner he'd singed himself on even after his mother had warned him not to touch it. "But I'm still working." He thumbed toward the couch and coffee table where he had his laptop open, working on ideas for Italy.

Kimmy left the bag on the counter without emptying it and tried to slip out again, but he stood in the way and they did a brief, awkward dance. She said, "I want to get cleaned up before I cook."

He stated the obvious question: "What are you wearing?"

"Just a new suit," she said, getting past him and leaving the kitchen, passing by the pass-through on the way to the bedroom. Her retreat inspired a wave of suspicion and he followed her, catching up to her in the bedroom, slipping the jacket off her shoulders.

"That's not how you left this morning. That's not what you were wearing. Did you go shopping?"

Her movement slowed, and he sensed something in her body language. Defeat? Like she'd been busted. She said, "No."

The answer surprised him, and he didn't know what to say. Had difficulty now forming in his mind how she'd come to arrive home in different clothing. There was an obvious horror, one his mind had been trained to pursue. "You saw him today?"

Kimmy went into the closet and found a hanger, put the jacket on it. “I did.”

“Did you dress for him?”

“We had a meeting today with Benny Chang, this guy who moves a lot from Qingdao.”

“China.”

“China,” she acknowledged. “And I had to look the part.”

“What’s the part?”

She faced him, hands on hips, tall and lean. “I have to look dangerous, Josh. And by dangerous, I mean competent.”

“You looked competent when you left.”

Kimmy untucked her shirt and unbuttoned it, then stopped. They looked at each other, saying nothing for a long time. A strong energy traveled from his wife, pushing him out of the bedroom, wanting to be alone while she disrobed. But he wanted to watch her disrobe. He said, “Where did you change?”

“Into what I’m wearing?”

His brow lowered. “Yeah. What else?”

Her hands went back to her hips. “I changed at the hotel.”

The answer rattled him. “What hotel?”

“The hotel where the meeting was.”

“They have a change room?”

“The meeting was in a suite.”

His heart sank. His shoulders slumped. “How did this work?”

Kimmy stayed silent a while, lips slimming, mouth moving around, her eyes roaming, not regarding him.

“Did it happen again?”

Now she was firm, like she was proud to say, “No. Nothing happened. I know what you’re saying, and no, nothing happened.”

“Do you have clothes you change into when you leave here? Is this what you do?” Like a bad girl leaving a good home and dressing in tramp wear when she’d arrived at school.

“No, I don’t, Josh.”

“Just today?”

Kimmy rubbed her brow, like she had heavy news. Not like she was harangued by him, but that she had difficult information for him to hear.

“Tell me,” he said, soft, but not timid. Did he even sound *supportive*?

Both hands on hips again, but her posture less proud, she said, “Devlin bought them for me.”

His stomach flinched, even though he knew it had been coming. “He bought them for you. He made you dress up?”

“Yes. That’s right.”

“And you went along with it?”

“He was right, Josh. He was right.”

Yes, sure, Devlin was right. Devlin was always right. “So you changed in the room? In the suite? You changed before this Benny Chan guy got there?”

Another long silence, Kimmy’s eyes on him, mouth shifted to one side as she chewed her cheek. “Benny Chan wasn’t there. The meeting was canceled.”

Stomach squirming, chest tight, lungs seizing, he put a hand on his chest. He’d never expected this horror to return today. Some day it would, but not today. Five minutes ago, he’d been click-clacking away on his laptop, feeling pretty good about himself. “You and Devlin were alone in the suite.”

Kimmy hesitated, hating the answer she had to give, the reluctance clear in the firmness of her mouth. “We were.”

The hesitation, the coming home with ingredients for dumplings, the rush to get home before he did. The way she stopped unbuttoning. He said, “Devlin bought you the clothes?”

“Yes,” she answered, resigned to the truth. At least he should commend her for that.

“Unbutton your shirt and open it,” he said.

Kimmy didn’t move for the longest time, but the moment grew too long and she knew he would ask again. She didn’t want him to ask again, because if he asked twice, he would be angry the second time. In no hurry, she unbuttoned the shirt all the way and then opened it and let it hang. The pants were high-waisted, up past her navel. Above that she didn’t wear a bra, only a lacy under thing, like a body suit, sheer, her skin showing. His knees jellied and his mind drained of blood, like someone had flushed an upstairs toilet. “Wider,” he said.

Kimmy pushed the shirt off her shoulders and let him see. Her nipples showed through the sheer fabric. This was how his bully dressed his wife. Kimmy complied. Kimmy dressed for Devlin as he asked.

He sat down on the foot of the bed and held his face in his hands.

Kimmy's voice, just above a whisper: "It's not what you think."

Into his hands, he said, "Who cares what I think, Kimmy. It's what I see that's killing me." He rubbed his cheeks, and Kimmy didn't defend herself nor console him. He looked up, eyes bleary, temples pounding. All was hopeless. "Take it off," he said. "Take it all off."

Kimmy showed submission, her face placid, serious. She unbuttoned and unzipped the pants, lifted heels and unbuckled shoes, flicked them off and returned to mortal height. She scooted the pants down her thighs and kicked her feet out of them, standing now in only some lacy, sheer bodysuit. No need for a bra, her small and perfect breasts needing no support, looking good without suspension in a spandex swath. Lean, thin, supple. Gorgeous. His wife. His wife dressed by an intruder.

He said, "I want to see the back."

Kimmy turned in place, revealing the bodysuit's thong seat. Kimmy's perfect firm ass cheeks bared, the sheer suit's cutouts high, swooping above her tailbone. The sight roused him and disgusted him. His heart twisted with animal lust and rage and humiliation. It was too much for a man to take. How could she expect him to accept such indecent outrage?

"Did you show him this— this *lingerie*? Did he see you in it?"

SHORTCOMINGS

“I didn’t show it to him. But he saw me in it.”

Disbelief and outrage intertwined, and his lips popped. He shook his head. “He watched you *change*?”

She nodded, lips pursed, knowing it was wrong, and knowing he had a right to be angry, but unbothered anyhow.

He bolted up to stand. “Like, what the fuck is going on, Kimmy? How can you tell me that? You can’t work for him anymore. And you can’t expect me to accept you working there. I haven’t fucking said anything—and you know I should have.” He stomped away like he would leave the room, but instead circling, pacing. “You *should* have quit. I didn’t tell you to quit. I didn’t tell you, but no one should *have* to tell you. Something in your head should have told you to do it.”

These were things he should have said a long time ago. But it was still good saying them now. He felt real. He felt whole.

Kimmy stood studying him, shoulders even, her legs even, feet parted. Confident in her attire. Not shy, not demure. She crossed the space between them, her muscles moving under her flawless skin. Sexuality crackled on her surface like electricity. Kimmy had always been beautiful, but since the summer, it was like he was seeing it anew. Or like Kimmy was seeing it in herself for the first time.

He had been on a roll and saying the things he’d wanted to say, but once she moved and those long legs brought her to him, he went mute, waiting for her to speak, waiting for her to determine the rest of the conversation.

Now face to face and eye to eye, she said, “I’m being honest with you, Josh. I’m being honest because I love you. And you won’t believe me, but because I respect you.”

He clucked his tongue and lamented with disdain the word, “Respect.”

She touched his arms, held them. “It’s true, Josh. But I’m not going to cry anymore and I’m not going to beg for you to see it.”

It surprised him—alarmed him—and he asked her, “Why not?”

“I’m just going to show you. I’m going to prove it to you. You won’t debate it.” She cupped his jawline in her fine hands. “Because I love you.”

For some reason, amidst this whole unholy terror he’d mired them in, he believed her. Her eyes told no lie. Everything in him softened. While he’d been so sure of himself, launching into the tirade that needed to be spoken, now he was unsure. “Well, I love you, too.”

“I don’t doubt it, Josh. I know it’s true.”

But the anger flared again, and he brought his arms up to push her hands off his face, stepping back, his eyes moving up and down her incredible body. “Take it off.”

She stared at him for a moment, but then complied. One long arm folded behind her and she unzipped the bodysuit. Arms pulled out of the thin straps, she shimmied it down her body, tugged it from where it had cinched in her venereal creases, and stepped out. She tossed it on the bed, and regarded him, plain and naked, hair still slicked back, eyes like a raven’s.

“I don’t understand how you could wear that.”

“Do you want me to explain it to you?”

“Are you being facetious?”

Her brow lowered, her mouth softening. “No,” she said, honest and emphatic.

He was quiet, still, then moved to the foot of the bed and picked up the lacy fabric Devlin had bought for her to wear. It smelled like Kimmy. Had hugged her body all day. Devlin gave it to her. A strong and powerful image blossomed in his mind, one of him taking the gossamer fabric and ripping it apart, like Hercules breaking his chains. But the truth was such a bold move could end with the tragic image of him discovering the undergarment’s trim proved too tough to break, and Kimmy would see him as powerless as he

felt. He handled the fabric, ran his thumb on its silk, then tossed it further up the bed. He sat down where it had laid.

Kimmy approached him, silent, naked, standing right before him. Her bare legs straddled one of his thighs, her thin knees on either side, her pussy right before his eyes. Her fingers wove through his hair, caressed his head, pulled him to lay his cheek against her hot, flat tummy. She whispered, "I'm sorry, Josh. I'm sorry it's like this."

"How can you work for him?" The question came from his pouting lips with no spark or instruction from his mind, just a placid evocation of his emotion while his eyes stared out their bedroom window at the September sky.

"I know you don't trust me, Josh, but I'm asking you to. On this one thing, I'm asking you to trust that I know what I'm doing."

He rubbed his stubble on her feather-soft skin, disbelieving the deep love he still felt for her. How could he trust a woman that he knew his bully had fingered behind his back? Maybe because he was the one to blame? Was that it? That it all fell at his feet. He was responsible. If he was responsible for getting them into this mess, would Kimmy be the one with the best sense of direction to get them out of it?

His arms circled her hips, pressing his face further into her belly, and Kimmy rubbed his head with care. He looked up then, and said, "He watched you dress?"

She nodded. "He did."

"You didn't stop him?"

"It doesn't work like that."

He closed his eyes and pushed away the images that wanted to loom in that darkness. He opened his eyes again. "How does it work?"

"He gets what he wants, Josh. Inch by inch, minute by minute. It's inexorable."

He fixated on "inch by inch." Found disgusting hidden meanings in her word usage.

"He's boiling you, Josh. Minute by minute, he's turning up the heat, and he's boiling you like a frog."

Had Devlin told her of his humiliation? Did Devlin tell Kimmy her husband showed up to see naked pictures of her and he'd worn her panties

to do it? Her husband was a pervert. Her husband was a cross-dressing pervert, manipulated by his high school bully into doing the unthinkable.

He shook that thought away and pushed back from her, his hands staying on her waist. She said, "Let me protect you," and touched his face again.

His breaths came shaky and his lips trembled; like all he'd ever wanted in his life was protection from a bully like Devlin Stone.

But he had to be a man before her, not a child. He said, "I don't need you to protect me." But he did. And he wanted her to. He tried to tell her with his eyes, looking up at her with love and longing. In this moment, he was sure he could ask her what happened. She would tell him the truth. She still caressed his cheek and played with his hair. But instead of demands for truth, all that was empty inside him, dying to be filled with the nourishment of truth, wanted to be filled with love, with intimacy. He lay back on the bed, taking Kimmy's arms and guiding her to follow, and she did, laying over top of him before rolling to his side. They faced each other, and he touched her face now. He said, "You love me?"

"I do," she said. "I have no doubt. I love you."

There was no lie, no manipulation, no deviousness. He kissed her mouth, held her neck, went soft and slow, savoring the stickiness of her lips, their supple cushion. His lips would be red.

Red from lipstick Devlin bought.

A sudden tightness seized his belly and he could feel his cock twitch and thicken. Had Devlin also made her put on the lipstick? Was this Devlin's favorite color on his wife's mouth?

He held her face back, thumbing her cheekbone, biting his own lips so she wouldn't see him wearing Devlin's color. He wanted to ask her if Devlin chose the lipstick, but knew he shouldn't mention Devlin now. Not now.

He kissed her again, his hand sweeping all over her warm, firm body. Grabbing her ass cheeks, sweeping her thigh, cupping the narrow of her waist. She pushed his sweats down and palmed his underwear-shrouded erection. "I want to make love. Make love to me."

A moment ago she'd told him she'd changed before the man who had corrupted their marriage, and now she wanted to make tender love. And he believed it, was sure it was real. He shrugged off his shirt, pushed his

underwear down, got to the foot of the bed, and stood to admire his wife. She lay on their bed without a stitch of clothing, bathed in golden autumn light.

But all he could think of was the bedspread's pattern around her. Could picture her now as the way she was, only she lay not on their marital bed but on some packages of potting soil or something, maybe in some filthy lakeside warehouse downtown. Or in Hamilton.

It made him harder. Made his cock throb stronger. "Spread your legs."

Kimmy looked puzzled, but she complied. She parted her legs and showed him her pussy. She gleamed wet. The wetness made him smile. Her husband aroused her. Not just asshole big-dick Devlin. But Devlin had shared this view. Devlin had looked down on Kimmy this way and been comfortable enough—and so was Kimmy—to take a picture.

He fell on top of her and thumbed the point of his erection into her hot velvet interior. Kimmy lifted her knees and clamped his waist with her thighs, caressing his head again. They kissed. Kissed while he thought how Devlin's fingers might be as big as the erection he'd slid into his wife. Devlin had fingered her. Did Kimmy orgasm? His first thought was to ask Devlin. Why ask Devlin when he could ask Kimmy?

"You feel so good," he said, thrusting in and out of her. He buried his face in her neck, eyes squeezed shut, compelling awful mysteries and quashing them at the same time, reminding himself how bad an idea it was to flirt with nihilism. But they were stubborn and stalwart ideas, and voices asked him why he would push them away when he wanted them so much.

It made him so hard. He was a stony battering ram inside Kimmy. Her hips rolled against his, her doing as much of the fucking as he was. She wanted it. Kimmy got horny sometimes. Sometimes she got horny around Devlin.

And he'd put the game they played in Kimmy's head.

He took her hands from around the small of his back and held her arms out, kissing her neck and her collar, thrusting deep inside her in short strokes. Kimmy moaned and whined, writhing underneath him.

"I love you no matter what," he said.

"I love you, too, Josh," she whispered, head rolling around as he suckled on her long, beautiful neck.

"No matter what you do."

“I know, I know, Josh, we’re together.”

“Even if you lay out like this for Devlin.”

She whimpered. But she didn’t stop. She still rolled her pussy into his stroke. His eyes roamed up to her troubled expression, eyes closed, turned away.

“I don’t blame you. I love you.”

“I know, Josh,” her voice was pinched with shame and sadness.

“Even if you showed him your pussy. Even if you got wet for him.”

Kimmy gasped and whimpered, head rocking back and forth like saying no, but all the while still humping his cock, still wanting sexual pleasure.

“Even if you showed him how wet you were. Even if you lifted your skirt in some Hamilton shipyard and showed him this perfect pussy, I still love you with all my heart.”

Her whimpers grew louder, more agitated. He liked taunting her with her own crimes, liked pummeling her with the harsh facts of her infidelity, of her wanton ways. Liked how it bothered her, liked how it riled her. Her beautiful face contorted as if in pain. Her lips trembled.

He slowed his thrusting, going easier, shallower, rousing her from ecstasy, returning her to their bedroom with her husband. Did she think of Devlin when they fucked?

“Tell me, Kimmy,” he whispered. “Tell me what you did.”

REVELATIONS

Kimmy told him she'd done nothing. "It was Devlin."

It was always Devlin. Even Kimmy could blame him. But that was better than her blaming her husband. If she accused him, it would be too much to bear. He wanted so much to know it all. Wanted to ask her, but was he really ready for the truth?

He caressed her neck and thumbed her strong jawline while Kimmy's face turned away from the window, away from the light, her eyes closed. She said, "He undressed me."

It was like a gut punch. Right away, he wanted to stop her, tell her that was enough. "He did?"

"Undressed me, made me look at myself."

He frowned, his stroke slowing, his cock inside her throbbing like a molten beam, harder than he could imagine, hearing how another man had subjugated his wife. If he'd shown up to Devlin's apartment in his wife's underwear, what kind of temptation prompted Kimmy to allow him to undress her?

What had been passionate sex turned now to confession. Cold gray confession made red and lurid by the circumstances, by the dreadful shame of it all. He wanted to fuck Kimmy and hear how Devlin had squeezed her juice.

"You let him undress you?"

"I didn't stop him. He was making a point."

His eyes pinched closed in disbelief. It didn't make any sense. What kind of point could license a married woman's boss to violate her that way?

“Kimmy, what are you talking about?” He reared back, his cock still inside her, on his knees now, Kimmy on her back below him.

Her head rolled on the mattress until she faced him, her eyes narrow, looking beautiful on her back this way, her skin tight, her hair loosening from its bun, but still swept away from her incredible face. “I’m telling you the truth. I want to tell you. If you want to hear it.”

Did he? Or did he not?

The truth was he didn’t want to know. Not out of fear, not out of sanctity. If he knew the truth, it would devastate him. And if he knew, *this* would end. It would be over. As terrible as this was—at times unbearable—there had never been anything in his life more exciting than this. Nothing had been more electrifying than the existential horror of Kimmy’s fidelity with a man who terrorized him.

If she told him what he feared, if she confirmed the darkest conjurings he imagined, he couldn’t *stay*, couldn’t *forgive*. The marriage would be over, wouldn’t it? And not just the marriage, the incredible bonds that lashed them together through this wicked storm—they would rot away. The closeness he’d felt to her in this misery would dissolve. They would separate, move farther from each other. And that hurt his heart more than the knowing would. Wasn’t that true? They’d gone through this ordeal together the way tribal cultures arrange ceremonies of passage. Ordeal poisons. Or trials by fire. They were meant to cement resolve, to test fortitude and conviction. Was his conviction such a gossamer thing that a man like Devlin Stone could breathe on it and it would zephyr away like the finest talc?

He got down over her again, his face close, his hands on the bed on either side of her head. “When was this?”

Kimmy looked at him, puzzled. “Today. At the hotel.”

His words rushed from him. “This was today?”

“Yeah,” she said, brow still furrowed.

Honesty for *today*. Today he could handle. Couldn’t he? A clean slate to begin with. “What happened?” Now those words didn’t rush, they whispered and trembled.

She breathed in and out at a calm pace, angling her head in reptilian study, her eyes looking deep into his. Her hands went to his neck and caressed. “He undressed me, and I ignored him.”

The urge to detonate, to tantrum and rail, sizzled, but his doomsday clock never hit midnight—held at bay by Kimmy’s calm and candid mien. Sincerity. Cold sincerity beaming his way like some ghostly golden spirit, warm and tender despite its frigid core; rich with warmth and fuggy womanhood.

“You ignored him?” He sounded hypnotized.

She traced her fingers through the hair above one of his ears. “Yes.”

At one time, she hadn’t ignored Devlin. He sensed it, heard it in her voice. But he already knew that to be true—had seen the proof with his own eyes, a photograph of his wife’s legs spread for another man’s enjoyment.

His hips began to rock, and wicked pleasure zipped along the plump flesh of his engorged cock head, plugged in a woman he loved with angst and disquiet, her liquid grip tight but so slippery.

“He saw you naked? You showed him?” Kimmy nodded, and he asked her now, “Was *he* naked?”

Her eyes narrowed further, into black, unreadable slits. “Yes.”

“He was? You were naked together?”

“No,” she said, palming his cheek.

“Tell me then,” he pleaded, tired of summoning questions, of prompting her step by step through this black mire. “You want to tell me, anyway.”

“No, I don’t. You want to hear it, but you’re afraid to ask.”

They stared at each other, and while her challenging words annoyed him, he couldn’t argue that she didn’t want to tell him. He only wanted to believe she didn’t tell him. But he believed that because there was much she hadn’t told him before.

The coldness of her tone, the blatant and brutal unambiguity, unnerved him. Like the value of his righteous contempt for her betrayal had declined. Like over a space of ten days, inflation had risen dark waters up his righteous shoreline and reduced his acreage. He’d had his chance a week ago to set things straight, to prune the shape of his lust and love with his wife, but he’d let another man shape it. Let his wife shape it. He wouldn’t describe for her what he wanted, and now she and Devlin told him.

Before this time had come, he had power. Now, once again, he had little. He hadn’t capitalized on his opportunity.

He asked her, “Why was he naked?”

“Because he wanted me, and I don’t want him. When he was naked, I left.”

“But you saw him naked?”

“I did.”

Fuck. Here it was. Frigid reality; a wicked wind against his face. “You’ve seen him naked before?”

She inclined her head in the silky locks framing her face, still touching his cheek. “You know I have, Josh.”

Though he knew she’d seen him naked before, this time her answer was different. She answered his question plainly with an answer he’d already heard—and she answered the question he’d *really* asked her but was afraid to form into words, to conjure into reality: there are times you’ve seen Devlin Stone naked that I don’t know about.

The truth crushed his heart, but remained wrapped in ambiguity and plausible deniability. He could keep lying to himself to protect his heart and his marriage. Even when Kimmy told him the truth, she afforded him dignity, if he wanted it. He’d pushed her over the edge and she still loved him. And no part of his heart didn’t love her.

For the first time since his Roman reverie, he felt like there was a glimmer at the end of the tunnel. For so long now he’d stayed mired in the muck of Kimmy’s and his transgression, and he hadn’t even known he was lost in it. He hadn’t known he was lost until a way out showed itself like light through a rainstorm.

His mind moved toward the light, stumbling and unsure, wary even, as though the light itself was a trap. What was the light? What was the hope?

Kimmy didn’t hate him for the darkness he’d cast on their marriage. He loved Kimmy, and Kimmy loved him. She would stay working for Devlin Stone, but she could refuse him. But now the hope closed on him like a Venus flytrap, poisonous tines coming down all around him. He could still enjoy his fantasy. He could still skirt the fine lines of right and wrong and stew in the sour deviant urges that consumed him. But when exactly had this fantasy ever come to him? Was it his own, or was it a planted seed? Was Devlin Stone his wicked gardener?

And did it matter when Kimmy was here with him in marriage and not running away with Devlin Stone, not abandoning him and removing from her husband her love and tender care?

His heart swelled with overwhelming relief and love. Not just of love for Kimmy, but the love he received from her. It was undeniable. It beamed from her. Not bright and ecstatic, but low and throbbing, like something real and enduring. She didn't hate him, and he didn't even realize he'd worried about that. It was like a suffocating veil had been lifted, and he felt united with Kimmy again. And, even if their reunion was delivered on a serving tray surrounded by the vile condiments of Devlin Stone's lust for Kimmy and his terrible manipulations, he received it well. Received it well because he needed it.

"He wants you, doesn't he?"

"His desire is strong, Josh."

He heard what she meant, but also heard the reference to Devlin's vitality, his male essence. And the challenge: how strong was his own desire for Kimmy and did she know it?

Kimmy's clear statement, the acknowledgement of Devlin's desire for her, the knowledge she'd allowed Devlin to photograph her naked pussy and finger her roared in his chest, sent his engine thundering. The longing to make love to her became something new, something baser, something dirty and challenging and wild and electric. Smooth strokes turned to pugilistic thrusts, and his pleasure soared.

His face hovered nearer hers and she didn't look away, Kimmy accepting the violent stabs of his cock inside her, absorbing it and showing him she could take it. But the violence had nothing to do with his feelings for her, it came from the incredible degenerate surge of his strangest kink, of the reality that his tormentor Devlin Stone wanted Kimmy, wanted to fuck her, had maybe already fucked her, and for sure had fingered her. All behind his back.

But he couldn't bear to have Kimmy think he was angry with her, so he relented, returning to a slower pace, breathing deep, staying connected to her.

Then, out of the blue, her voice soft and sibilant: "I told him to jerk off."

The hair on his neck bristled and his eyes widened with shock. "You what?"

"He wanted to have sex, but I'm not going to do that, so I told him to jerk off. Then I left."

Simple, matter of fact. And astounding.

This very afternoon his wife was in a hotel room with the worst man in the world, one who'd manipulated them both, one who tortured him, had him wearing women's underwear just to get a glimpse of a photo he'd taken of Kimmy's pussy. And yet, they were two married people in bed with each other a few hours later, working together, loving one another and finding ways they could make the best of the awful things that had happened. In the midst of this disgusting revelation, he almost could laugh at the sheer absurdity of it all.

He said, "Do you think he did?"

"I know he did," she said, flat and monotone. Just the facts, ma'am.

"How— Wait, how do you know?"

"I didn't watch him. But I know he did."

"How do you know?"

"I saw him doing it while I dressed."

"You said you didn't watch him."

"I didn't. But I saw him doing it. Heard him. He ejaculated."

Every male cell in his body screamed for him to burst into anger, yet he still couldn't do it. Some other part of him wanted to ignore it, ameliorate her words into something else, something he could stomach. And a big part of him wanted all the dirty details.

Instead of pulling out and telling her once and for all that this kind of life wasn't for him, instead of storming into the closet and packing an overnight bag and heading to Meyer's, instead of throwing table lamps and screaming at the top of his lungs, he asked her, "Did you . . . see him come?"

DARK DESIRES

Josh's heart needed tender care. The hurt radiated from his eyes. Her husband was lost again. He'd folded himself over and over in the sticky dough of his own strange desires. She thumbed the soft skin of his cheekbones, just under his eyes.

"I'll tell you, if you want to know."

Josh struggled against her calm demeanor, challenging it. "That's *why* I asked you."

"I'll tell you, but we have to stop."

Josh looked befuddled for a moment, understanding her words in different facets. Her hands smoothed from his cheeks down to his neck and collar, her fingertips rippling the flesh on his chest. She squirmed away from him and he understood now what she meant. They separated their union, and she sat up, awakened from her sensual reverie and now feeling more naked and vulnerable than before. The sounds of the room swelled louder than their breathing and the beat of her heart. Josh moved aside, and they sat hip to hip at the foot of the bed, very close but not looking at each other.

She said toward the bedding, "I don't want to do that anymore. Our game."

Josh was silent, soaking in what she said. Then he touched her neck, and her eyes moved up to meet his. He said, "I'm sorry I ever introduced it. I'm sorry I ever made you—"

She touched his neck, and her thumb stroked his chin, up to his lip and silencing his untrue words. "Don't," she said. "We're both grown up. We

both know what we're doing. We can't blame things on each other or on the past or..."

"Or on him?"

Her eyes had wandered away, but now she regarded him again. "I'll tell you if you want to know what happened today, but I don't want it to be..." She shrugged a shoulder. "Erotic" was the word she wanted to say, but was afraid it would insult him, denigrate her husband's sexuality. This turned him on, though she didn't understand it. And it turned her on as well. And Devlin, too. And it might be the one thing that could save her marriage. At least, she'd *thought* that at one time. But at the first tingling fear, she'd retreated like a scalded cat. The shame from Josh's discovery—from Josh's wounding at that discovery—had done awful things to her heart. Josh was kind and tender. Josh was love. Devlin was none of those things. Devlin was a stark landscape; barren steppes, rocky crags, and foggy horizons. There would never be love with Devlin Stone. There was no life to be had in Devlin's landscape; it was insupportable.

She said, "We don't have to say anything. You don't have to know, and I don't have to tell you."

Josh's eyes narrowed, his face jutting forward, and his voice tightened. "You don't think I have to know?" Not spoken in anger, but in disbelief. Or maybe something else. Like hope. Like maybe she would understand if her husband didn't want to know. But how could a man not want to know?

She said, "He doesn't want me for who I am, Josh. He doesn't like Kimmy *Waters*."

"He calls you Chang," Josh said in disgust.

"That's who he wants. Like a trophy or something."

"You say he wants to boil me like a frog."

"You know he does."

Josh nodded, his lips slimming. When his chin dipped, and he showed a look of almost pure innocence, she asked him the thing that had frightened her the most: "Has he... Has Devlin talked to you?"

Josh's brow creased, but he didn't look up. He shook his head no. But she didn't know what to believe. He'd mumbled a statement about a shipping yard in Hamilton. She could confront him on what he meant, but she had engaged with Devlin in a shipyard in Hamilton, and a woman who hadn't done what she'd done wouldn't be ignited by such specifics. An

innocent woman would pass it over and stick to the vagaries of her husband's renewed game of dirty talk.

Josh knew she wasn't innocent. He knew it, but he didn't know where. Devlin knew where.

She thumbed Josh's jawline. "He hasn't contacted you?"

Josh shook his head no again. She chewed her cheek, seeking a way to get through to him.

She said, "It's been hard with Devlin, Josh. Really hard. He's a difficult man, and I know the games he plays with me. . . . If he played with them with you..." Her eyes flicked to his, but Josh stayed sullen, somber eyes down-turned.

Then he looked up. "If he's so terrible, why are you there? Why are you *still* there?"

Her face moved closer to his, pleadingly. "You know why, Josh. Maybe you don't believe it anymore, maybe I have to try to convince you again, but I know in my heart"—she jabbed a thumb between her naked breasts—"I'm doing it for you and for me. We can start our lives, jump ahead five, maybe ten years for every one year with Devlin. Don't you want that?"

"It costs so *much*, Kimmy."

"Josh, you need to see it. You need to see it the way I see it."

"How *can* I?" He looked forlorn again, his eyes roaming the room. His penis had deflated to a slick, misshapen bulb between his legs.

She lamented the loss of their innocence. The loss of what they had before the summer. But she had to maintain it. Preserve what was left. There was nothing else for her.

Josh said, "I want you to tell me. I want you to tell me what happened today."

Her features slackened and dread gripped her heart. "Then look at me," she said. But Josh wouldn't, his eyes and the corners of his mouth down-turned.

She didn't want him inside her when she told him. When she did that, allowed him inside her, it was to control him, take advantage of his weakness. But if anything would keep them together, it would be preserving Josh's spirit; his ego.

He licked his lower lip, gathered the strength he needed and looked up at her at last. "Tell me," he said, his voice soft but grave.

She nodded once, and now her toes curled a cliff edge, a high diver with a watching audience; a daredevil who was going to fall from a seventy-five foot ladder into a pool ten feet across and ten feet deep.

Her mind fought this final moment, looking for a way out, thinking again to control Josh, grab that little bulb and work it into a handle, get her husband on his back and get him to utter the terrible things that flitted around in his dark attic. Get his hands as dirty as hers. But she didn't touch him. Didn't reach between his legs to take control of his joystick. She said, "He wants me to be Kimmy Chang. I'm playing a role. I don't want to play that role for him."

"It looks like you do."

"I don't want to do it for *him*, Josh. I don't want to be his toy. His conjured succubus, some summoned demon who appears at his side to strike legal fear in his business partners. I don't want to be used. But that's what Devlin wants from me. Why he hired me. He bought me those clothes so I would look the part. He tricked me by cancelling the meeting, and then he showed me what he wanted."

"He took your clothes off?"

She nodded. "But I... I let him. I want to be what he wants, but I hate being it for him. I'm better than he is, Josh. . . . But Devlin is right. If I'm going to stay there and, Josh, I'm telling you I want to stay there; not for him, but for me and for you"—she cupped his cheek—"I need to do it. . . . But not for him, so I walked away."

Josh's soft eyes flicked over hers, studying her. "Where were you?"

"In the bathroom. You know, in front of the mirror. He wanted me to look at myself, look at what I could be. What I should be."

She didn't want Josh to see the shame she felt, but was too afraid to look away. If she looked away, she might lose him. She implored him: "I need you to understand it has nothing to do with Devlin. It's all me. And it's you I care about."

Josh grimaced and pulled back, his eyes closed. "You told him to jerk off."

She withdrew her hand from his cheek and touched her own face. "He wanted more than that, Josh. He *wants* me."

Josh's cheeks puffed out and his eyes widened. It was like a man winded, but instead of exhausted eyes, Josh's were throbbing with pain.

Another man wanted his wife, and that other man was his bully and that other man had everything Josh didn't.

She said, "I don't want him. Josh, do you think I want him?"

Josh scratched his head, his movements becoming more erratic, jittery, like this was all getting to be too much, and she said to him, "I don't have to tell you, Josh. If you trust me, I don't have to tell you."

Josh looked at her, confused, like a man with no comprehension of how he would trust a woman who'd betrayed him the way he'd only *thought* she did.

He said, "No, Kimmy. You *are* going to tell me. Tell me why Devlin is comfortable taking your clothes off. And why you *let* him do it."

The glimmering ember of anger that flared in his eyes scared her. It brought back all the fear and anxiety that had prompted her scramble to Rome, desperately seeking the man she loved. Sadness squeezed her stomach now, and the cold resolve she'd found today in the hotel room with Devlin crumbled. She could be strong with Devlin, but she couldn't be strong with Josh. She loved him too much. Love and honor were two different things.

A moment ago she'd been a stubborn puzzle piece that refused to sit in place, that resisted the shape meant for her to take. But now she acquiesced, turned what would harm her husband into what would soothe him. Her hand moved to his thigh, and he flinched and held his breath. Right before her eyes, the hair on his arms bristled with goosebumps. Regret washed away the sadness, but it was a more comfortable place to exist. Her fingertips fondled the head of his penis and it responded right away. Josh's breaths returned, but were soft and shaky. His head lolled on his neck and his penis grew with her provocation. She swallowed and bowed her head, feeling his penis harden until she could grip it. Then she whispered, "He told me to undress, and I did."

"How could you do that?" Josh's voice was as faint and weak as hers.

"I didn't want to, but I didn't want to back down. And I want to be myself sometimes, even when who I am is cold and calculating."

Josh's mouth fell open and his cock went to stone. She hoisted a leg over his lap and guided him to lie back, pushing fingers on his chest. Over top of him now, their faces close, one hand on the bed above his head, the

other down low at their crotches, caressing his erection in slow and meaningful strokes.

“I like that, t-too,” he stuttered, his teeth almost chattering like he was cold. His hands came to her sides, smoothing her ribs and headed to her breasts, but she stopped him. “Keep your hands down, Josh. Let me tell you what happened today. Lay your hands on the bed.”

“O-okay,” he said, eyes still closed, maybe afraid who he’d see if he opened them. He lay on his back with his hands down by his thighs, knees bent, feet on the floor. She stroked his cock and watched his face. Seeing how he loved this dreadful treatment soothed the spiky parts of their weld. Made her feel less guilty, made her sins softer and easier to swallow.

“Do you want to hear it, or do you want me to stop?” Her grip slowed right up as she squeezed his cock head.

Josh trembled and sighed, his body shuddering between her knees. “Oh god, ah, p-please, tell me. . . .”

TANGLED PATHS

When Kimmy touched him this way, and when Kimmy told him dirty stories and played along with the things that turned him on, he never felt closer to her. And that was so wrong—so wrong the act came with the heavy weight of shame and guilt. Kimmy was a better human than this. A woman who didn't need the burden of kinky games that turned her husband on. But he loved them. He loved them, and—he could deny it as much as he wanted—Kimmy liked them too. But the way Kimmy liked them was the same way he liked them: cloaked in dark regret and disgrace. He'd asked her, and she'd told him the humiliation turned her on. She fought this like he did. She fought it, but she liked it. Like Devlin sought to boil his frog form, he'd done the same to Kimmy. Degree by degree, turning up the heat until he had his wife playing forbidden games on a private beach in Cayman, cavorting with him and Devlin, staying present for her husband's sake while her boss had disrobed for a skinny dip and to show off to Kimmy how huge his penis was.

Kimmy's grip pulsed on the end of his cock, her eyes watching his squished end point peeking out the end of her slippery fist. "The only thing that makes it okay when I'm like that—when I'm cold—is it's not who I am, Josh. I don't want to be cold. I don't want to be mean. I'm like that to *win*. It's a game, Josh. You make it real. The game's stakes are for you and for me. That's why I like it. Am I making sense?"

"Yes-s, yeah, you are. I know, Kimmy. I know."

She stroked him a few times. "Our home, our apartment, that's who I am. That's who I want to be. When I walk out the door, I get to *play*. You

know? And I'm good at it."

"You are. I know you are."

Her eyes moved to his. "Do you want to hear it?"

"I do."

"Do you understand what it's like for me?"

"I do, Kimmy. I really do. Tell me. Tell me what happened."

Kimmy hesitated for a moment, her attention on her hand again, watching it go up and down her husband's throbbing erection, her grip swirling, adding pleasurable flourishes to her stroking motion. At last, she said, "He proved his point, Devlin did, making me look at myself, making me look in the mirror. I know it sounds crazy to you, crazy that would happen, but maybe that's what had to happen. I figured it out. I've been lost, and when you went to Rome, I thought . . . I couldn't stand you being away like that. . . . I don't think I saw in the mirror what Devlin wanted me to see. But I know what I'm doing now."

His stomach bowed in and out as an enormous pressure built inside him, inflated by his wife's awful ministration. His whole body trembled, and he hated how pleasure reveled in this awful revelation of how his wife behaved with her boss when her husband wasn't around. And he followed the path of today's event between Kimmy and Devlin all the way to Cayman—where the path began.

He said, "You were naked. Naked in front of him."

Kimmy's eyes returned to his. "Totally naked, Josh. Devlin was dressed. Okay?"

"Y-yeah."

"He wants me, Josh. He wants me really bad."

"Oh, fuck, yes, you're so hot, so amazing."

Kimmy watched her hand again, down low between them, his cock pointing up to their faces. "This makes you so hard."

"So hard, Kimmy. . . . I hate it."

"Don't, Josh. Don't say that. You love it, and that's fine. . . . I don't want you to want it, Josh, but I can't make you stop."

Yes, this was all him, all his fault. His indecent fantasies had set them on this tortuous route that led to his wife's panties in Devlin's couch, to Devlin undressing his wife and then . . . And then? "You're torturing me. Tell me what happened."

“He wanted me in his bed, so I told him to jerk off instead and I walked out.

“And he did?”

“I didn’t know if he would or not, but, yes, he did. He jerked off in the bathroom.”

His leg muscles tightened to cables, and he twisted underneath his seductive wife. “While you were there?”

“I was in the bedroom, I was getting dressed. But the door was open, and yes, I saw him jerking off.”

“You saw him hard?”

A beat of hesitation, then: “I did, Josh.”

“Fuck,” he hissed, and though she’d told him to keep his hands at his sides, he palmed his face and growled, rage swimming behind his eyes but held in check by his wife’s stroking grip.

Into his hands, he groaned, “This wasn’t the first time. The first time you’ve seen him hard.”

Kimmy kept her grip on his cock but pried his hands away with her free hand. She looked into his eyes, then shook her head no. “Devlin loves to show that thing to anyone who might want to look. He showed it to us on the beach in Cayman.”

Josh whispered, “He wasn’t hard.”

“I’ve seen it hard, Josh. I’m sorry, but I have seen his dick get hard before.”

Bright flashes of times when Kimmy might have been alone with Devlin flickered behind his eyes. Brief passionate moments where Devlin seduced his wife, tempting her with the best things a man could offer, and gifted with all the physical tools that a woman desired. The body, the looks, the money, the endowment; all things that drove women crazy, including his wife—his fine and glorious wife, who seemed so above such debasing desire. He pictured her office when everyone else had gone home, pictured hotel rooms with canceled meetings, pictured Devlin’s apartment, only a short drive from the office and equipped with all the amenities for dick revealing and deep, deep fucking. Kimmy alone and separate from her husband, living a different life, a glamorous one. All with a hyper-sexual macho degenerate who wanted to fuck her. And who wanted her husband to know he was fucking her.

His eyes locked with Kimmy's, inches apart, his body prostate and subordinate below her. She stroked his cock and told him all the things he fantasized he might hear. But this time it was real and true. Their gazes remained locked and her hand continued to deliver pleasure. Much was beamed back and forth between them, two people seeking understanding, looking for a way to settle this difficulty between them without having to utter the horrible words that crushed his heart yet made his dick as hard as steel. Kimmy knew the difficult dance she had to perform for her husband and he loved her for wanting to do it.

Voice soft and caring, she said, "It's okay, Josh. It's okay. It doesn't mean anything. You understand that, right? You know you're everything."

"Kiss me," he said. "Please, Kimmy, kiss me."

Her mouth came to his and her soft lips closed against his. When she pulled back, she said, "Put your hands down again."

His hands had remained at his neck, like he was protecting himself. He moved them down to his sides again, vulnerable and naked to the true things Kimmy told him.

"Keep them there," she said, working his cock, eyes boring into his.

He said, "Do you like it?"

Kimmy said nothing for a while, knowing he'd meant Devlin's penis, but answering his question with, "You know I don't like him, Josh."

"Do you like it? Like it when he shows it to you?"

She frowned and looked away. "I don't like to be manipulated. When he does that, it's..."

"You know what I'm asking you, Kimmy. Tell me the truth. Do you like it? Do you like how big he is?"

Her eyes met his again, and he knew what her answer was in the heartbeat before she said it. "I do. I like it."

His voice rose high, as if in disbelief, even though he'd wanted this answer. "You do?"

"I can't help it. Just like you can't help this"—she squeezed his dick, indicating how hard he was—"I can't help what happens to me."

"What happens to you?"

"I get aroused, Josh. The same way you do."

His head rocked back on the mattress like a man in anguish, but the hurt in his heart wasn't unwelcome. It was cathartic. He hated to think these

things were true, but deep down, he'd always known they were. Now that it was confirmed, and Kimmy had shared such strange intimacy with another man, he had the proof that his fantasy had sunk deeper into dark waters. And yet that's where he'd always wanted it to be.

And if there was ever a time he could accept the answer to his forbidden question, that time would be now. He summoned the courage to ask, and with great effort, he said, "Has he ever touched you?"

Kimmy's expression shrank, but her brow lowered. "What do you mean?"

He scaled back the question, not liking the dark fire that flared in Kimmy's eyes. "He's shown you. Have you shown him?"

Kimmy's hand stilled. Her posture slumped.

He encouraged her to not give up, his hand moving to her wrist, guiding her hand to keep moving. "It's okay. It's okay, Kimmy. Don't stop, keep going—but *tell* me."

"*Why* do you want to know?"

"How can I *not* know?"

"You already know, Josh. You showed me. Showed me the proof."

"Your panties?"

She nodded, sad eyes averted from his, and he hated the direction this release had taken. He didn't like this at all. "He did. He's seen you. You showed him. It's okay, Kimmy." And wasn't it? *Wasn't it okay?* For fuck sake, he'd played games with his own sexuality, exploring the terrible things that turned him on, engaging his wife in it, brought her into his mire, and meanwhile, she's getting turned on, too. Getting turned on by Devlin Stone's big dick and asshole demeanor.

But she's here in bed telling you about her devotion. Telling you that you're the one that matters. And, hey, how about this: If you accept Kimmy's love and if you accept her transgression, Devlin has no power. It brings you closer together with Kimmy. When you're mad and you're in Rome and you don't want to see her, you're giving Devlin all the strength. All the power. You're giving him a victory.

But if he saw you getting this dirty-talk hand job in bed with Devlin's sexy Kimmy Chang, he'd shit a brick. Josh Waters is the winner here, isn't he?

“It’s okay, Kimmy,” he told her again. *Even if you let him finger you—and I know he did.* “Keep going. Tell me what happened today. Don’t stop. Please, don’t stop.”

Her expression changed. Her eyes returned to his, back to business. “Touch me,” she said. “Put your hands on me.”

His hands went to her sides, and he loved how his touch brought Kimmy’s eyes closed, showing how she loved his hands on her, how he connected with her. He wished they could be honest and intimate, instead of honest and dirty. Honest and *kinky*. He wanted to make love to her again, be inside her while she told him how she told Devlin to jerk off and Devlin jerked off right in front of her. Devlin must have thought he would dominate her that way, and yet Kimmy ignored him. Turned her back on him. Got dressed and let him masturbate.

“He sat on the tub edge while I got dressed in the clothes he bought me, and he had his dick out and he was masturbating.”

“You saw him come?” *Oh, how fucking horrible.*

“Kind of, not really. But, yeah, I guess I did. He came all over the bathroom floor.”

“Oh fuck, oh fuck, are you kidding me?” *What the fuck was going on? Devlin Stone fucking jerked off in front of your wife and you’re okay with it?* No. Not okay. But something else. Something crazy. . . .

CONFIRMATION

Kimmy closed her eyes. “No, Josh, he came all over the floor.” He feared she pictured it in her mind now, some bad part of his wife liking how another man had ejaculated at her request.

“You saw it? You saw his come?”

Kimmy looked down at his cock, biting her lower lip, squeezing him tight. “Yeah.”

Yeah? Fucking yeah? You saw another man ejaculate? “Aw, fuck, Kimmy, what the fuck?” He thrust his head back into the mattress again, raising his hips up and pushing his cock through Kimmy’s exquisite grip.

“I don’t care, Josh. I don’t care about Devlin’s come. It’s an act of male dominance. Devlin came on the floor because he wants me to know I’m on his territory. I’m in his dominion.”

“Oh fuck, slow, slow, Kimmy,” he gasped, putting a hand on her wrist to slow her stroke. “What are you saying?”

“I showed him my back, Josh. I got dressed.”

He let go of her wrist and Kimmy resumed pleasuring him. “And what did he do?”

“Came up behind me. Brought his sovereign closer because I don’t bend to him.”

His eyes narrowed to hurting slits, his temples throbbing. “Are you serious? This happened? You really . . . Are you in some mind game with him?”

“That’s how Devlin is, Josh. But I don’t get bullied. I don’t bend.”

The statement came in a sudden punch and he grunted as if hit. Josh Waters let Devlin bully him, and his wife had, too. For a time. But not anymore. Was there a time Josh Waters could live his life without a man like Devlin striking fear in him? A time where Josh Waters might not be under the heel of a man like that?

Kimmy slowed, her body writhing above his, like this turned her on just as much as it turned him on. It wasn't thoughts of Devlin that made Kimmy's hips hump—though Devlin might be a part of it, he was sure that this act of dominance over her husband was what turned her on, what aroused her. She'd told him she got off on his humiliation. That time at the tailor when she'd espoused the knowledge of which side Devlin Stone liked to tuck his huge penis: she'd done that for Josh, part of their game. But what if he was a bystander, and Kimmy had done that for herself? Done it because it turned *her* on?

It was his greatest erotic fear realized, brought to vivid undeniable life right before him. All the things he fantasized to be true coming true right before his eyes. His powerful wife coming home in the clothes another man bought for her, putting her husband on his back and stroking his cock while telling him how she'd got the best of another man during the day, the two of them in some bizarre sexual encounter deep in the heart of the city, a world away from her suburban milquetoast husband.

And the fear and the humiliation aroused her milquetoast husband like no other thing could. His whole body stiffened and his stomach went to steel. The pressure built low in his belly and every slight, slick movement of Kimmy's grip brought his orgasm a thousand miles closer.

Kimmy still humped the air, her hips rolling in circles, still on her knees and over him like a panther on prey. She pushed the belly of his cock against the hot skin of her naked thigh, rubbing her skin against it. Her face came closer to his, and she lowered her stomach to his cock, swished it across her skin there, too. There was an undeniable fear present in his heart. Kimmy's strength showed like he'd never seen it before. It had always flirted close to the surface, but now it shimmered on her skin. She'd said she would protect him and he believed her now.

Quieter, more sultry, she said, "He put that huge penis against me."

He seized up, surprised and wowed, not even believing he was hearing this. These were words of fantasy, but now they were words of document.

He jolted and began to writhe even more than Kimmy.. And Kimmy smiled—she knew her husband wanted to hear this. Kimmy’s smile intimidated him. How could this be the same woman who followed him to Rome and cried in his lap?

“Standing behind me,” she continued, “he let it hang against my thigh.”

“Oh, Kimmy,” he groaned, “Oh, my god.” The hands down at his sides moved outward, curling the flesh of his wife’s long, skinny legs, caressing the place where Devlin had introduced the touch of his impressive manhood. Was it her left leg or her right leg?

The pace of her stroke quickened, and she whispered, “His come leaked on my skin. It dribbled down my leg.”

It was too much to bear. His hips rose again, and his cock surged in his wife’s hand. He grunted and exhaled until pinpricks of light swam behind his closed eyes. His balls rolled backwards into his body, and he ejaculated. The release was enormous, a huge cottony explosion in his skull. Kimmy’s grip went slick with the wild deluge of his eruption. His come pattered his stomach, then his chest, even up to his neck and cheek. He emitted a long and tortured howl as his seams ripped apart with the orgasm’s thundering release.

Kimmy continued to milk and stroke his manhood as he writhed on the bed until at last he had to still her hand before the tickling pleasure became too much to endure. She’d left him blown away and bewildered.

In the aftermath of release, though, her confession closed in around him with an oppressive gloom. What he’d thought to be true was proved true. Devlin and Kimmy were close. Closer than he could have imagined. Close enough that what happened today didn’t seem too much to either of them. Kimmy didn’t shrink and recoil from his undressing. She didn’t shriek and recoil when Devlin let his come-dripping organ dangle against her leg.

Kimmy prowled away from him, off his body to the spot beside him, where she lay flat on her stomach, her right hand held out and away, shining with his pearly eruption. He lay on his back looking at the ceiling, trying to interpret his place in the marriage now after this revelation.

He didn’t even know what to make of the revelation. He would have thought he would be angrier. But his frog had been boiled so slowly that what Kimmy had just told him seemed to be sensible. How could it not be true? This was the game you’d played. Kimmy lay silent beside him,

stretched out, long legs and pert bottom, higher than him on the bed, her feet dangling off the bottom, her thigh beside his face. Maybe the thigh where Devlin had let hang his heavy, dripping meat.

His arm went over the backs of her legs, just above her knee, his fingers stroking the skin. He kissed her naked hip.

She said, "That's the leg. But lower."

He frowned, not knowing if she'd meant where his fingers stroked or where he'd placed his lips. Then felt ashamed that she knew his perverted brain had him seeking out the section of skin where another man had tempted his wife with his huge penis. He sat up on one hip and admired her beauty for a moment, Kimmy with her head facing his direction, but her eyes staring at nothing across the room, one hand under her chin, the other held out with his seed covering it. He retreated to the bathroom and got a towel, dried his chest and stomach and his face, then brought another one for Kimmy, coming to her other side and wrapping the towel around her dirtied hand. He cleaned her, getting between her fingers and down her wrist before tossing the towel toward the bathroom. Kimmy still lay silent and naked, her face hidden from him, his shadow crossing her slender back.

His hand passed over her bare buttocks and caressed the far side thigh, just below where he'd kissed her. Kimmy allowed it, remaining passive, still staring across the room, knowing her husband wanted to touch the spot where Devlin had been. She wouldn't know why, but neither did he. What might she tell herself about kind Josh Waters, the upstanding young man she'd married?

Her wedding ring hand moved down to take his and guide it lower, guide it to where Devlin's cock had touched her. It gave him licentious approval, and from where she let his hand go, he stroked lower, to the side of her knee, to where Devlin's semen might have dribbled.

Kimmy had reached out to him today. She'd told him some awful things. But there were more important statements made. She doesn't like Devlin Stone. She's better than him. Josh Waters is all she cares about. This apartment she shared with him was her home. It was the place where the real Kimmy resided. That statuesque and frightening lawyer she became when she donned the costume and the face paint and headed into the city was something she did for the success of their marriage and the life they'd plotted for themselves. He detected no lies in her statement. She'd been

adamant. And as much as her presence in Rome had driven a stake through his heart, he couldn't imagine how lost he would feel right now if she'd never come to him. Never come to his hotel room and begged his forgiveness without ever uttering the direct words. She'd been unfaithful. Kimmy and Devlin had got close, and Kimmy had been prompted by her husband's desire.

He said, "Do you blame me?"

Kimmy didn't react right away, didn't jump up and assuage any guilt he might have. But she slowly raised her head, then turned to her side, looking over her shoulder at him. She looked innocent and resigned. This was the way their life was now.

"Not one bit, Josh."

"Are you sure?"

Her head cocked to one side. "I love you."

He exhaled, and his shoulders fell forward. It was an absolution he hadn't known he needed. And then, as if Kimmy's indiscretion had been only a mild thing, he said, "You're not going to leave me for him?" It was a boyish, comical thing to say, something to lighten the mood even. But he did want to know her answer. He wished he had a maturer way of asking.

Kimmy reached to take his hand, and he offered it. She wove her fingers through his and he lowered himself to lie at her side. The sun had lowered and lit the bedroom in an otherworldly orange, like they had an apartment on a distant planet somewhere.

Without the nerve to say it to her face, he said toward their orange-painted ceiling, "I wish I wasn't this way."

"You?"

"You know what I mean."

She said, "You can't help who you are. Nor can I. I don't want you to apologize for being you. I married you because I loved you and this is who you are."

He didn't even deserve her. Didn't deserve this blameless treatment. She should defend herself with greater weapons, poke at him and say how he started it, how he put her in the place where all this bad could happen. "So, where does this put us?"

Kimmy squeezed his hand, spoke to the ceiling the same way he did. "I think we're in a lot of trouble."

Her words chilled him. They'd been in a quiet and caring moment, but her words were grave and frightening. "We are?"

She brought his hand to her chest, not letting go of him, bringing him closer. "We're together, Josh, and I'm not letting you go. But we're in trouble."

His head rolled so he could face her profile. "What do you mean?"

Her head rolled so she faced him. "If we stick together, maybe we can get through it."

SLEEPOVER 3

Kimmy scrunched up her nose, trying to recall her own first sleepover. Sophie waited. “I don’t remember whose house it was, Soph. Maybe my friend Karina.” Then to Hyun, “You’ve met Karina, right?” Hyun called out from the kitchen that she had, and Kimmy said to Sophie, “Karina was my best friend when I was little. Yeah, it *must* have been Karina’s house.”

Sophie would spend her first night away from Hyun’s or from Meyer’s tonight; a big step in any little girl’s life. But at six, Sophie wasn’t too young, and she’d been shuffled from house to house since Hyun and Meyer divorced. Tomorrow was a P.D. day and Sophie was off school. Sophie planned to spend the day tomorrow at her friend Chloe’s house. Hyun said Chloe’s parents had an arcade and an indoor pool.

“You’re going to have a lot of fun at Chloe’s. You can play games, maybe stay up later and watch a movie...”

“Not *too* late,” Hyun said from the kitchen, “and only if Chloe’s parents say you can.”

Kimmy raised her eyebrows and made funny faces at Sophie until Sophie started laughing. They were sitting on the couch in Hyun’s family room, Hyun cleaning up in the kitchen after making bibimbap for dinner. Sophie was clean and dressed for her first night out, and Kimmy marvelled at her niece’s pure and perfect face. Happy, unblemished; faultless. She wanted to snatch up Sophie and squeeze her or maybe tickle her until she burst into terrorized giggles, but didn’t want to be selfish or weird, so she only tweaked Sophie’s earlobe. Sophie scooted closer, looking for affection,

and Kimmy slipped her arms around her. Sophie turned, backing against Aunt Kimmy's side and snuggling into her. Hyun turned the corner from the kitchen, coming to join them, and stopped in her tracks at the sight of her adorable daughter snuggled against her former sister-in-law. Kimmy kissed the top of Sophie's head. Hyun shone with warm affinity, then asked Sophie if she was all packed and ready to go. "Mr. Wu's going to be here in about five minutes."

"I'm all packed, Mommy," Sophie said.

Hyun crossed the room and sat on the couch beside Kimmy, Sophie in between them.

It was a strange and familial feeling that Kimmy didn't know she'd needed until just the last few moments. The day had been surreal and staggering, and there was nowhere else for her to find comfort after a day like this one. She said, "Maybe you'll take me with you to your sleepover." Sophie giggled and looked at Hyun as if it were a possibility. Kimmy said, "No, it's your night tonight, Sophie. But the three of us will have to make a plan for a night of fun sometime soon."

Hyun agreed, and Sophie did, too, reciting now a hopeful ream of possible activities the three of them could do on this imaginary night sometime in the near future. Hyun was a good mother. An admirable one. Though she didn't make much money and lived in this small apartment, Sophie always presented herself well. Sophie had wonderful manners, an intellectual curiosity, and a sweet disposition. But most of all, Sophie was this shimmering beacon of possibility; a human being with potential, nurtured and nourished with love and duty. And, while a distinct individual with her own genetic programming, Sophie was a reflection of her mother's spiritual intent, like an emissary set forth to do good in the world in her mother's name. The thought brought a heavenly and golden weight onto her heart; but that added burden pushed discomfort low in her chest, where that light couldn't shine bright enough to make a difference.

Hyun's phone chimed with an incoming text, and she tilted the screen to read it. "Mr. Wu's here now, Sophie," she sang. "We'll go down and meet him."

At first she'd thought to stay in the apartment while Hyun and Soph went down to the lobby for the official handover, but then changed her mind and went along. Better to be vigilant and scrutinizing than trusting. Mr. Wu was a Hong Kong hotshot with sunglasses and a spotless Mercedes GLS in diamond white. As the three women emerged from the lobby into the early evening sunlight, Mr. Wu's demeanor changed, and now he looked like a family man, showing an honest smile at Sophie waving to him. Sophie trotted to him in greeting and he cupped a hand on her head—then performed a double take, averting his smoky-lens gaze to Kimmy. The smile faltered, but not toward unhappiness; near more to incomprehension. It gave her a funny feeling. Like maybe Mr. Wu had suspicions of the young and attractive Hyun's sexual preferences now that she was divorced. And Kimmy was a confirmation to the man. He removed his sunglasses and nodded in greeting, mouthing a silent hello. Hyun looked aside at Kimmy and said to Mr. Wu, "Oh, this is my sister-in-law," muttering in sheepish correction, "*Former* sister-in-law."

Sophie clarified: "She's my Aunt Kimmy, and she wants to come over tonight with me and Chloe."

All the adults shared polite chuckles, and Mr. Wu patted Sophie's head again. Kimmy said, "Hyun and I are good friends."

Mr. Wu's eyes appraised her, eyes going up and down, nodding. She'd changed after coming home from work, out of her suit and into peg slacks and a light sweater and canvas slip-ons. He said, "I'm on my way home from work, but April said Chloe's dying for Sophie to get there—she's been talking non-stop since she got home from school." Then, as a better explanation, said in a lower tone, more conspiratorial: "We just got an ice cream maker, and Chloe's been waiting for this weekend to show you."

Sophie already knew all about the ice cream maker and had even told Kimmy. Hyun stooped down and spoke to Sophie, reminding Sophie of all the rules and of being obedient and respecting Mr. and Mrs. Wu, all in front of Mr. Wu, like some sort of protocol so all parties engaged could rely on the other for understanding the rules. Then Mr. Wu put Sophie into the car seat, made sure she was safe, then waved as he got into his SUV. Kimmy and Hyun stayed to watch Sophie go, Sophie making happy faces and waving at them from the back seat as Mr. Wu drove out to the road from the apartment complex.

Hyun said, "They just live over in Riverside, not too far."

"Nice of him to pick Sophie up."

"They're a really great couple."

"Just the one daughter?"

Hyun nodded, then they stood around for a moment, enjoying the still and warm night, the smells of autumn coming in on them, summer fading away from the landscape. Hyun said, "Where do you want to go tonight?"

Kimmy sighed. "I was kind of hoping we could stay in and talk."

Kimmy waved off a glass of wine and chose a strawberry Bubly instead. She watched Hyun take a few sips of wine, waiting for her to figure Kimmy's abstinence out. And she did.

The two of them alone in the apartment now, both of them on the couch with the room getting dimmer as the sun set. Hyun's brow lowered, and she set her wine glass down on the coffee table, then looked plainly at Kimmy without saying anything. Kimmy said nothing either, only raised her eyebrows.

Hyun said, "Are you . . .?"

Kimmy nodded, her mouth a slim line. "I am."

Hyun covered her smile, trying to contain the abounding enthusiasm until all was confirmed as good. Kimmy chuckled and rubbed her brow, leaning her head to one side. "I went to the doctor today. And, uh, yeah. Yes."

Hyun made a small, quiet exclamation of happiness, looking up to the ceiling, then facing Kimmy again. "Are you serious? How far along?"

Kimmy squinted, and despite the weight of the news, even smiled. "Maybe eleven weeks. Ten maybe."

Hyun's features went through a range of emotions as she sought the right way to react and the right thing to say. The miscarriage in the spring put wrinkles in what should be a smooth event. Voice very quiet, she said, "You must be so happy."

Still smiling, she shrugged. "I'm not sure how I feel yet. It's pretty sudden news. I did a home test on Monday and went to the doctor today."

Hyun frowned. “You guys weren’t trying?”

She said, “I was on birth control.”

Hyun’s frown deepened. “What? Then how...”

“Oh, I only started the birth control ten weeks ago.”

“Oh, okay. You started because...”

She took a drink of the strawberry sparkling water Hyun had poured into a glass with ice for her. The answer didn’t come easy to her. Everything since the spring had been this weird blur. Lawyer, pregnant, not pregnant, not a lawyer, depressed, hormonal. Wanted to try again; didn’t want to try again. Lawyer again. Lawyer in a way she hadn’t even dreamed of since law school. She closed her eyes and shook her head, lamenting, “I think my hormones are crazy.”

Hyun chuckled, constraining a smile that wanted to grow bigger—but she still didn’t have the confirmation this was good news yet. And it was good news. She wanted it to be. Knew it was, but still...

Hyun said, “Ten weeks is a tough time. Sometimes it got so bad I thought I was going crazy. That’s how I found out I was pregnant with Sophie.”

At the mention of Sophie’s name she put her hand on Hyun’s knee and smiled enough Hyun felt comfortable about the news. They shared a long moment, saying nothing, Hyun with her hand over Kimmy’s, both of them smiling and staring off.

Kimmy retracted her hand, but brought Hyun’s along with it, pivoting in the seat to face Hyun, bringing a folded leg up onto the couch and resting their joined hands on her calf. Hyun stared at her, waiting. She said, “I had a lot of fun that night we did karaoke.”

“I did, too.”

“And I really like spending time with you.”

Hyun smiled. “Me, too.”

Kimmy averted her eyes, looking down, unsure how to say this—or if she even should. “I feel like that night you wanted to say something more.”

Hyun put on a manufactured look of incomprehension, furrowing her brow, and pursing her lips. “Like what?”

The look on Hyun’s face bruised her heart, and she lost the nerve to bring up what she’d expected. Hyun was too clean and innocent to tarnish. Even though at one moment she’d considered doing just that. She’d

considered leveraging Hyun against Josh. There was no denying she'd played with the idea. And more. She'd even considered bringing Hyun into a threesome with Devlin. How the fuck had such a nefarious scheme bloomed in her mind?

She stroked her palm on the back of Hyun's hand. "I don't know what I'm talking about. I just mean... I like your friendship. Value it. I like being close with you. And when..." She sighed and wanted to stop.

Hyun urged her with, "Go on."

"When you slept over... I liked being close with you. I want... I *need* a friend right now." She rolled her eyes up and then chuckled at how this had her so flummoxed. She'd known she would broach the subject and in her mind, it seemed a straightforward thing to do. She wanted Hyun's affection but didn't want to injure Hyun's relationship with her; didn't want to lead her on. "Would you . . . hug me?"

Hyun looked at her like she was crazy, then folded her into an embrace. It felt so good to be in Hyun's arms, to feel cherished or appreciated; and with no male obligation. They both chuckled, and Hyun held her tighter.

When Kimmy pulled back, she had to wipe wet from her eyes. Hyun reached to a side table and plucked a tissue from a cardboard box. Kimmy thanked her, sniffing and wiping. Hyun studied her, trying to understand what was going on. Kimmy crumpled the tissue and held it in a loose fist on her lap, working her mouth around, slumping into the couch. She put a hand over her flat belly. "The doctor said I'm ten weeks along, give or take. If it's eleven weeks, I'm happy. If it's ten weeks, I'm happy." She wanted to face Hyun, but couldn't. "But if it's nine weeks . . . it could be from another man."

FRICTION

Hyun's reaction was hard to decipher. A tremulous fluttering of her brow, crinkling for a fraction of a second in troubled folds; her lips twitched and her face jutted closer. For a fleeting moment, Kimmy thought the revelation angered Hyun, but then an expression of confusion solidified. "What do you mean?"

And now, wary she'd miscalculated Hyun's surety, she pandered a heartfelt clarification: "It's not how it sounds."

Hyun's confusion became bewilderment, and the question forming on her lips dissolved. Her eyes darted as she sought an explanation without being told—none came.

Kimmy said, "It's a lot to explain," and ran fingers through her hair.

"But how could it not be Josh's?"

Kimmy sighed and averted her eyes. "It's been a strange summer."

Hyun rubbed her knee, looking away and lost in thought for a moment. Then she said, "It was weird when Josh came home that night. Was he mad?"

"Like I said, it's been a strange summer. I don't even know how to explain it."

Hyun was more eager now, ready to become involved. "You can tell me."

Kimmy rubbed the back of her neck, then looked Hyun in the eye. "I need someone I can talk to."

"You can talk to me," Hyun said with earnest zeal.

Kimmy looked down, shaking her head, gathering the courage to take this risky step forward. Hyun waited. Kimmy said, “Nine weeks ago...” Then she faltered, not sure of the best way to begin. “Josh already knows this.”

“That your baby might not be—”

“No-no-no,” Kimmy interrupted, taking a light hold of Hyun’s wrist. “I haven’t even told Josh yet.”

“Haven’t told him you’re pregnant?”

Kimmy pursed her lips and met Hyun’s gaze. “You’re the first person I’ve told. I only went to the doctor today.”

“Really?”

“Josh isn’t expecting me to be pregnant. This is going to be a surprise for him.”

The crease in Hyun’s brow hadn’t left. “But he’s going to be happy?”

“Of course,” Kimmy said. “Of course he’ll be happy.”

In the silence after this confirmation, the admission of her baby’s unconfirmed providence loomed large. The silence was filled with Hyun’s obvious but unspoken question: *Even if the baby isn’t his?* Kimmy said, “It’s his. It has to be.”

Hyun’s features softened to a more compassionate mask. She said, “I’m sure it is. But... but who’s this other man?”

She wasn’t sure how to answer. The thought of saying the man’s name disgusted her. She imagined hearing her voice saying Devlin Stone’s name out loud, and it turned her stomach. She thought of answering by saying it was her boss, but that was worse. That came with the connotation that her infidelity may have come from the impetus of career improvement, or worse, that her boss had manipulated her via an exchange of power. That was worse because it made her look weak. At last, she said, “A guy Josh and I know from high school.” Heat flared on her brow and cheeks. That sounded worse. *High school*. How immature. How juvenile. There was no way this spectacle of bad behavior could be spun to gold. No way for her bad behavior to shine in a bath of flattering light. The realization hardened some knot in her heart.

Hyun said in a soft voice, “Your boss?”

Kimmy’s corrective response was quick. “Before he was my boss.” And that meant Hyun would think Kimmy’s offered invitation inside her body

garnered her lucrative employment. She groaned and rubbed her brow. “There was a... we—Josh and I—went to a high school reunion in July.”

“I remember.” And, seeing how hard this retelling came for Kimmy, Hyun reached to hold Kimmy’s shoulder, her thumb stroking lightly.

Kimmy paused, as if for dramatic effect, but she was staggered by the enormity of this revelation, growing huger in scale before her. Now, no matter what happened, the time before this conversation couldn’t be recovered. There was no going back. This would change everything forever. “I’m trusting you,” she said, her tone serious and grave, not an act, but a recognition of reality.

Again, Hyun showed that earnestness, that desire to connect. “Of course,” she said, sincere.

After a moment of consideration, Kimmy said, “I need someone to hear me. You know?” Hyun said she did, and Kimmy continued, saying, “Everything is fine between Josh and I. Yes, maybe things got a little weird between us—like when he came home that night you were sleeping over—but we’re fine. . . . If I try to explain this, you’re going to think it’s crazy, so I don’t even know where to start.”

“You can take your time.”

Kimmy looked aside, contemplating, then she said, “Josh and I have, like, fantasies or whatever. You know, we play around with each other; mind games.” Hyun watched and waited, not interrupting. “I hope you don’t think it sounds wrong. Or immoral.”

Hyun didn’t answer right away, but when Kimmy was silent, Hyun said, “I don’t know what you’re saying yet.”

“Okay. It’s like this: nine weeks ago, I was *with* this other guy in a way that makes me worried.”

“You slept with him?”

Kimmy shook her head. “No, it’s a...” She palmed her forehead and sighed. “It’s a stupid long shot, but I can’t get it out of my mind.”

Hyun seemed exasperated by the stalling and presented a new direction. “How can your boss be the . . .?”

“He’s not my boss.”

“But I thought . . . Isn’t he?”

“I suppose. I don’t see him that way. I’m . . . I’m more important than he is. His *father* owns the company.”

Hyun lowered her eyes, thinking, saying, “Oh,” eyelashes fluttering.

None of this was going as easy as she’d imagined. Hyun’s reaction exposed a personal weakness; a shallowness that she knew existed but thought would be easier to conceal. Referring to Devlin as less-than-her showed vanity. Showed it in a way that Hyun didn’t concede—her claim had been unconvincing. And Hyun saw an aspect Kimmy didn’t want her to see. It seemed more important to show Hyun that Devlin didn’t dominate her, that she didn’t submit to Devlin. But it would be *better* to present it that way. Better for her perceived innocence to be portrayed as a woman subjugated by a powerful man—a time-honored tradition—than one who led her own path of dishonor. “Devlin’s my boss. He is. I don’t want you to think he took advantage of me. That’s all.” Hyun nodded and Kimmy continued. “Devlin and I almost had a thing in high school.”

“Okay,” Hyun said with easy patience, letting Kimmy roll now.

The plain truth now. “Josh likes it when I flirt with Devlin.”

“Why?”

She shrugged. She didn’t even know why, she could only guess. “I don’t think Josh even knows why. He just likes it.”

“So you flirted with your boss?”

Kimmy couldn’t meet Hyun’s eyes, looking away and saying. “More than that. We . . . rolled around, we, uh, we weren’t wearing clothes.”

Hyun shook her head in disbelief.

“I know. I can’t believe I did it either. But I did. And Devlin was, you know . . . *aroused*.”

“And Josh knows?”

“Josh likes that.”

Hyun scratched her head and narrowed her eyes, struggling to comprehend what Kimmy was telling her.

Kimmy said, “I know it’s crazy.”

“No,” Hyun said, slow and draggy, more to say but unsure if she should say it. Then: “I mean . . . Meyer liked to play games, too. It’s just...”

“You don’t have to tell me.”

“No, I’m not going to. It’s Meyer’s business. But I guess I understand.”

Kimmy sighed, then said, “I’m glad. It’s so much to dump on you—”

“I don’t mind,” Hyun said, brightening. “You can tell me whatever you want to tell me. I’ll listen to you.”

Kimmy cocked her head and showed a weak smile. “That’s all I want. I need someone to hear me.”

Hyun smiled at last, and the skies opened. Kimmy smiled as well, then shook her head at the insanity of it all. “There’s not a chance it isn’t Josh’s, but I can’t stop thinking of that time when...” She didn’t know how to phrase it.

“Did Devlin, you know, uh . . . did he finish?” Hyun’s eyes darted to Kimmy’s crotch, not wanting to say a vulgar thing out loud.

“No,” Kimmy said. “No, he didn’t...” She didn’t want to say this next part, but she had to for Hyun to understand why she might be worried. “He put his thing inside me.”

Hyun’s eyes widened, and, though her lips stayed closed, her jaw dropped.

Kimmy also widened her eyes, admitting how insane it was. “Yeah. I can’t even believe it, but...”

“And Josh *likes* that?”

This was something she wouldn’t be able to answer honestly, so she said nothing, only pursing her lips and looking aside. “So, yeah, Devlin didn’t finish, like we didn’t have sex or anything, other than...”

“He put it inside you.”

“Right. And . . . and...”

Hyun waited, face innocent, but Kimmy felt funny saying what she wanted to say. “Oh,” she chuckled and let it go. “Never mind.”

“No, Kimmy, tell me,” Hyun said, and touched her wrist again.

“Devlin’s thing is . . . it’s like, uh . . . huge.”

Hyun’s reaction to this salacious detail was unexpected. If she’d grimaced or even gagged at this disgusting revelation, she wouldn’t have blamed her. But Hyun giggled, then clamped a hand over her mouth, her eyes showing the embarrassment at such a response.

Kimmy let her know it was okay by joining in, laughing too, but still trying to be serious. “Sorry. I had to say it. . . . It’s important. You know? Like, it was way inside me, if you know what I mean. And I know he didn’t . . . uh, *ejaculate*. But, like, what if it was, you know...”

Hyun said, “Like, leaking?”

Kimmy nodded. “Right? Like it was...” She didn’t know how to best reinforce the message she was conveying. She tugged up the loose sleeve of

her light sweater to reveal her skinny forearm, holding up a fist and showing Hyun, gripping her other hand down at her elbow. “It’s, like, *this* big.”

Josh watched Hyun’s apartment window from the Qashqai, parked at the end of the visitor’s lot, backed in so his windshield faced the building. Kimmy ran into Hyun at the grocery store, she’d told him. Girl’s night out. Dinner with Hyun and Sophie. Sure. Okay. Yeah, maybe.

But it could be bull shit, too.

It could be total bull shit.

She ran into Hyun at the grocery store and arranged a night she could borrow Hyun’s apartment. *I just need it for an hour. I’ll pay you five hundred if you take Sophie out for a movie. Call before you guys get back.*

Kimmy could be up there right now fucking Devlin Stone. Laid out in Hyun’s bed, taking Devlin’s monster cock. Kimmy was probably addicted to it. She could hate Devlin as much as she wanted, but her husband could *still* picture her with her legs spread for the man. *Just fuck me, then shut up and leave.* That was what the new Kimmy was like. Crazy as the scenario was, he could picture it clearly and didn’t think it was ridiculous.

Or maybe it was worse. Maybe Kimmy told her what an incredible fuck Devlin was, how rich he was, how hung he was. Maybe the new Kimmy wanted to corrupt Hyun. Maybe she would tease Hyun. Maybe she’d bring Devlin over for some fun, hoping the three of them would end up in bed together. What if they were all in bed right now, Sophie away at a friend’s house, two empty bottles of wine, three naked bodies writhing in Hyun’s bed?

He groaned and bit a knuckle, sitting in the coffin silence of his shut-down car, the windows opened a crack so he wouldn’t steam them with his hot breath in the cold of an autumn night. He unzipped his jeans and pulled his cock out, the thing hard as steel and leaking with excitement.

STEAM

Though Hyun had giggled, she now turned up her nose in the pose of childish disgust, and Kimmy laughed and asked her why. Hyun squeezed her nose for a second, let it go, wiggled it, then whispered, “Men’s *stuff* is weird.”

Hyun must have meant the reference to the size of Devlin’s penis. Kimmy summarized it better: “Men, in general, are weird.”

“Yeah,” Hyun said in quiet agreement. “So you think because it was big, or long, I guess, that...”

“I’m being stupid, right? I mean, there’s so slim a chance that...”

“I wouldn’t worry, Kimmy,” Hyun said, soft but with concern, putting an arm on the back of the couch and touching Kimmy’s neck. It felt good, and at the same time, invasive enough it lifted her skin in goosebumps. She leaned into Hyun’s touch. Hyun said, “How can you and Josh have a relationship like that?”

“Where something like that can happen? I don’t know. It’s all very new. I don’t know how to feel about it. I don’t even *like* Devlin.”

“You don’t? You’re doing it for Josh?”

“No, it’s not like that.” She thought about it for a moment while Hyun rubbed the back of her neck. “Devlin’s . . . he’s an asshole. But he can be funny, and he’s really masculine. He’s tall and strong. And he knows what he’s doing.” She chanced a look at Hyun. “Do you know what I mean?”

Hyun’s brow furrowed with query. “Like, in *bed*?”

Kimmy nodded. “And his body is...” She felt stupid saying it out loud, juvenile and dumb. But she said it anyway. “His body is unbelievable.”

“I can’t believe you’d ever do this.”

She chewed her lower lip, then regarded Hyun again. “So am I bad? Is this immoral? I mean, I want to explore, and if Josh . . . I love Josh more than anything. I really do.”

Hyun’s rubbing fingers ceased, and she returned her hand to her lap with the other one. “I don’t think it’s bad or that you’re bad. I don’t know if it’s immoral or not, but—”

“I wouldn’t ever do this if we had children.” She put her hand over her stomach, lips pursing, regret and shame heating up her collar.

Hyun smiled and made a small, amused sound in her throat. She regarded Kimmy with compassion. “It’s okay, Kimmy. It is. If you didn’t concern yourself with all the ramifications, then, yeah, maybe that would be immoral. You’re not cheating on Josh, right?”

Kimmy’s mouth opened, then closed. She said nothing more. Hyun asked her if she wanted another drink, and she said she would like one. Hyun went to the kitchen and returned with another sparkling water and a refill of her own wineglass.

Kimmy said, “Josh is my man. He’s the reason I want to do anything. I really love him. He’s a man in all the best ways. He really is. And this guy Devlin, he only *thinks* he is. He’s like, got the body, the height, the deep voice and everything, this huge penis, you know, but there’s not much else there.”

“Does that matter if he has any of those things?”

Kimmy shook her head. “It’s not like I’m trying to choose between two men. What I mean the most is Devlin doesn’t think much of Josh.”

“What?”

Kimmy nodded, not looking at Hyun, looking at the bubbles fizzing in her glass. “I don’t like that.”

“Do you tell him to stop?”

“Yeah. He doesn’t though. See, I look at Devlin, and he’s a guy who only *looks* like a man. He tries to espouse all these new age manosphere philosophies, and he reads the books he thinks he’s supposed to read, or at least he says he reads them, and he swings this big *tool* around”—she wagged a loose fist at her crotch like she was a man holding an enormous penis—“and he makes fun of Josh’s penis, you know, compared to his, and like...”

“He makes fun of Josh like that?”

This was going further than she'd intended, like the soft hand on her neck and the supportive feminine posture and listening ears had paved a smooth path for her, and once she started rolling on it, it felt so good she didn't want to stop. Hyun sat open and caring, knees drawn up on the couch seat, sitting on her feet. Intent and curious. And supportive. Kimmy regarded her without saying anything, just enjoying a really good feeling from her. They both smiled. “He does. He makes fun of Josh. I defend him.” And then in case Hyun thought otherwise: “Josh doesn't have a small penis. . . . Sometimes I think he likes it when Devlin makes fun of him.”

“He does?”

She nodded. “Yeah, I don't *think* that, I *know* that. Josh doesn't reject it when Devlin does that. He just . . . onboards it.”

Hyun said, “So this was more than one time with him? With Devlin?”

This was where it was too far. She didn't want to admit to more than what she'd already divulged. She rubbed her forehead, leaning forward. “I wish I could have a drink right now.”

Hyun rubbed circles on the center of Kimmy's back, right between her shoulder blades. She sat and let her former sister-slash-cousin-in-law do it. It felt so good. Totally different from what she was used to. She chuckled and said, “I'm caught between them. One man who loves me and who I love in return, and another one who I share some intimacy with purely on a physical level. But they're both a drain. They're both all about themselves. Josh is...”

“Selfish?”

“No. It feels unfair to say that. He's so kind, and he loves me. But, shoot, you're not wrong. It's got to the point now whenever I see *either* of them, I'm wondering what they want from me next.”

Hyun still rubbed her back, sitting quiet for a moment before saying under her breath, “I still can't believe this.”

“We're not like this, Hyun. I don't know how this came to be.”

“That's why I can't believe it. And you go to work every day and see this guy? And Josh doesn't stop you?”

“No, he just wants to know everything that happened.”

“And *does* stuff happen?”

Kimmy sighed, then groaned, sat upright, leaned her back on the couch, the crown of her head falling into the cushion. She rolled her face towards Hyun and showed her the expression of a woman at her wit's end. "Sometimes."

Hyun looked down at the space between them, working her fingers together, contemplating this unexpected and shocking revelation. Her brow furrowed and her mouth switched to one side. "How come you didn't use a condom?"

"We did."

"So then why are you worried? I don't get it. Could it have torn?"

"No. It didn't tear." Nope, all of Devlin's sperm was collected in the end of the condom after she'd jerked him off with two hands in the driver's seat of his Mercedes. Then the removed condom fell before she could tie it closed and it fell upside down on her leg and leaked down her ankle and into her sneaker. All of Devlin's come was safely collected by the condom, and none of it was inside her body. But she'd rubbed his unprotected cock on her. She'd even teased his naked cock head inside her opening. The chance that Devlin was her baby's father was less than one percent. But she still couldn't get it out of her mind. And in her newfound dark and complicated complexion, she couldn't halt the runaway erotic thrill of bearing the offspring of a man she hated. Even thinking of it now, of having Devlin's little boy in her belly, made her thighs flex. It would be the ultimate punishment for the ultimate sin. A lifetime burden forced onto her, one she would bear for the rest of her life, one that would remind her every day how bad she was.

Hyun was troubled, not understanding this at all. "Kimmy, don't you think you're worrying about nothing?"

She faced Hyun. "What would you think of me if Josh wasn't my baby's father?"

Hyun's eyes stayed soft and compassionate, stroking Kimmy's forehead, playing with her hair, her mouth working around. "I would love you and I would love the baby. You would love the baby, too."

She nodded. She would love the baby. "I would. I would love the baby even if it wasn't Josh's."

Hyun smiled and whispered, "Kimmy, it's Josh's baby."

A sickly swirl rolled around her tummy and seized her low, tightening her core, her inner thighs. “Oh my God, Hyun, if it *isn't* Josh’s...”

Hyun laughed louder and fell forward, burying her face in Kimmy’s collar, the wetness of her breath heating Kimmy’s skin. She sat up again, smiling wide. “You’re playing with me. You’re doing it to yourself. Worrying for nothing.”

“I know I am,” she said and laughed too, then wiped her cheeks. “I’m just a ball of anxiety right now.”

Hyun seemed satisfied now that her friend’s apprehension was unnecessary, her mind at ease and like she wanted to imbue Kimmy with the same positive spirit. “I’m going to make you some tea, okay? And then you can tell me more, if you want. But I don’t want to entertain your worry over something so infinitesimally small.”

“I can’t help it. I worry about Josh. I worry about what he would do.”

Now Hyun looked glum again, slouching a little. “What do you think he would do?”

“He would hurt. That would hurt him.”

“It would. Of course it would. But . . . didn’t Josh know the risk?”

“I guess.”

“He wouldn’t be mad at you, would he?”

She had to think about it, think about the right way to answer, but something just appeared on her horizon like a glowing sunrise, the dawning of the most incredible idea. She covered her face with both hands, and breathed into them, feeling her fingers tingle. “You’re right, Hyun. No, you’re right. I’m being crazy. I have to be pragmatic here. I’m pregnant. Josh is the father. I have to leave alone the idea he’s *not* the father. The odds it’s not his are astronomical. Once I start to think about it, I spiral. And it’s just not possible. Right?”

Hyun spoke no answer, only smiled and showed a proud look, like she’d gotten through to her and made a difference. “I’m going to boil some water. Do you want anything else?”

Kimmy showed Hyun an embarrassed expression. “Do you have any cookies?”

We're in trouble.

That's what she'd told him lying in bed with him after he'd found her coming home wearing clothes another man bought her. They were in trouble. So much trouble. Ever since the night he'd drank too much at that stupid party after the high school reunion, his entire sturdy fortress he'd constructed around his psyche had been taken down brick by brick. There were two demons working against him, disassembling his will and his resolve. One who loved him and one who hated him. Hated him for no reason. And the one who loved him?—he gave her everything he could to earn that love.

The satin feel of her panties—the pair Devlin removed from Kimmy, then concealed where he knew Josh would find them—slipped up and down his erection. He pulsed persistent streams of pre-come into the fabric, watching the window where his wife held erotic rendezvous behind his back in his cousin's ex-wife's apartment.

His hot breath fogged the side windows.

They were in so much trouble.

MAGNITUDE

Hyun concocted an impromptu recipe for homemade cookies using the ingredients found in her kitchen. She didn't keep cookies in the house very often, even for Sophie. Kimmy toasted sesame seeds in the countertop oven, and Hyun prepared a batter. "Where's your honey?"

Hyun told her it was in the cupboard on the left side of the fridge, second shelf, and Kimmy retrieved it. As she heated the sugar-stuck lid under hot running water, she said over her shoulder, "Did you sing that song for me at karaoke?"

Hyun chuckled, saying, "Yeah. Who else would I sing it to?—we were the only ones there."

"No, I mean, it just seemed . . . *special*."

"Oh. Yes, it was special. I *love* that song."

"Okay."

She unglued the lid and opened the honey jar, turning to face Hyun's back while Hyun stirred batter with a spatula. There had been a change in Hyun's stirring movement, Hyun wondering why Kimmy would ask her about the song.

Still stirring, slower now, Hyun said, "What did you mean by *special*?"

"I don't know," Kimmy said. "When you sang it, it didn't seem like karaoke. It seemed like you were, I don't know . . . *honest*. You were conveying so much emotion. I've never seen anyone sing like that at karaoke."

"Really?"

“Yeah, really,” Kimmy said, turning away to spoon out honey into a measuring cup, but still watching Hyun over a shoulder.

Hyun paused and rested her hands on the counter. Without turning around, she said. “It *was* special.”

Kimmy studied the lowered slope of Hyun’s shoulders, the bowing of her head. All signs of an admission. A confession. She set down the honey and turned around. “I thought so. I’m glad.”

Hyun quarter-turned. “You are?”

Kimmy stepped over to Hyun’s side of the galley and leaned on the counter at Hyun’s side so they could see each other. “I like spending time with you.”

Hyun’s sweet face traveled a cavalcade of unpretentious but ardent human emotion; confusion, hope, fear, worry. . . . The fear and worry rose from the apprehension of misinterpretation; of desire and longing superseding her practical thought. Hyun wanted more from their relationship, but believed she didn’t deserve it or it couldn’t ever be. But the revelation of an open relationship with Josh had opened the doors of possibilities in Hyun’s mind. Things that *could* be. And her struggle was one most likely of morality and propriety. Kimmy was married to her ex-husband’s cousin; Kimmy was her daughter’s proximal aunt. Hyun’s attraction would stoke a fiery internal consternation, a veritable tussle within Hyun’s psyche. But this recent presentation of the object of her desire’s wanton, wayward lifestyle would open up temptations impossible to resist.

All of this played out on the pale porcelain landscape of a face as pure and blameless as innocent Sophie; a naïve ingénue.

Kimmy smiled and said, “Hey, I mean it.” She lured Hyun closer with waving fingers to come closer. Hyun did, and Kimmy hugged her in the platonic attitude of close friends. Hyun felt soft and warm and perfect in her embrace. “You make me feel good when we’re together.”

Later, they were on the couch eating warm cookies and drinking tea. Hyun had abandoned wine for tea in sympathetic sobriety. The cookies were crisp

at first but also chewy, coated in a honey-ginger syrup. The tea was chamomile and sweetened with more honey. Hyun sipped, watching Kimmy in silence over the curved edge of the pottery mug. When she set her mug down, she said, “How did it start?”

“How did what start? The *thing*...”

“Did it come out of the blue? Did he warm you up to the idea?”

“I don’t know where it came from. It’s Josh’s thing. If you asked me last year if I could see this happening in my future, I would have said you were crazy. Josh is under a lot of stress. We were . . . we *were* pregnant. Now it’s all changed, and he’s moving up at work and . . . I don’t know what to tell you. It wasn’t all at once. It was inch by inch. And, look,” she said, setting her mug down too, “I’m not unhappy about it...” She shook her head, frowning, rubbing her neck. “I want Josh to be happy. Devlin is good to me. I fear this could hurt my career sometimes, but...” She sighed and grimaced in exasperation.

Hyun scooted a little closer and moved Kimmy’s hand out of the way and took over rubbing her neck. Kimmy slumped and looked Hyun’s way, smiling and showing the psychic relief that came from her touch. “Josh has hangups. Like trauma from bullies in high school. Devlin wasn’t so nice to him back then. I want to do this for Josh because I hope he’ll have some breakthrough, or some sort of stalemate with whatever ghosts haunt him. It sounds crazy, but we talk about it. We talk about how it can reclaim Devlin’s historical power over him or whatever. It doesn’t make sense sometimes, but I think I understand.”

“I don’t understand it,” Hyun said, rolling the pads of her thumb and fingers on the sides of Kimmy’s neck, smoothing them up and down. Kimmy moaned and bowed her head forward. “But I trust you know what you’re doing.”

“I don’t know if I do.”

“You can stop if you want?”

“Of course.”

“Would Josh make you feel guilty about that?”

“About stopping? Maybe. He might try, but Josh is no bully. I don’t want you to think he’s making me do something I *don’t* want to do. I don’t do *anything* I don’t want to. Josh can’t make me, and I don’t know *anyone* else who could. And like I said, I don’t hate the act. I’m kind of, gosh . . . I

like being open. I like being able to share parts of myself without Josh being jealous. There are parts of this that are pretty amazing, really.”

Hyun’s hand-rubbing slowed and stalled for a moment. They both stayed motionless for seconds, then Kimmy turned to regard Hyun. “Do you want to have a real chill out night?”

“Sure,” Hyun said, timid, pupils darting over Kimmy’s.

“Like a sleepover night, like Sophie’s having? We can get comfy and watch movies and talk.”

“I’d like that,” Hyun said, looking like she would do anything Kimmy asked her right now.

“Like last week when you slept over—oh, we should climb into bed.”

“My bed? Yeah, okay. Yeah, we could do that.” A small sparkle in Hyun’s eyes pleased Kimmy; the little smile of excitement on Hyun’s face, the honest keenness in her reply.

“I’d really like to get horizontal,” Kimmy said, rubbing her own neck again.

Hyun’s bedroom decor was sparse, and the room tidy and organized, looking like nothing would be out of place. It looked unused, or like someone didn’t really live in it; a show room model. The queen-size bed frame was chunky brass, the quilt white with small embroidered roses.

What had it been like for Hyun when she split with Meyer? How would it be to go out on your own and not know what your life ahead would be like, when a moment before you’d thought it was set in stone? She had bought all this furniture for herself and her daughter, and done it alone.

Kimmy put one knee up on the bed, then lay down on it, curling up with her head near the pillows. Hyun turned on the bedside lamp and then went back to the bedroom door, closed it, and turned off the main light. She turned on the television, a small LCD on her dresser.

Hyun came to the other side of the bed and climbed up as well, not looking at Kimmy, but looking toward the television and working a small remote. Kimmy asked her, “What was it like when you went out on your

own—when you and Meyer split and you got this apartment, how scary was it?”

Hyun still watched the television, thinking how to answer, caressing the remote’s central circle pad with her thumb. “It was awful,” she said in a barely audible voice full of anxious breath.

Kimmy put two hands under her cheek, laying her head on Hyun’s pillow. “What was the scariest part?”

“I worried about Sophie. I worried I made a mistake, that maybe I’m selfish, maybe...”

“I think you did the right thing. From where I look, it’s clear you made the right decision.”

Hyun nodded. “At the time, though, it was really scary.”

“I bet it was,” she said, then reached a hand over to lay it on Hyun’s. “You’re happy now, though.”

“Of course I am. Yeah, it turned out okay.”

“Did you ever wonder what other people would think? About Josh’s family, about me? Like, what would we think of you?”

Hyun smiled a little, like the answer to the question was a resounding yes. She shifted where she sat, scooting lower so they both lay with heads on pillows, looking at each other. “My family’s in Guelph. I have to stay in Ajax. I have to be near Meyer. I can’t go home to Guelph with Sophie. All the Waters are east of Toronto, all the Kims are in Guelph...”

Kimmy smiled and touched Hyun’s cheek. “You were trapped behind enemy lines.”

“Kind of, yeah,” Hyun said. “But you guys were good to me, and Josh is Meyer’s favourite Waters. They’re like brothers.”

“They are. I think about that a lot. How weird it must have been for you. I’d hate to feel the way I pictured it.”

“It wasn’t that bad, Kimmy. It was Sophie I was concerned about. Meyer’s been great, and we get along.”

Kimmy sat up and hugged her knees, looking at the menu screen lit up on the television. “What do you want to watch?”

Hyun said, “Something sweet or something funny.” Then Hyun’s hand touched Kimmy’s back, between the shoulder blades again, smoothing slow circles. Kimmy groaned a long feline sound once more, not even an act, just loving Hyun’s contact.

Hyun said, "I can rub your back for you. Is your back sore?"

Kimmy still made sounds of pleasure, chuckling a little in her chest. "I'd like that."

"Really? You would?"

"I sure would," she said and sighed, laying a cheek on the point of one knee, face angled toward the screen. She'd found the remote in the bedding near Hyun's hand and clicked on the Disney app, then Hyun's profile picture, a portrait of Donald Duck. Hyun sat behind her, her legs appearing on either side of Kimmy's hips, closing Kimmy's back in the V of her open thighs. Hyun began rubbing her back, running the curve of her thumbs upward on both sides of Kimmy's spine, running them back and forth on her shoulders, caressing her collar. Kimmy sat straighter and removed her top, taking the light cotton tank she wore under her sweater along with it. She'd worn no bra tonight; her back was bare. There was a long, unending quiet, and the air seemed still, atmospheric ions coalescing in the damp air between them, the tension zipping an electric current between them.

At last Hyun's warm hands touched her naked skin, laying pigeon-toed on her back, thumbs touching, like she tried to imitate an angel's wings, even spreading her fingers wide, angling them like feathers. When she drew her fingertips down Kimmy's naked skin, those ions crackled and popped on her static skiff, and sent wild shivers through her central nervous system. She shuddered, and her skin tightened all over her body.

Hyun made an amused sound, then rolled the points of her nails in slow spirographs that tightened her nipples so much they hurt. She pushed her thighs up into them.

Hyun said, "I think I have some almond oil."

"That would be nice," Kimmy said.

Hyun scooted back, got off the bed, then went to the bedroom door. She left and closed the door behind her. Kimmy lay back on the bed without a top, bare chested. Hyun had balled her nipples up to hard, aching buds. Her touch had set her scalp tingling, and even her ears felt ticklish on the insides. She shuddered again, listening for Hyun's return. On the other side of the bedroom door, she heard Hyun opening and closing the apartment door, then re-locking it and putting the chain on. She returned through the bedroom door with a brown glass bottle of massage oil. This time, she locked the bedroom door.

When Hyun looked up, she saw Kimmy laying on her bed, face up, shirtless, her breasts bared. Kimmy regarded her with an unbothered look and put one hand under her head. Hyun's eyes widened, and her lips slimmed to a nervous line. But Hyun didn't stall. She walked to the bedside and sat down, turned and lay on her side, looking at Kimmy with the bottle of massage oil held at her chest in two hands. Kimmy rolled to her side and faced her.

"If anything happens," Kimmy told her, "you know it's just physical."

PROXIMITY

S addened but still eager, Hyun's eyes looked down, then back up again. "I understand, I think."

Kimmy's hand rested on Hyun's shoulder. "I feel so much from you, Hyun. I want to share with you. I love it when we hug, when you touch me. You make me feel so good. Like, safe. But I don't want to take advantage of you. I don't want to lead you on, make you think there's more there. When you sang at the karaoke, I saw so much wonder in your eyes, and I don't like to think of it just being extinguished, you know, whatever you're feeling shouldn't just stop."

Hyun's eyes took a high gloss and her brows furrowed in the middle, wanting to believe what Kimmy said, wanting it to be true.

"I want affection. I want to be close," Kimmy said.

Hyun nodded, her chin going down, eyes averting, trying to make sense of what was happening.

Kimmy's hand stroked from Hyun's shoulder to take a gentle grip on her upper arm. She met her eyes, showing a small, amused smile, trying to make the mood lighter for Hyun. "I'm going to use you. I'm going to take from you what I need." Her mouth went to one side, showing she was joking, being silly.

Hyun smiled, eyes wincing to black lines, a chuckling little snuffle breathing from her. "Like a vampire."

Kimmy's hand cupped Hyun's soft, smooth cheek. "You want to be my familiar? You can say no."

Hyun's smile shrank, and she whispered, "I think so."

“You do?”

Hyun smiled a little again, then her eyes wandered, moving to Kimmy’s naked chest, her breasts pressed together.

“I want affection. I want to be close to you. I know I’m selfish, I know. I know I am. You make me feel good, Hyun. You’re good. I want to steal it from you.” She moved her hand from Hyun’s face to her collar, then to her chest, resting over Hyun’s heart. Hyun moved the hand with the massage oil bottle out of the way to give her space.

Hyun started to speak, hesitated, slimmed her lips, working her mouth around. Then: “I know it’s not my place to say, but . . . I don’t like it. I don’t like what you do with your boss. It’s not good for you. And I don’t like to think of you with this other man.”

“Yeah,” Kimmy agreed in a soft whisper, nodding. “It’s over. It’s not going to happen again.” Which was true. Devlin had changed everything. Devlin had taken the fun out of the endeavor.

“Obviously,” Hyun said, eyes drifting lower from Kimmy’s chest. Her hand moved, timid at first, then bolder, coming to touch Kimmy’s bare skin, warm hand resting on Kimmy’s waist, just above the waistband of her cotton pants. Her thumb drew a circle near the centre line of Kimmy’s belly. “I guess *this* changes everything.”

“It does.” Now she retracted her extended arm, rolling her torso away and laying her shoulder blades flat on Hyun’s bed, her breasts exposed. Hyun’s hand stayed in place, dragging across Kimmy’s skin to lie flat on her bare stomach. But the pants Kimmy wore were high-waisted, and she unbuttoned them and drew the zipper down. Her hand covered Hyun’s and guided it lower, under her opened fly, over the space where her baby grew. Their fingertips touched the top edge of her panties.

Her head rolled toward Hyun’s and she smiled. Hyun smiled, too. Kimmy played her nails on the back of Hyun’s hand while they looked into one another’s eyes. Hyun was a kind human. A special woman who Kimmy admired and cared for, who birthed and raised one of her other favorite humans, away tonight for her first sleepover. She had real and true feelings for Hyun, though they’d never been sexual. The affection was honest. The respect was honest.

But this union with Hyun would rob Josh of his ability to cast his forsaken wife out of the family. She would establish ownership over

Sophie, the child in their life. She would gain an ally, someone who would cast doubt on Josh's claims; Hyun was someone who would defend her, someone who would muddy Meyer's understanding with conflicting or contrary details. If Josh finally broke before she could save them, if her loving husband crumbled and could take no more, she wouldn't be so easy to cast out into the cold blue light, away from the warm fire of family.

Her eyes lowered to Hyun's soft and succulent mouth, and she moved closer. She'd never once kissed another girl, or had ever thought about it. But Hyun really was special. She was quiet and private and it was just the two of them alone in the apartment and no one would know what they were doing. There was an erotic pull.

Hyun closed the space between them, rolling Kimmy's way, bringing their mouths into cool, damp contact while her hand rode down between Kimmy's legs and cupped her panty-clad mound. Kimmy gasped into Hyun's kiss and Hyun swallowed it, working her mouth on Kimmy's in slow, sensual exploration.

Hyun's boldness surprised her, and she chuckled while they kissed. She raised her knees and opened her legs wider. Hyun caressed her pussy over the cotton underwear, pulling Kimmy's lower lip with her own. Hyun said, "You have the most beautiful mouth. I love to watch you talk. And smile. And laugh."

Hyun withdrew the hand from over Kimmy's pussy, like the boldness was only a show, and her hand remaining there without explicit permission might be a violation.

Kimmy said, "Take your top off. I want to feel your body on mine," and touched the hem of her sweater. Hyun closed her arms protectively, squirming away.

"My body's not like yours."

Kimmy rolled toward her and embraced her, kissing her cheek, squeezing her in her arms. "Let's get under the covers."

Hyun found that agreeable, her eyes still showing trepidation, but they each went in turn, lifting the bedding and shifting so they were underneath. Kimmy showed Hyun a happy expression while she shimmied her pants off under the covers, and it spurred Hyun into taking her sweater off, pulling her arms out and then lifting it over her head, all without accidentally lowering the covers and revealing her nakedness to the lamp light.

Kimmy went to her again, now naked but for her cotton underwear bottoms, finding Hyun topless but wearing her bra, and still wearing pants. It felt sweet hugging her, putting her arms around Hyun, and feeling her soft body. She was warm, and the feeling was tenderness and care. Hyun's hands explored her back.

Kimmy said, "I only want affection. We don't have to do anything, Hyun. We can just do this. I don't want to push you or make you feel pressure."

"I'm okay," Hyun said.

"I want to take your bra off."

"Okay."

Kimmy's hands worked behind Hyun, unclasping her bra. She freed it, then ran a strap off her shoulder with the point of her index finger. Hyun, at first, crossed her arms over her chest, but soon found the courage to remove the bra. She even allowed the bedding to slip down to her upper arm. Kimmy kissed the front of her shoulder.

Then she took Hyun in her arms again, rocking with her, her hands sweeping Hyun's smooth back, dipping into the backside of her pants to see if she wore underwear. She did. Hyun nibbled small kisses on Kimmy's neck while they embraced. It felt sweet and safe and altogether good.

Hyun stopped kissing her for a moment to ask her, "Josh lets you do things like this? He likes it?"

"Yeah. But this isn't for him."

Hyun's eyes widened as she faced a newer fear. "You're not going to tell him, are you?"

Kimmy shook her head and touched Hyun's cheek. "No, this is between us. Don't you think it's only *our* business?"

"Yeah."

"This is just us in a closed room with the door locked. This will *only* be ours. No one else's. I promise."

Hyun nodded. "I would like that."

They rolled together, sometimes kissing, sometimes touching. Hyun liked kissing everywhere on Kimmy's body, but never moved her mouth to Kimmy's nipples and her hand did not return to between her legs.

Kimmy asked her, "Have you been with someone before—a woman?"

Hyun took a long time answering, but said at last, "One time."

It warmed her heart, and she couldn't help feeling so much affection for her. She cupped Hyun's cheek again, saying, "You are so special. So special."

Hyun said, "Have you?"

Kimmy's smile dissipated and she said, "No."

Hyun lay her head on Kimmy's arm and looked up at her. "Did you . . . did you see other guys before Josh?"

"Yeah. I did. Do you mean more than that? More than see them?" Hyun didn't answer, but Kimmy read it in her eyes. "Yes. Josh wasn't my first."

"Was it weird then with this other man?"

"Yeah. It was."

Hyun thought about it, her eyes lowering, drifting again to Kimmy's breasts. Her fingertips explored Kimmy's stomach. "You're so beautiful. I've always thought you were so beautiful."

"I think you're beautiful too, Hyun." She guided Hyun's hand to her breast, squeezing the back of Hyun's hand, encouraging her. Hyun's thighs shifted under the covers and she inched closer, concentrating on cuddling one of Kimmy's breasts.

Hyun said, "I'm not like a man."

"No, you're not. You're better," she said, thumbing the back of Hyun's hand over her breast.

"I mean, I don't know how to please you."

"You're doing it right now, Hyun. I don't want it from a man. I could lay with you like this all night and be happy. Sometimes when I'm with Josh or with Devlin, I feel like I'm just an object for them to fight over. Josh loves me. Devlin doesn't. But neither of them are tender like you are. That's all I want. That's all I need."

Hyun said nothing, still looking lost.

Kimmy said, "I don't know how to please you."

At last, Hyun showed a small smile, seeing the truth in that statement.

Kimmy chuckled and hugged her tight. "You don't need a penis to please me. I only need—"

She stopped, mind racing. A sudden spike of pure thrilling erotic desire tightened and her heart began racing.

Hyun said, "What is it?"

Kimmy rolled over Hyun, getting her flat on her back and began kissing her again. This time with pure horny passion. Hyun was receptive, kissing her stronger in return. Her hands went over Hyun's soft shoulders, caressing her breasts—the first breasts not her own that she'd touched. She shot her rump back and lowered her mouth to one of Hyun's soft pink nipples. It went hard in her mouth, her tongue toying with the rubbery bud. She kissed Hyun's stomach and her ribs. She was soft all over, curvy. A woman. A mother. She wore the dimpled curve of a c-section scar.

When she put her face over Hyun's again, Hyun's eyes were alert and electric. Her pale cheeks showed the pink of sexual blush.

Kimmy said, "Let me get my phone." Hyun didn't object, only waited as Kimmy searched under the covers for her pants. She fished her phone out of her pocket while Hyun rubbed her back. She lay back with Hyun, cuddling at her side like they were teenagers.

"I have to go to work tomorrow, but..."

Hyun said, "And I have to go to school."

Kimmy said, "Is it okay if I sleep over?"

Hyun giggled. "We're going to have our own sleepover?"

"Yeah, what do you think?"

"Definitely."

"Good," she said, texting Josh. "I have to get up *super* early, like four-thirty, four-forty-five. I'll have to go home and change..."

"And shower."

Kimmy finished the text to Josh and sent it, putting the phone between her bare breasts and looking at Hyun. She bounced her eyebrows, saying, "Why's that? A shower? What the heck are you going to do to me?"

Hyun laughed and hid her face from Kimmy for a second. Josh answered her text, saying that was fine, he wouldn't wait up for her. "There we go," she said, showing Hyun Josh's answer. "My dad said I can stay."

But before they embraced again, Kimmy sat up and climbed out of the covers, snatching her top and bottoms from under there while Hyun clenched the bedding to keep herself covered. "What are you doing?"

Kimmy hiked a leg into her pants. "I'm running down to my car for just a fraction of a second. I'll be right back." She tossed her top on without the tank, and added. "I sure hope those pants are off by the time I get back."

STAKEOUT

When he saw Kimmy coming through the glass doors of the apartment building's lobby, pushing them open and trotting down the steps, he couldn't conceive of how she knew he was there. His heart pounded in his chest and his eyes focused into crystalline life-preserving perfection. He could see the determined look on his wife's face, the set jaw, the quick stepping feet down the stairs onto the parking asphalt; the jostle of her breasts, the stride of her long, elegant legs. Guilt and shame exploded in an enormous psychic geyser, and he clutched at his chest as if he were entering cardiac arrest. His fingers tingled while blood pounded and whooshed in his ears—all this in mere seconds, startled out of a tortured yet quiet reverie.

He scrambled to push his dick back into his pants. He hadn't been jerking it, but he might as well have been. The implication of a man sitting in a parking lot with his dick out didn't need a lot of angles and facets—no one sought an easier, ameliorating explanation. They put you on a list.

He pushed it down and under his fly, darting a look to see how close she was, but she wasn't coming. She hadn't figured him out. She hadn't known what he was up to.

He cursed under his breath at the fright she had given him. In one split second, he'd come face to face with the depths of his own depravity. He could see through Kimmy's eyes what she would witness, and it disgusted him. But alas, all for naught. Because Kimmy didn't march up to the Qashqai and ask him what he thought he was doing. Didn't say there were children in the building or that Sophie could be around. Didn't say, "You're

a total pervert and your perversion has gone too far.” No. She went to her Leaf and opened the hatch.

He watched now from the shadows of his car cabin, the window slid all the way down, cool October air buffeting his face. And he watched Kimmy, and she rummaged in the cargo. Maybe a gym bag. It was a bag of some kind; a zippered one. One she would bring along to yoga or to the fitness center. Not that she had much time for that these days since she began working for Devlin. No, since she was working for Devlin, maybe she burned calories in a whole different manner.

He palmed his erection under his pants again, watching her. What was it she came down for? What did Kimmy and Devlin need during their borrowed-apartment tryst? What could she have forgotten? Kimmy transferred an item from one bag to another, the other one a canvas shopping bag she’d bring into the store when she stopped to pick up a few unexpected grocery items. Whatever she came down for, it went into this shopping bag. It looked heavy; a bottle of wine, perhaps, to be shared by two lovers by candlelight. No, a bottle of whiskey. That made more sense. That was where her tastes skewed these days, all because of Devlin Stone.

He flinched when Kimmy looked over her shoulder, left and right, and he was sure he’d been spotted, but Kimmy went back to business, putting now a towel from what had to be her gym bag into the shopping bag. What do you need a towel for? Clean up on Aisle Devlin. That’s what she needed it for. Maybe she didn’t want to dirty any of Hyun’s towels. He was sticking with whiskey—it made more sense. If there was a necessary clean up in—

Shit. Kimmy looked over her shoulder again, not left and right this time, only to the right, looking right at the Qashqai.

He sank further into the shadows, wishing the window was up and casting back a glare to her like when you wore mirrored sunglasses—but she went back to work, putting the key fob in her pocket, slamming the hatchback lid down, looking left and right again, walking . . . then slowing and turning around and looking right at the Qashqai.

Now he’d been caught. She’d seen the Qashqai, but didn’t fathom how her depraved husband might be in it, skulking and watching. But her subliminal mind had worked while she tucked an expensive whiskey bottle to gift to Devlin for the magnificent fucking he just delivered, and then it hit her. That was the Waters’ Qashqai.

“Oh fuck,” he said under his breath, first instinct driving his hand to the car’s push-button start and thinking he could put the pedal down with the car in gear and get out of here before he got caught, but he stalled, picturing how that would look. Guilty times ten. He’d be even more depraved in Kimmy’s eyes.

And hold on just a fucking second. Kimmy was up to no good, as usual, and he had nothing to hide. He stuck his forearm out the window, rested it on the sill and leaned aside until his face felt the bath of moonlight.

Kimmy looked angry, rolling up the shopping bag and tucking it under an arm as she marched directly to him. A myriad of defenses raced through his mind, things he would say, things he could explain himself with, theories and formulas. Maybe even go after her. And why the hell not? Why *wouldn’t* he go after her? It was her fault he was sitting in this parking lot.

She spoke a dozen feet before the Qashqai, beginning the argument before their eyes could even meet. “What are you *doing* here?”

He said, “I went out for a drive,” cold and flat and unbothered.

“Why are you parked out here?”

“I felt like stopping, put my thoughts together.”

She crinkled her nose derisively. “Oh yeah? What are you thinking about?”

“What’s it to you? Why do you sound mad?”

“Why do I say I’m mad, Josh? Because you’re parked out front of Hyun’s apartment, like you’re spying on me. I just texted you five minutes ago and said that I was sleeping over. You didn’t say anything about, oh, you know, where you were, like you were right outside.”

“It’s too much to type.”

She shook her head and came closer, peering into the Qashqai.

“What?” he said, defensive.

“Why *are* you sitting out here?”

“I told you I was out for a drive. I didn’t know you were going to come out and see me here.”

“I don’t know what you think you’re doing. Why are you following me around?”

He scoffed. “Gosh, I don’t know. Why would I follow you around? I must be out of my mind.”

Kimmy pursed her lips, jaw muscles flexing. “What are you doing, Josh?”

“What do you think I’m doing?”

“I don’t even *know* what you’re doing. You could be doing anything.”

He chuckled, an honest reaction of total disbelief at Kimmy’s incredulity. “Like what? Yeah, why would I do something like this? I’d have to be out of my mind. I wonder what drove me crazy?”

One hand on her hip: “Did I drive you crazy? Is that what you’re saying?”

“A normal person doesn’t sit outside an apartment his wife is visiting.”

“So you’re saying you’re not normal?”

“Yeah, *that’s* what I’m saying,” he said and rolled his eyes, gripping the steering wheel, thinking back how it might have been a better idea to push that start button and peel out, burn some rubber.

“You’re your own worst enemy,” she said.

“What’s in the bag?”

Kimmy squeezed the bag tighter in the crease of her elbow. “This? What do you think it is? What did your crazy imagination come up with?”

He said, “A bottle.”

“I just told you I’m staying over at Hyun’s. I was grabbing some of my stuff out of my gym bag. Is that okay?”

“How’s Hyun doing?”

Kimmy screwed up her mouth, eyes narrowing, studying him, scrutinizing eyes that bore into him. “Is that it? You don’t think I’m here with Hyun? That’s what it is, isn’t it? Are you crazy?” Her eyes narrowed, and she looked stunned. And for a second he did feel really stupid.

He squeezed the steering wheel, saying, “I asked you how Hyun is doing.”

“Hyun’s fine. We’re having a good night. So good in fact that I thought I that I might just stay over. We’re gonna stay up late, watch some K-drama, and I would probably fall asleep, so I texted you to let you know that I would be home in the morning. I’m going to have to get up at like four-thirty. You don’t trust me to stay out at Hyun’s apartment until four in the morning?”

“Is Sophie there?”

“Sophie’s at a sleepover.”

“How convenient.”

“You’ve got to be fucking kidding me, Josh. How convenient?” She clucked an indignant sound in her throat and crossed her arms. “Why don’t you come up and say hi to Hyun? Why don’t you come up and make a big fucking fool of yourself—and of *me*, by the way. My husband coming to check up on me. I told you how things were going to go. I told you what we were going to do. I told you how I *feel* about you,” she said, dragging out the word *feel* in a long, pleading note and putting a hand to her chest, light glimmering on the surface of her wedding ring. “I told you all that, and this is what you do. You are your own worst enemy.”

“Yeah, you said that already.”

“Yeah, I said it—but *you* need to hear it. What are you sitting here thinking about? What are you sitting here concocting in your head? You make everything worse. You make everything so much harder than it has to be.”

“*I* do? How much did *I* lie? How much did I lie about what was going on?”

“You don’t even remember, do you?”

He frowned and studied her face, looking for meaning. “Remember what?”

She shook her head and turned her face up to the moon. “Never mind,” she said under her breath

“No, what do you mean? I don’t remember what?”

“Look, Josh, this is fucking crazy. I come out here and I find you spying on me. Stalking your own wife. I’m here for a night out with your cousin’s ex-wife. I thought Sophie was gonna be here. I thought it would be the three of us girls, but it’s just the two of us. And the two of us are going to stay up late and we’re going to watch TV.”

“You two sleeping in the same bed again?”

“Oh my god,” she growled, raising her voice. “What the fuck does that mean? Seriously, Josh? What the fuck does that mean?”

“Nothing,” he said, grumbling to himself.

Kimmy got closer to the car, looking in the window again, seeing what he was up to in the cabin of the Qashqai. “What are you doing in here?”

“Nothing. Sitting.”

“Sitting and doing what?”

“Thinking about you.”

“Just driving around thinking, and you ended up here.” She stepped back from the Qashqai, looked up to Hyun’s apartment. “Were you watching us through that window?”

“I can’t see in the window, Kimmy. It’s like fucking way up there.”

“But you would if it was lower, wouldn’t you? You’re fucking crazy. You’re really fucking crazy.”

“No, I’m not,” he said. “It’s crazy to me that you think that this doesn’t make sense. How could you not see? How’s it come to this? And how can you put it on me? And what’s this *remember* shit? What does that mean?”

She came closer again, leaning on the Qashqai and looking in the cabin. “Are you jerking off in here? I Swear to God, Josh.”

“I’m not jerking off. Don’t be stupid.”

Kimmy persisted. “What are you thinking about?”

“I’m wondering what you’re doing. That’s what I’m sitting here thinking about. I’m thinking about how you said we’re in trouble.”

“You’re making everything worse with your imagination. The things you concoct in your head are ten times worse than what really happens. And why *are* we in this, anyway?”

“Why are we in this? Gosh, I don’t know, Kimmy. What could it be? What could have brought us here?”

“You. You brought us here.”

Now he raised *his* voice. “*I* did?”

“Josh, don’t start.”

“I’m not starting. I don’t want to do this at all. I didn’t know you were gonna come down. I was content to just sit here.”

“Well, I’m down now. And I’m standing here and I’m looking at you in our car spying, looking through the windows.”

“You guys moved to the bedroom early.”

Now she got so close her face loomed in the window. She said, “You *are* jerking off.”

“No, I’m not.”

“Show me your dick.”

In total shock and disbelief, he said, “What?”

“Take your dick out and show it to me.”

“What the fuck are you talking about?”

“Josh,” she said, sniffing, “if your dick isn’t hard, if your dick wasn’t hard right now, you’d be jumping at the chance to snatch it out and wiggle it at me.”

He grunted, his heart jumping at her lewdness. “Wiggle it?”

“Take it out. “

“Go back to see Hyun. Go back and cuddle up in her bedroom.”

“You’re really making me mad now, Josh,” she said in an even and grave tone. And for the first time in this interaction, he felt dirty and guilty and really stupid. She said, “Take it out and wiggle it.”

“Don’t be crude.”

“Do it Josh. Prove it.”

“Just go away. Go back up. I’m going to go home.”

“No. I want to see it.”

“Don’t...”

“Josh, take it out.”

“I wasn’t jerking off. I was just driving around and I stopped here. You texted me. I said, yes, sleep over. And I was going to sit here for another minute and then go get something to eat and go home.”

Kimmy shook her head, saying, “I don’t believe it for a second.”

“Well, it’s true, so tough shit.”

“Show me that dick, Josh. Show me your dick.”

He said, “Are you trying to be funny?”

“I don’t think there’s anything funny about this, Josh. I know I’m right. . . . What if I reach in there? What if I just reach in and check? What am I going to find?”

He wiped at his brow and saw the answer flash before him. “Well, yeah, it’s hard *now*. You saying you want to see it.”

“You don’t want me to see it? You don’t want me to touch it?”

He folded his arms and gave her a get-serious look.

“I’ll do it, Josh. Tell me what you were really thinking. I’ll put my hand between your legs, and you can tell me everything you thought, sitting out here. Every terrible thing that drives you so crazy you get hard as steel.”

She leaned further in through the window, his hand brushing her chest. He looked away, looked down, mumbled complaint to himself, and found his thumb searching for the shape of her nipple under her top. He found it, found the hardened shape pressing from under the cotton.

She said, "Take it out."

"Stop, Kimmy. I can't do something like that here."

"You've always got an excuse to stop yourself from having fun."

"I don't think any of this is fun," he said.

Kimmy shifted, stuck her arm into the Qashqai, leaning in, her face close to his. Her hand went down his front, between his legs, and grabbed a handful of cock bulge. When she squeezed, his naked erect cock popped out of his unzipped fly and stuck to her palm.

"Holy fuck," she said, so close to him he could feel her soft breath on his cheek. "You were doing it. I fucking knew it. Down here jerking off." Her hand slunk around his cock and he groaned with terrifying delight. "This little thing has caused so much trouble. This little thing has made our lives so difficult." She pumped her hand up and down, and right away, her grip went slick with his pre-cum. "Out here jerking off. I told you how it was, but you can't let it go. You're out here thinking, thinking, thinking. Thinking and thinking all kinds of dirty, dirty things that I'm not doing. And you think it's me? You think it's my fault?" She squeezed his cock and ran her thumb pad across the slippery slit, making him jolt and bounce his knees.

She kissed his temple. "I'll be home at four-thirty. If you're awake, maybe I'll put your little thing to use."

She stepped back with the bundled shopping bag held under her arm, head cocked, inclined at a sympathetic angle. She smiled in a way that could have him believe that this was a kind and generous act. Kimmy could make him believe anything.

She said, "I'll see you in the morning. Good night, Josh," turned and walked away, clicking the fob in her pocket and locking the Leaf as she passed, trotting up the steps, and through the glass doors into Hyun's building, unlocking the main door with Hyun's key.

LUGGAGE

The thing in the shopping bag disgusted her. It represented the worst she offered, and Josh catching her with it put her shame into sharp focus. The only way for her to react to getting caught was to shovel it all back on him. He'd even asked her what was in the bag. Why would she have such a thing? The answer to that was terrible. But what was worse was the reason she had it now and was bringing it with her back to Hyun's apartment. The urge to discard it burned like a fever. Her stomach churned and roiled in the long and agonizing elevator ride back up to Hyun's floor, and when she emerged in the hallway, she searched for the garbage chute, thinking she would drop the venereal thing down into the pits of the building's waste management level. But flashes of potential discovery dissuaded her, standing by the stainless steel chute drawer in the carpeted quiet of the hall. Someone discovering it. An older woman with time on her hands to launch a campaign to track down who'd tossed such a totem of sin to where a child could discover it. Cameras everywhere these days, and then they shame Hyun out of the building for permitting such a degenerate acquaintance to disgrace their hallowed real estate.

Fucking Josh.

Fucking Josh was on to her. He didn't know what she planned, but knew he couldn't trust her. It hurt that he couldn't, but then again, he shouldn't. Though she meant him no harm and she wanted only good things for him, there were tasks to complete before she could restore them to some sense of reclaimed unity. If he persisted moth-flitting around the lamplight of her

sex, he would get burned. And she didn't want that. She wanted him whole and happy. She wanted them repaired.

So with the forbidden thing wrapped and tucked under an arm, she resumed her return to Hyun's apartment, nausea rising to tickle the back of her throat. Josh had scared her. She would never have thought he'd camp outside Hyun's. What if he'd seen through the window and Hyun and she had been kissing, standing up where he could see them? That would be devastating. To her, and for him. Especially since such a debacle wouldn't have been curated for him by her; it would be real and raw and terrifying. The whole elevator ride up, her subliminal mind replayed the evening, trying to recall if she and Hyun had shared any intimacy where they could have been seen.

She let herself back into Hyun's apartment, looking to get rid of the thing in the bag, but still not finding a place. She almost placed it at the door with her shoes, but then imagined Sophie coming home early and...

That terrifying thought sickened her and raced her heart. And put her depravity into further hyper-focus.

This thing with Hyun was too much. More than she'd anticipated. All she'd wanted to accomplish was an alternate-theory stratagem, something that would muddy the waters should this whole thing blow up in her face before she could defuse it, but somehow it had grown by leaps and bounds, and she'd actually gone downstairs to retrieve a sex toy to use with Hyun. How vile.

Yet, she re-entered Hyun's bedroom with it under her arm because there was no where else to stow it before she left in the morning. Hyun had turned the television and the table lamp off and the room was dark but for the silvery-blue moonlight coming into the small room from the window by the bed. Hyun shifted under the sheets, but she couldn't see her shape or her face. She walked with careful steps, waiting for her eyes to adjust to the dark, making her way to the dresser and resting her sex toy on the top, pushing it back as far as it would go in the hopes something of Hyun's would fall over it and Hyun wouldn't notice the thing in the bag when the sun was coming up. Hyun was silent, and so was she. When she'd left, she uttered the sly command for Hyun to remove her pants while she was gone, but now all that sexual adventure and excitement had faded. She returned to the bedside from where she'd departed and removed her clothes, getting all

the way naked again and slipping under the covers. Hyun's arm went around her, and while human touch right now should annoy her with all these conflicting emotions racing through her head, Hyun's touch brought comfort. She put a hand over Hyun's forearm and held her.

Hyun must have sensed a change, whispering now with a measure of concern, "Are you okay?"

And she had no answer prepared, nothing to counter with, and she said what was true. "Josh was out there."

Hyun stiffened. "He was?"

"Yeah. Just sitting out there."

"Why?"

"I don't know. Watching me, I guess."

"Did he say anything?"

"Yeah, we talked."

"What did you tell him?"

"I didn't tell him anything. I asked what he was doing here."

Hyun thought about it for a while, scratching her cheek, then returning her hand to Kimmy's arm. "Does he do that?"

"Follow me around and spy on me? No. I don't think he does."

"You're not afraid of him?"

She chuckled and dragged her nails on Hyun's forearm. "No, sweetheart, it's not like that. It's not like that at all. I'm not afraid of Josh."

"Are you mad at him?"

"I don't know how I feel. Mad, flattered, annoyed, alarmed . . . I don't know what feels right."

Hyun's arm snaked away, and she backed out of the bed, grabbing a bundle of clothes to hold against her naked body as she moved to the window.

Kimmy said, "Don't turn on the light."

"I'm not going to," Hyun said, hiding in the shadows but eyes looking down into the parking lot.

"He's gone home. I'm sure he's gone home."

"Where was he parked?"

Kimmy told her where Josh was parked, and Hyun said, "The spot's empty now."

"Come back to bed."

Hyun complied, dragging out her departure from the window with wary down-turned eyes before at last getting back into bed. Kimmy's hands went right to Hyun's thighs, stroking up and down. "You took your pants off."

Hyun made an embarrassed sound and Kimmy let her go and snuggled against her. Hyun rubbed her shoulders, hands drifting to rub her collar, then down her back. "Go flat and let me rub your back for you."

She rolled to her stomach, burying her face in Hyun's pillow. It smelled like Hyun. She turned her face aside, looking away from Hyun, while Hyun began to knead the muscles below her neck and between her shoulders. Hyun's hands were soft and delicate, but she was strong. The lid popped on what must have been the massage oil bottle and then Hyun's hand returned, gliding across her skin, working fingertips deeper into her knotted muscle.

Hyun said, "Your back really is tight. I'm not just saying that, it's really, really tense."

"I believe it," she said and sighed, feeling a shimmer of regret at what she'd intended for Hyun. But soon her mind drifted to Josh, wondering what would bring him to park outside of Hyun's. She grunted with some pleasure Hyun provoked, running pressed finger pads into her collar and lighting up her vision with sparkling release.

"I think he thought I was here with Devlin."

"In my apartment?"

"He makes things up in his head. He likes to do that. He likes to create terrible scenarios and then imagine they're real."

"But sometimes they *are* real."

Hyun's astute assessment felt harassing. Yeah, sometimes it was real. Sometimes she told Josh right to his face the bad things she'd done, and he'd lapped it up, eager and horny and under her spell in a way that thrilled her in the most unexpected ways. She shook off the aggravation and tried fessing up to see what Hyun would think. "I've tricked him before. I've played games with his mind and made him think his wildest fantasies were real. Josh is complicated and . . . *dark*."

"That's why he was outside?"

"Yeah. You're right. I drew him here. He wanted to think I'm doing something that would drive him wild."

Hyun's hand slowed on her back, still kneading, still plying, but like her hand had lost its bluetooth connection with Hyun's mind. And she knew

what it was; could picture Hyun's path of thinking. This thing with Hyun and her tonight was all for Josh's benefit; this was a Josh and Kimmy game, and Hyun was only a game piece.

But she couldn't defend herself, couldn't blurt out some proclamation of honest attraction to Hyun. It wasn't there, and the absence in face of Hyun's suspicion made her feel hollow.

Hyun said, "I don't want to be in the middle. I don't want to be between you and Josh."

Kimmy right-faced now, turning her other cheek to rest on Hyun's pillow. "You're not, Hyun. You're not in the middle of anything. I don't want you to think that. That's not what this is."

Hyun watched her own fingers draw designs on Kimmy's back. "But what is it? What is this?"

"This is it. I love your affection. I love your company. You make me feel safe. All of that is true." She watched Hyun's eyes dart around as she processed what Kimmy said, tried to find whatever advantageous position from where she would license whatever she wanted to claim from or provide for Kimmy. When Hyun's face never brightened with the expression of a woman who'd made a decision, she touched Hyun's cheek and cupped her jaw. "You're not part of this thing with Josh, Hyun. You're my friend. You've been my friend for a long time. You know that."

Hyun nodded, her eyes still turned down, hand rested on Kimmy's back, sticky with the oil.

"What can I do for you, Hyun? I want you to be happy. I want you to feel as safe with me as I feel when I'm with you."

Hyun's eyes moved with an inexorable slowness, and Kimmy waited for their gazes to meet. And when they did, the hand on Hyun's neck slipped around to grab the back of her neck and guide her closer, bringing her mouth to Kimmy's. Kimmy kissed her again, not with lusty passion, but with sensual slowness. Hyun's soft lips were stiff at first, but soon melted into hers. She broke the kiss off and let Hyun go, laying with her hair and admiring her porcelain skin.

"You make me feel safe," she said, in a tone of reverence, as though the safety Kimmy provided couldn't be described so easily. "You're so strong. You're courageous. I admire you so much."

“I admire you too, Hyun. Everything you’ve built for your life, that amazing girl you’re raising.”

“I wish I was as strong as you were. I wish I had your confidence.”

“You’re perfect the way you are.”

Hyun snuffled a small laugh at that, and her eyes showed she liked the compliment.

“Not everyone can be strong. Soft and caring draws strength closer to it. I’m drawn to you for those parts of me I wished were closer to the surface, just like you. You’re drawn to me because you admire what I have you feel is missing in you.”

Now Hyun smiled, rubbing her own cheek against Kimmy’s palm, and Kimmy thumbed the soft skin under Hyun’s big brown eyes.

“I love that you want my strength. I want you to have it. I’d be strong for you when you wanted.”

Hyun’s head rolled, her cheek under Kimmy’s palm, then she was coming close again, looking to kiss her. Kimmy arched her neck and allowed their mouths to connect. Hyun moaned a soft sound that thrilled her, and she raised over Kimmy, climbing over her under the covers, the covers sliding down her back and leaving them both topless. Her soft black hair swished on her skin like silk. It was passion like she’d never experienced. Hyun had no hard male angles, no tough skin, no coarse body hair. She was supple and loving and slow and the experience bloomed before her in a way she hadn’t expected. Hyun took the lead, sitting over her hips with her legs tucked underneath her, cupping Kimmy’s jaw and kissing her mouth. Kissing lower. Kissing her neck. Her heart raced at this unfamiliar sensuality, her thoughts careening to make sense of whether she liked it or not. The pleasure was simple to accept. The enormity of the act was something else.

Hyun’s kisses traveled her collar now, and Hyun shifted lower, her hips wagging lower, her fuzzy pubic thatch dragging a feathery line between Kimmy’s hipbones while Kimmy stared up at the ceiling.

PASSAGE

This was her sister-in-law's tongue swathing her skin; her sister-in-law's mouth enclosing her nipple. Teeth tugging, the soft sounds of sensual breathing, coming from Sophie's mother, in Sophie's mother's bed. A trembling urge to cry—to burst into tears—squeezed her, constrained her innards and tightened her breathing until her temples pounded. Her hands formed fists and pressed into her eyes while Hyun's tongue traveled her ribs. She'd started this, and now she suffered with her choice. This was the deepest, darkest regret she could conjure. But it was easier to lay prostrate in Hyun's bed and allow Hyun to pleasure her than the other option of ceasing Hyun's action and risk wounding her sister-in-law's delicate trust; her kind heart was at stake.

With gritted teeth and closed and fretting eyes, she endured Hyun's kisses down her middle, lingering in the flat expanse above her navel. Before tonight, she'd confronted the possibility actions between her and Hyun could escalate, and how to mitigate such a dreadful turn. Yes, she'd been keen to unleash the thing in the bag on the dresser, but things had been different. Josh's presence had confounded her. Turned the light on in the room and ruined the magic. Now she'd changed her mind, but couldn't prevent the fire she'd started from spreading.

Hyun's kisses explored her body, lingering near her middle, loving that expanse of flesh from sternum to the shallow between her hips. Every warm stroke of Hyun's tongue felt like biblical sin. Hyun was a family member. Hyun was a woman. Hyun was a mother. Hyun was Sophie's mother.

But stopping Hyun now would be even harder than stopping her before. So she allowed it, her brow condensed in sorrowful furrows as an innocent and beloved woman drew closer to her rotten core. Once Hyun's sweet mouth tasted the flesh of her sex, nothing could be undone. And if it couldn't be undone, it was better the knot tied even tighter.

She moaned. She writhed. Hyun thumb-stroked her waist.

It was encouragement. Hyun grew bolder and now Kimmy wished she could take it back. She'd hoped upon hope Hyun would fizzle, would never be so bold to put her mouth between Kimmy's legs without permission. But an uttered moan seemed like acceptable permission to Hyun.

Lower went Sophie's mother's mouth, lower, down to the hillock between her thighs. And Hyun wasn't eager, wasn't kissing with urgent lust; Hyun played along the wide and rounded edge of mutual pleasure; giving Kimmy the tension of the tease, but exploring parts of Kimmy she'd probably fantasized about, and taking her time with it. By the time Hyun's breath souged near the creases between her thighs, she realized the writhing of her hips came now unbidden.

When Hyun's tongue went over the scratch of shaved flesh, she moaned again, the writhing slowing so she could raise her hips up. She dug fists deeper into her eyes, trying to bowl her consciousness over backward, trying to exit reality so the physical pleasure Hyun delivered could be unremembered. Then Hyun moaned. And then Kimmy whimpered. Whimpered knowing the only thing she could do now was to tear away, to stop Hyun, to make sense of the evening, to fucking cease and desist this immoral act.

But Hyun was so close. Hyun's tongue was so close.

She closed her thighs around Hyun's ears, reached between her legs, and stroked her hair. Then opened her thighs again. Opened her thighs and humped her hips; rose her sex to meet Hyun's mouth. Hyun's mouth closed around her pussy with a wet and heavenly seal. She gasped and emitted a small squeak. The writhing returned.

She'd surrendered. Hyun's armies advanced over her hill and when her troops met Hyun's, all their bravado extinguished under the thumb of sexual might. Hyun's tongue was timid, but the timidity was heaven. Josh was eager and hungry, determined to make her come so he could claim his male victory; but what Hyun did was so different. So incredible.

But this was Sophie's mother.

More whimpering. From Hyun's tongue. From the sin.

More from the sin.

For as great as the pleasure was, the sin dwarfed it.

She surrendered further. Abandoned all.

Thunderous skies broke as the rain began to fall; the rolling thunderheads dropped their burden on the upturned face of her shame. Hot-wet passion splashed her skin and roused the dead spirits from under her sun-baked farmland. Her nipples tightened to bursting pain as she thought the worst thought: If Josh could see her now, he would die. Josh would pop like a balloon; just an explosion of strawberry jam on the latex eggshell walls. Walking through the apartment doors, bypassing the locks, bringing bolt cutters and wearing the crepe-soled shoes of a jewel thief, getting past the bedroom door, slinking in and witnessing his wife with her legs open and his close cousin's ex-wife muff diving, both women heaving with ecstasy. He would die.

Hyun was Sophie's mother.

A sharp cry pierced her throat, and her back arched, hands thrusting out and seeking to claw at the sheet. The sudden erotic thrill of total libertine turpitude rolled over her in an oily swell.

It made her come so hard. It made her explode. Not the pleasure. The sin. The pleasure of the sin. It gave her meaningful iron weight; it provided grandeur. Those thighs closed on Hyun's sweet head again and she humped and humped, her pelvic floor undulating in a piston's push-pull of great hydraulic magnitude; grunts chugged in her throat. She was squirting. Hyun working to accommodate the deluge. Her head fell back on the pillow and she flexed and rolled her tummy, continuing to jet her loads into Hyun's mouth.

The second it was over, she rolled out of instinct, looking to get out of the way of the shame that would fold over her, fork-press a seal, and bake her in an oven set to hellfire temperature.

But nothing followed her. The thrill of her base corruption, of the corruption's spread, had fired a bolt into her heart; it delivered an adrenalin shot, a stainless-steel needle into the heart of her darkness; Marlow tracking down Kurtz. Hyun finding her clitoris.

Hyun climbed over her side strewn and folded body. She needed comfort. She needed affection. This was huge. This between them was so big it could crush the whole family.

No, Hyun wasn't seeking comfort. Hyun sought her nipple, kissing her side and getting her stretching out like a cat. Hyun's body against hers was all woman. All soft tender flesh; her mouth was small and perfect, the flick of her tongue like a feather. It was incredible.

She ran her fingers through Hyun's long, silky hair. Smelled her sweet scalp, breathed her in. Feminine. Kind. Floral. Heat.

Her arms went around Hyun and brought her to sit up together. She wanted to kiss Hyun, to be close with her, to connect, but the wide and shimmering sheen on her mouth and cheeks stopped her. Her head came back and her eyes lowered. She giggled and covered her mouth, not saying what she wanted to say: she looked like she won first place at a watermelon-eating contest.

Both her hands cupped the sides of Hyun's neck. Hyun's eyes were dark and quivering. And coal-hot with fevered passion.

Kimmy said, "Looks like I came all over your face," laughing lightly and brushing the backs of her fingers on Hyun's cheek.

"It's okay," Hyun said in a quick, sighing breath, hooping her arms around Kimmy's neck. "I liked it."

"You're dirty—oh, Hyun, you're so dirty," she said, growling, lunging teeth to her neck like a vampire. Their chests pressed tight again, Hyun's soft and feminine tummy squashing against Kimmy's tight stomach.

When they collapsed to the bed again, it wasn't the dynamic of man and woman; no male ego looking to affirm command—it was closer than that. Their bond was totally different, though the physical pleasure was simpatico with reproductive copulation. This was like play. Like two friends engaging in dirty play. Her hand sought Hyun's core, wondering what she would find. What was it like to touch another woman there?

Her hand glided over Hyun's feathery pelt. Her pubic hair was long and softer than she imagined pubic hair could feel. And in the heart of that nest, Hyun's vagina was a hot and slippery mess. Hyun gushed. The stroke of her fingers through another woman's slit had Kimmy's jaw quivering. Her breaths came fast and shallow. Up and down her hand went through Hyun's well-greased channel, then she slowed to almost stalling, embedding the

pads of her two middle fingers into the deepest cleft in those soaking membranes, easing them inside Hyun. Hyun whimpered, and the sound of her high, pleased voice condensed Kimmy's focus to a narrow, predatory point. Hyun buried her face in Kimmy's bosom and clutched her upper arms, digging in the points of her nails as Kimmy sunk her combined fingers further. Then eased them in and out, Hyun's tight canal crushing Kimmy's long fingers.

The roaring sexual frenzy Hyun's tongue ignited drove a powerful engine; the curious sensation of a woman's inner walls sucking on her finger at once revolted her somehow and yet ignited jet-fuelled lust. She wanted to consume Hyun, to deliver a tidal wall of pleasure that would wipe Hyun across the bed in a gibbering mess of jelly.

"This feels so . . . unusual; God, Hyun, you're so wet, so tight."

Hyun gasped and whimpered, her head falling back, her hair swishing on the bedding. Kimmy bit her neck again, kissed her collar. Sought her nipples. Took one in her mouth as she continued to finger her trembling friend. Hyun was pure and innocent. Kind and sweet. But with two fingers inside her, Kimmy could make her say whatever she wanted. Make her do whatever she wanted.

She sucked Hyun's small but bursting nipple, and withdrew her fingers almost the entire way out, leaving the tips in the shallow of Hyun's pink, gripping aperture. Her curled-back thumb rubbed circles on the nest of labial folds, working out her swollen bean and rousing it. Hyun's soft grunts were little submissive squeaks that blew into the flames of Kimmy's already churning-hot oven.

While she rolled that innocent little clit around, squashed it, caressed it, she told Hyun what she wanted. "I brought something for you. It's on your dresser."

"Uh-huh," Hyun squeaked.

"I want to watch you get it. I want to watch you bring it to me."

Hyun breathed the slightest sigh of complaint, and Kimmy thumb-pressed her clit until Hyun's back arched and she emitted a cat-like mewl. "You'll do it," she said and withdrew the pressure. Hyun's thighs trembled. Her breaths came in quick chuffs. She still held a tight grip on Kimmy's upper arms.

"I want to see you walk. I want to see your body."

“My body’s not like yours,” Hyun said again.

“That’s why I want to see it. . . . Now go to that dresser and get my shopping bag. Bring it back to me. Okay?”

Hyun’s tummy went up and down as she panted with sexual fervor. But then she was releasing Kimmy’s arms, wiping hair from her face, sitting up. She rose into the moonlight, timid and embarrassed, covering her bottom with a hand. Hyun was a sexy woman. Her skin was smooth and pale, her waist narrow. Her breasts were small, but bigger than Kimmy’s. Her hips were wide, her cute butt a little flat, but it looked amazing lifting and shaking as she stepped in the dim silvery light across the room. She disappeared into the dark, but Kimmy heard her hand sweeping the dresser, finding the cloth shopping bag, then she was coming out of the dark into the moonlight, facing her now, her nipples rosy and wet from Kimmy’s mouth, and standing at strict attention. Hyun held the bundled bag over her stomach.

Once back in bed, Kimmy pulled her close, rubbing skin on skin, missing Hyun’s smell and her warmth. Hyun asked her what’s in the bag and Kimmy said, “Put your hand inside and feel. Tell me what’s in the bag.”

COMPLIANCE

Hyun said, “There’s something under the towel,” and Kimmy told her to lift it out. Hyun did what Kimmy told her, lifting the toy out of the cloth bag, loosely cloaked in a white gym towel, laying it on her thighs. Kimmy watched Hyun peel back the towel folds to reveal the enormous veiny pole that much resembled Devlin Stone’s erection. Hyun’s face retracted in horror at the silicon monster’s sight.

“What is it?” Hyun’s question was soft and timid, and moot—there was no denying or mistaking what the thing wrapped in the towel was.

Kimmy said, “It’s my toy.”

Hyun shook her head in comical disbelief. “What do you do with it?”

“I use it when I need it.”

“Need it for what?” Hyun still wouldn’t touch it.

“When I miss what Devlin has.”

Hyun turned her eyes down and regarded the huge dildo with a small measure of sneering disgust, crinkling her cute nose. “You *use* this?”

“It’s clean,” she assured Hyun.

But cleanliness wasn’t what Hyun had implied, Hyun saying now, “I’m sure, but, I mean, what do you use it for? No, *how* do you use it?”

“Hold it. Lift it in your hands.”

Hyun contemplated the act for a moment, but there was no doubt she would do what Kimmy asked. At last, Hyun moved both hands to lift the penis up from her thighs, one hand cupping the molded balls, the other gripping the shaft just below the head. A sudden growling hunger purred in

Kimmy's belly, seeing Hyun's innocent hands gripping such a malevolent thing.

"Why is it so big?" Hyun's eyes marveled at the sight, disbelieving such a thing would be used for pleasure.

Kimmy's legs stretched out on either side of Hyun's haunches and she scooted closer to Hyun, enclosing her in the V of her opened legs. "Do you like it?"

Hyun turned up her nose and shook her head no.

"You don't? I like seeing your hands holding it."

"You do?"

"You have such pretty hands."

"No, I don't," Hyun said. "Not compared to yours. You're so elegant."

"I love your hands," Kimmy said and put her hands over the backs of Hyun's, both women now holding this totem to Devlin Stone's mighty organ. She caressed Hyun's skin, stroked her wrists, closed her hands over Hyun's, and helped Hyun stroke one hand up and down the shaft. "Would you believe this is the size of Devlin's penis?"

"No," she said and chuckled. Then her eyes flitted up to meet Kimmy's. "It is?"

Kimmy nodded and smiled, still stroking it with Hyun's hand.

Now she lowered the dildo, helping Hyun to guide it between her legs, Kimmy taking the base and holding it to her sex, letting the thing tower from between her hips like it was her own impressive organ.

"Devlin's just as big," she said to Hyun. "Stroke it for me. I want to see you stroke it."

The act might have been too perverted for Hyun to perform, but she was engaged in play with her crush and she would comply. With pursed lips, she situated herself straighter between Kimmy's open legs, wrapped both pretty hands around the thick shaft of the toy, then eased them up and down. An imaginary phallic thrill whistled through Kimmy, tickling up her back and tightening her nipples. The sheer masculine intimidation of owning such an outsized sex implement must be a wonderful thing. She herself had simmered to a gooey childish reduction that night in Devlin's Mercedes, parked outside of her gym. And she smiled, flirting with the phantom notion of Josh between her legs, Josh stroking Devlin's cock, both of them alone in

their bedroom and worshipping the only redeeming quality of the worst man in both their lives.

She said to Hyun, “This is all Devlin’s got. Just a huge penis. He’s pretend smart, shallow, dumb. But he’s so hung and he’s so amazing in bed.”

Hyun said, “His isn’t really like this, is it?”

“It’s why I bought it. With this toy, I don’t need Devlin in my life. I reduced him to a plastic replacement.”

Before Hyun could respond, she was rolling forward, claiming Hyun’s mouth with a kiss, pushing Hyun back to lie on the bed, head at the footboard, the dildo dropping between their open legs. Hyun’s knees rose, stroking up Kimmy’s hips, smooth as silk. She suckled Hyun’s sweet, bursting nipples, making Hyun emit small chirrup of pleasure, the whole while Hyun running nails over Kimmy’s scalp. Kimmy’s hand found Hyun’s soaking pelt again, stroking her labia with the back of her thumb. Hyun gushed with excitement. With two fingers she stroked her little pussy with more purpose, getting Hyun’s breath coming in heaving, quivering gusts.

“Oh, fuck, Hyun, I love it, I love your wet little thing.”

Hyun whimpered and hugged Kimmy’s neck, pelting her temples and ears with kisses. Kimmy’s hand drifted from Hyun’s hungry pussy to the dildo, lifting the heft end and slicking it with all the wet from Hyun’s pussy.

Then she slowed, taking control of Hyun’s mouth with long, passionate kisses, bringing down the tempo of their lust. She brought the huge blunt end of the dildo between Hyun’s legs while overtop of her like a man, pinning her with kissing, introducing his engorged manhood to the woman. Hyun whimpered again as she felt the end of the toy push against her petals. Her back straightened, and she caressed Kimmy’s shoulders. “It’s too big,” she whispered.

“You’re wet enough.”

She eased the head of the cock into Hyun’s tiny nest, and Hyun whined complaint. Kimmy withdrew and re-entered. The Devlin replica pushed deeper this time, but met resistance. Hyun mewled and wriggled. Her little canal was too tight for entry.

Kimmy told her, “Get on your tummy.”

And as Hyun rolled over, ever compliant, Kimmy reached back for one of the pillows, brought it over and tucked it under Hyun's tummy, lifting up her bottom. Now she took the time to appreciate Hyun's rear end. Her hands circled the globes of her pale bottom. In the moonlight, Hyun's slit was revealed in soaked glory; a pink twist of flesh fully swollen by sexual excitement, a pretty and enticing entry. But Hyun was shy, wiggling her bottom in protest, embarrassed by how much of her showed to Kimmy. But Kimmy made lusty sounds, peeling back Hyun's butt cheeks to reveal better that sexual part of Hyun, the most secret and intimate part. Hyun stalled, ceasing her swaying hips, lured by the thought that Kimmy appreciated what showed. She stroked Hyun's slit with the pad of her thumb and it went over like with no resistance, the membranes so greased Kimmy barely felt them.

Now, from this angle, she tried again to part Hyun's flesh with the end of the huge dildo. Hyun raised her little tush, making moans of complaint, but wanting to please Kimmy with submission. The shaft sunk deeper, Hyun's pussy swallowing the engorged head of the dildo, then snagging as the shaft widened. It wouldn't go further, Hyun's slick little petals sinking inside her vagina with the Devlin-proxy's beefy width. The toy's size wanted to push all of her sex outside-in, her feathery pubic hairs clinging to the silicon, disappearing inside her. She bleated a louder sound now and wriggled away from the penetration.

"It's so big," Hyun said, aroused but abashed, beaten by her body's limits, pushed by her lover's desire.

Kimmy rose to climb over Hyun's back, one hand still gripping the dildo partly pushed inside Hyun. She kissed Hyun's shoulder blade, trying again to ease it deeper inside her, but knowing Hyun wasn't eager, and Hyun was too tight. There was a time when Kimmy had thought the same of herself, yet her desire had whipped her body into obedience, her own tight canal learning to accommodate something her dark desires wanted so bad. Hyun did not lust after a huge cock.

She kissed Hyun's back and let go the pressure she applied with the dildo. Hyun's tightness squeezed against the toy and it slid out of her body into Kimmy's hand.

"I'm sorry," Hyun said, ashamed and sullen.

Kimmy said nothing, sitting and listening to the whooshing of her racing heart in her eardrums. Her heart beat slowed. Hyun's hands moved to cover her bottom, the shame Hyun felt rising too high for her to endure. Kimmy rose and covered her back again, kissing her shoulder, putting her naked front on Hyun's naked back.

Hyun whispered, "Sorry."

Kimmy interwove her fingers through Hyun's, lacing from back to palm. She said, "Don't fizzle on me, don't you shrink."

"I wish I was better," Hyun said.

"You're perfect," Kimmy told her, wishing Hyun could accommodate her fantasies, comply with the method of her same-sex lovemaking, but not wanting Hyun's temperament wounded, not wanting her to feel inadequate.

"Is Devlin really that big?"

"He is."

Hyun said nothing, and Kimmy got the sense that Hyun might be jealous that Kimmy's other extramarital lover could provide something that excited Kimmy so much.

"Do you like how big he is?"

Kimmy sighed, rose to her knees over Hyun's back. Hyun quarter-turned so they could see each other. Kimmy smiled. "He fills me up, stretches me. It feels good, but he's not . . . I don't like him very much."

"Then why are you with him? Why do you see him?"

"I told you," she said, "that's why I have the toy."

Hyun stayed expressionless, thinking, then, at last, she smiled just a little. She rolled around between Kimmy's legs, working her way around so she lay on her back, the light from the window falling on her face. She put her hands behind her head, looking up at Kimmy admiringly, exposing her breasts. Kimmy thumbed Hyun's nipples while they regarded each other.

Now Hyun's hands came from behind her head and stroked Kimmy's thighs, up to her hips, then her waist. Hyun said, "It's your turn."

"You haven't had your turn yet." Which was true, and, if anything, the fizzling of their session could be better attributed to her fault; she was the one who'd failed to provide pleasure.

"I want you to lie down," Hyun said.

Kimmy waited a beat, then knee-walked backward so she was no longer straddling Hyun. Hyun pulled the pillow out from under her and tossed it up

with the others. Kimmy sat down, lay back, and watched as Hyun slipped off the bed, then went on her own knees to the drawer in the bedside table. She opened it, withdrew a box, opened the box's lock with a key from the drawer. With the box opened, Hyun lay out on the bed next to her, a small and streamlined vibrator in classy white and blue, and a tube of personal lubricant. The secret stash of a single mother with difficult dating prospects and an enduring crush on her ex's cousin's wife. Kimmy bet Hyun had pleased herself with this vibrator thinking of Kimmy; thinking of a night just like tonight.

Hyun climbed back up on the bed, bypassing the items she'd just retrieved and going instead for the bigger Devlin dick. Kimmy chuckled watching Hyun's newfound confidence, showing off her own toy collection to her new friend from the neighborhood, and looking to keep the play going.

Kimmy asked her, "What are you going to do now?"

"Give you what you want," Hyun said, sitting on her heels and taking the lube, squeezing out a small circle into one palm, the huge dick tucked under her arm. Then she put the dick down on her thighs and coated the end with her grip rolling circles on Devlin's big cock head. Kimmy raised her knees and let her legs part. Hyun claimed the surrendered real estate, knee-walking between Kimmy's legs and holding the huge rubber cock in one hand. She went over top of Kimmy, face to face, her silky hair falling to brush Kimmy's nipples. She rubbed the cock head against Kimmy's own soaking entry and Kimmy's eyes narrowed with a sudden surge of warm, friendly lust.

Hyun whispered, "I'm not too big for you?"

Kimmy smiled wide, bursting inside, biting her lower lip and smiling. "You're perfect," she said as Hyun eased the cock head into her pussy.

DEPTH

As each inch sunk deeper inside her, her heart beat harder. The toy's size stretched her out the same way Devlin did, and the feeling of surrendering that sacred dominion to the oversized impalement of a foreign invader felt like divine punishment, yet wrapped in the velvet cloak of an imperial spy. It wasn't solely the size of the implement, but the intangible power that surrender provided; the size felt good, felt incredible at times, but what felt better was the success of her own allure. Devlin's sexual pride, the rapture the vain man held for his own endowment, was his weakness. It turned her submission into his victory, yet it wasn't him who truly gained a thing. Not in the grand scheme he ran in his own mind. Her submission to Devlin's sexual mastery, provoked through a game of nefarious curiosity, brought her so much more. It brought her everything. And even now, submitting to the silicon mimic of Devlin's grand sexual ornament, even more was gained. Submission granted power, yet the one who received this gift could never acquire it without her permission. Their power was a mirage. A hazy image painted in suggestive strokes, the brush held in her own graceful grasp. With curiosity, submission, platitudes, and presentation, she could manifest a work complementary to the greatest Classical French Masters. Devlin assumed power the way a wartime general would. Hyun assumed it in the careful manner of ebbing and flowing lunar tides. Even in pursuing power she still shed it in huge waves of supplication and groveling appeasement. Hyun couldn't hold power for long. Her natural inclination was to return it.

Hyun studied Kimmy's face while she eased the toy deeper and Kimmy showed her the faces she would want to see. She showed Hyun sexual bewilderment, unfamiliar pleasure, new pleasure; the kinds of expressions Hyun would fantasize about. Hyun's proclivities were newfound, exhumed from the protocol of her upbringing, and what she would desire would be a shared sexual discovery, of a way they could be together that Kimmy had never explored. What Hyun delivered must be bigger and better and newer than anything ever before. Hyun wanted to be important.

Kimmy drew in three cold chuffs of air as the toy neared maximum insertion. She widened her eyes and raised her arms above her head, writhing under the pressing thumb of enormous ecstasy. She blabbered. "This is so . . . This is so . . ."

Hyun touched her neck, resting the curled warmth of her palm on Kimmy's collar and stroking her thumb up the tendon from her clavicle to under her earlobe.

"Deeper," she whispered, luring Hyun to darker places, seedier alleys in the neighborhood, lowering a hand to her own tummy and trying to pinpoint where the dildo terminated below her navel. "You feel so good." She watched Hyun's eyes travel from her gaze, lower, to where she brushed long nails over her taut tummy.

Only it didn't feel so good, as she described. At least not in the way she craved. The Devlin-sized toy was a golem substitute for the real thing. Devlin's enormous penis was spongier, warm and yielding at times. It changed states. Sometimes wriggly and floppy, other times rigid and pole-like. Sometimes when he was rock hard, out of his mind, driven there by the sexual angle she provided—his obsession with humiliating other men—she could feel every ridge, every risen vein, the rubbery lip of his coronal ridge.

This wasn't sex with Devlin Stone. It didn't bring what sex with Devlin brought, no matter how similar in size the sexual replica may be. This was bizarre intimacy with a close family friend. A former relation. Still a relation in some manner. And it was good in a whole different way. A humming tuning fork of energy between them, resonating with their mutual badness; this was Hyun's corruption. This was Hyun getting everything she fantasized about but hated. When it was presented at her doorstep, a bad part of this good woman snuck the gift inside her home where no neighbors could see her and she unwrapped it with trembling hands. Power flowed

back and forth between them like in a closed circuit, back and forth and back and forth, each of them sipping from the same poisoned cup and then swallowing while watching the other one drink.

That sexual dynamo that buzzed within her roared to life once again, shaking the rivets that bolted it inside her interior. Another orgasm swelled large, threatening imminent bursting; her saturated fields would be drenched again, another downpour coming on the heels of the first.

Her knees rose higher, exposing more of her sex to Hyun. Hyun kissed her knee and watched her eyes as she fucked her with the dildo in short and ultra-slow inch-long pulses, the toy's head pushing so deep it bordered on discomfort. Hyun didn't have the knowledge or skill with her rubbery weapon, not in the same way Devlin could wield his flesh-and-blood one, and she wouldn't be able to stretch out that inner box canyon that Devlin did, wouldn't deliver her into a whole different sexual stratosphere the way orgasms spun up from that spot would.

And yet an orgasm loomed. There was an erotic pull in the way Hyun's eyes shone on her with black, quivering intent. It lured the orgasm so close it brought a shimmering heat, showed a glimmering shine on her skin.

Then Hyun did the unexpected. Introduced something Devlin wouldn't do. Brought something only Hyun could bring. The vibrator. One Hyun used on herself. Used on herself in her direst, most fraught times. Late at night, all alone, her minion asleep in bed. She must worry about the vibrator's buzz. Or maybe Hyun only used it when Sophie stayed with Meyer. Going a week at a time with no sexual pleasure.

She groaned and purred as Hyun introduced it between her legs, fumbling for a moment as she tried to use two things at once, pulsing the dildo and seeking to start the vibrator's electric motor. And when it did start, when Hyun brought it to life, the gasp of excitement Kimmy uttered was true and real and large. She cried out and squeezed her own breasts.

This was awful. This was confounding. This was intricate. And most of all it was dark and wrong, and she held the rod, making the lure dance in the sunlight, spinning through the tall grasses; impossible to resist.

Her hand went around the back of Hyun's slender neck. She felt so soft and female; warm skin, tenderness. With the dildo buried near the hilt and the nose of the vibrator dancing around and over her clitoris, she said to Hyun, "Are you going to come inside me?"

Hyun gasped, shocked by the vulgar words. But she complied, leaning her body into Kimmy's, kissing the point of her knee again, both hands working hard to make her crush reach orgasm. "I'm going to . . . come in . . . come inside you."

Josh returned to the Qashqai, half a meatball sub and a can of Dr. Pepper in a plastic Subway bag swinging from one hand. The car was parked with the grille pointing toward Old Kingston, nosed up to the concrete barrier. He got back in and turned the car on so the fan might blow some air around the cabin, cool it off after the heat he'd generated building frustrating anger over an impossible scenario, then the heat his wife had sparked when she'd discovered him outside Hyun's building.

Past the shopping plaza's gardens, past Old Kingston, past the Mumbai Grill and the dry cleaner and the halal butcher, over the top of the black nighttime treetops, he could see the top floor of Hyun's building. He ate in silence, no music, no talk radio, only the quiet whoosh of the car's climate control. He contemplated what might be happening there. He contemplated his testy exchange with his wife. Contemplated the way she manipulated him. The way she worked from a spot two or more places ahead of him. The way, with no effort, she'd turned the tables on his stakeout and humiliated him. Her humiliation came with the steady, unbothered ease of a practiced craftsman. He had caught her in something, but she'd snipped the red cable while the clock to his detonation counted down. Snip. Problem solved.

But what problem would there be if she discovered him outside Hyun's building? Why would her natural inclination go to humiliation? Humiliation was control. In that strange moment, Kimmy had controlled him. Only a guilty person would seek to control their investigator. An innocent person would wield their innocence like a weapon. Wouldn't they?

An innocent woman might be charmed to find her husband thinking of her so much he was driving around and came to park near where she may be.

He was tired of being guilty. And he was guilty. Guilty of worry and hurt and suffering. It was her behavior, her mystery, that brought him to Hyun's building. And, yes, he'd unzipped his erection and had manipulated himself in brief, furtive caresses. But it wasn't masturbating. It wasn't the thrill of Kimmy's badness that begged for sexual touch. Sexual touch was a pressure valve; a release from the high anxiety stakes of loving Kimmy Chang. Of marrying Kimmy Chang.

Kimmy's deceptions came in pastry-thin wafers, but built layer over layer, they assumed a surprising integrity. When he felt the pressure of their weight, sex was the release. Sexualization and humiliation were the things that allowed him to endure this torment. Even if the introduction of his fear-based kink was the enacting agent of his wife's talent for framing her actions as guileless and his actions as provocative, the way only a clever and analytical lawyer could.

He finished the meatball sub in six bites, ravenous now that his clouded mind had brightened. It was a quarter after ten and he hadn't eaten since lunch at work today. Sub wrapper balled up and tossed in the flimsy bag, mouth wiped, tonguing meatball remnants out of his cheek, he popped the top on his Dr. Pepper and contemplated some more, looking out again over the roof of the Mumbai Grill. Kimmy was in that apartment. He was sure of that. He had seen her there with his own eyes. Had seen her return through the lobby.

A terrible idea revealed itself. He burped, grumbled, then sighed, set the can back in the cup holder, wriggling it into place. He licked his lower lip, eyes glued to the pale light in the windows of Hyun's building's top floor. The anxious ball of greasy worry still slithered in his stomach. A heavy dread weighed on his shoulders. Something big was happening, and he knew he couldn't see it. Knew it was right in front of him, but his eyes were tuned only to one specific wavelength.

But he knew what he could do.

It was stupid and self-destructive, but it was action. Inaction had corralled him into his current state. Action might put him clear.

He hefted his phone and teased himself with every excuse in the world not to do this. When the objections waned, he rubbed the heel of one hand into an eye and grumbled again.

Then, with sudden but fleeting nerve, he tapped the contact on his phone and then sent them a message.

Josh: Where are you right now?

He set his phone down and waited. Devlin answered less than a minute later.

Devlin: I'm with Kimmy

CADMUS ET HERMIONE

Passion pumped through her system in unexpected ways. Sometimes she lost herself in it, rolling with Hyun in her arms, suckling on her skin, enjoying the feel of Hyun's delicate mouth on her own skin. There was no reproductive imperative, only pleasure. The act of sharing intimacy with a woman was so foreign, but now that she was immersed, so much came naturally. She loved to hold the back of Hyun's thigh, loved to sweep her hand on the small of her back and then move it down to coddle her ass. She loved when their hard nipples met and rolled against each other. Even loved kissing her. And kissing was the most intimate.

The strangest thing, the scariest thing, was the honey-soaked space of time during Hyun's approaching orgasm. That was when the roiling, queasy guilt returned. She would deliver this pinnacle of sexual pleasure; she would experience it with Hyun. While she'd come twice already, delivering was not the same thing as receiving. Receiving was abandon, delivering was responsibility. And with responsibility came guilt.

But she persevered, preparing herself to witness Sophie's mother in her time of release. Hyun liked the little toy. She liked the vibrator. She did not like the threatening bulk of the Devlin replica. The vibrator made her do many things. Hyun would writhe. She would moan. Her moan was delicate, and a turn-on. She liked to grind the heels of her hands into the bed, and when she made fists, she let her curled little fingers stick out. When Kimmy would draw out the vibrator, she would roll it upward so the plastic shaft crushed Hyun's clitoral hood, mash it while the motor had the thing buzzing. This drove Hyun wild. And that's when she realized the orgasm

was close. Hyun's breaths came in brief in-and-outs, then she would hold her breath for seconds, then the quick chuff again; her hips moiled against the buzzing vibrator, and Kimmy kept it in place, maneuvering it against Hyun's clit. Then small feminine cries rose and fell in Hyun's throat. The thought occurred to her that Hyun would be silent when she came. She wouldn't bell out a long shrieking cannonade. No matter how large the orgasm, Hyun would hold it in like a sneeze in church. The curiosity quelled the guilt and encouraged her vibrator hand to continue working. She teased Hyun, gave her what she wanted, then gave her *almost* what she wanted. Then the moments where Hyun held her breath lengthened. Her own complicity in this revelation was undeniable—the teasing she delivered would conjure Hyun's orgasm. Hyun's hips raised from the mattress. She humped her pussy against Kimmy's teasing. The orgasm began. Hyun grabbed the bedding, a squeezed and tormented sound building in her collar, rumbling in her heaving chest. The writhing stiffened. Hyun fought the writhing's natural progression: thrashing. Kimmy watched Hyun's neck in the moonlight as the tendons stretched against her soft skin. A quick moment of release where Hyun collapsed in the bed, gasping and panting, and then she stiffened once more. Her legs trembled. One foot kicked out in a sweep. This was it. She'd pushed Hyun over the edge. Hyun's legs bent then, heels pushed into the mattress, knees pointing up. Her legs flapped open, then snapped closed, and she performed a half sit-up. Her hands went over Kimmy's, easing the pressure away from her swollen and sopping sex. Kimmy couldn't stop the smile. She'd just witnessed an amazing and intimate sight. One that bound them. She snuffled a small laugh and kissed Hyun's knee, her thumb finding the vibrator's button and clicking it off.

The orgasm reduced Hyun to boneless slag. She breathed through her mouth, trying to catch her breath while making as little noise as possible. She had stifled the enormity of the orgasm. Some heroic interior soldier had jumped on the grenade.

Kimmy climbed up the bed and deposited the vibrator on the nightstand, turned and closed her body against Hyun's. Spooned with her. She wouldn't chase Hyun with provocative statements, wouldn't rile her with all the itemized reasons what they'd done was okay. Only presented herself as a stalwart companion in their mutual adventure. She comforted her. Helped bring the covers over them both, re-cuddled with Hyun, both of them naked

under the bedding. She brought the sheets right under their chins, hugged Hyun, kissed her shoulder. Wanted Hyun supported and safe. Hyun should feel safe with her, feel protected and cared for.

Afterward, there was no more talking, only breathing, only comfort. Hyun stroked Kimmy's arm and let her head incline toward hers, their black hair tangling in the pillows. In time, they fell asleep that way.

But sleep was controversial. Maybe only an hour or two before she was awake again and staring at the bedroom door's pale rectangle. It was a flimsy, hollow barrier that kept them safe from the outside world. Because what they'd done held cascading implications that flickered before her like a blackjack dealer riffling the deck. So much beyond that door would hold what she'd just done in high offence. It should bring her before a war crime tribunal. In the cool clarity of the quiet and still bedroom, the guilt returned. Hyun was delicate, and what she'd done truly predatory. And yet, even now, even facing the grimness of her immoral act, the care she felt for Hyun was real and throbbing with hot-blooded honesty. Their sexual endeavor had been a revelation; a genuine discovery. Maybe just the tip of the iceberg.

But the act also brought with it the dismaying complex of potential disaster. While the union shored up her defense, it also left a wide, indefensible swath on the battlefield. More transgressive proof.

That door bothered her.

It wasn't enough to hold back the outside world. It wasn't sturdy enough to withstand the boring, penetrative gaze of the suspicious. And without that door, she was naked. There would be no hiding her unclothed sin.

No familiar faces peeking into this bedroom would assemble any rational explanation. She'd sexualized Josh's discovery, but Josh's discovery of this indiscretion would be incendiary. And what about Sophie? The thought of Sophie wrung her heart. And her father? Her sister? Not even Devlin would get it, though it would amuse him. Maybe only Amy would see the path that brought her here.

The phone alarm went off at a quarter to five. She'd told Josh she would be home at four-thirty, but set her alarm for fifteen minutes later. The tension would drive him wild.

Hyun stirred, and Kimmy held her. Hyun sighed, the weight of morning realization settling on her frail shoulders. The thing they'd done last night was not a dream. It had happened.

But then Hyun moved past the dread, rubbed Kimmy's arm, turned her head to face her. There was a small, uneasy smile there, but she was happy to see it. She kissed Hyun's forehead, then regarded her a short while, caressing her cheek. They said nothing, only watched each other, then Kimmy left her, sat up and stretched. They were both still naked. Hyun gathered the bedding to cover herself. But she didn't stay in bed, instead, stepping a leg out, saying, "Let me make you something to eat."

Kimmy stuck a leg into her pants. "No, no, stay in bed, Hyun. You don't have to. I'm just going to sneak out."

"Shower here, Kimmy. I can make you some breakfast. It'll save you time."

She zipped the fly, buttoned the waistband, then stood topless admiring Hyun. So much goodness ebbed from her. She'd tainted Hyun's goodness last night, tainted it for her own uses, and that was a terrible thing to do. And yet, her feelings for Hyun were undeniably caring. What she'd done was a means to an end, but she'd also given Hyun everything Hyun had worriedly fantasized. "Just some toast."

Hyun picked up some of her clothing from the floor, holding it in double coverage over the bedding clinging to her body. "And some eggs."

Kimmy picked up her top, holding it loosely in one hand. "You don't have to, Hyun. Stay in bed, sleep longer."

Hyun shook her head no, urging Kimmy, "Go, go get in the shower. Don't worry about me."

She would shower in Hyun's bathroom and then come home to Josh, not smelling like sex. Not smelling like Hyun's pussy. That smell would deliver the sweet, endless-questioning torment Josh loved, but it would betray Hyun. This was their secret.

But while she soaped and cleaned, she did so surrounded by Hyun's personal items. Not just Hyun's, but far worse: *Sophie's*. Johnson's baby shampoo, paraben and tear free, plus comical sponges in the shapes of rubber ducks and slices of watermelon. The squirming guilt resumed, but by the time she had cleaned up, she'd talked herself out of it, knowing in her heart she cared for both Hyun and Sophie, and she would never harm them for anything. Yes, not only that, she would do anything to protect them.

When she emerged from the bathroom, showered and dressed in last night's casual ensemble, she found Hyun in the kitchen, dressed in pajamas, pouring a cup of tea.

"How was the shower?"

"I'm all clean," Kimmy said.

Hyun had poached eggs and put them on toast with butter, served tea and orange juice, and cut up an apple and sprinkled it with cinnamon. Kimmy laughed and shook her head, pulling out the kitchen chair and sitting.

Hyun asked her what was funny and Kimmy told her, "You might be the kindest person I know."

Hyun's cheeks went red, and the sight widened Kimmy's smile.

They ate together, though Hyun only had time to poach two eggs. Kimmy offered her one to share and Hyun said, "I'm going back to bed, it's too early to eat." Kimmy ate what she could while Hyun nibbled on a slice of toast, eyes darting furtively in her direction, looking at her, but not wanting to get caught or for their eyes to meet.

There was so much to say, so many things to straighten between them, but they were both too comfortable in the moment's easy placidity. Then it was time to leave. Josh was waiting.

Hyun waved her away from putting the dishes in the sink, saying she would do it, telling her to get going, she would wash them later. Sophie was away today, not at school, but free on a PA day at her friend Chloe's place, where they had an ice cream machine. They laughed about it, but the laugh was uncomfortable.

In the foyer, ready to leave, they stopped and faced each other. Hyun looked down.

Kimmy stood, shoes on, her shopping bag with Devlin's big dick in it, wrapped in a towel. She lifted Hyun's chin so their eyes would meet.

"Everything is going to be okay. Do you believe me?"

Hyun nodded, chin dancing on Kimmy's fingers. "I do."

"This is us. This is you and me. I'll never say a thing about it."

Hyun's lips thinned, and she chewed her cheek. "Okay."

Kimmy unlocked the door, and opened the bolt, turned back to Hyun, wanting to say the right thing, the perfect thing that would ease away all her troubles.

Hyun spoke first. "Don't hurt me, okay?"

Kimmy winced and looked down, much like Hyun would do. She lifted Hyun's chin again, and this time kissed her on the lips, long and lingering. "I won't," she whispered, kissed her once more, turned and opened the door.

ASHERON

There wouldn't be much time to play with Josh this morning. She'd woke up late, showered at Hyun's, and Josh would have to get ready for work. Although, if she played this well, maybe she could even convince him to call in sick to work. What she'd like to do is lure from him his darkest fantasies—remind him that he builds the walls that cage him. And then coax him toward what she wanted to hear: the worst his imagination could conjure. *Devlin wasn't inside Hyun's apartment, so why were you there?* Without Devlin, what was Josh's greatest fear? That fear would become his new desire. And she could craft and shape it to her whim.

They were perfect. They were meant for each other. How could two people work so well together to manifest the world around them, all while attaining the most frightening treasures they would ever dream of possessing?

When she was done with Josh this morning, she could cook breakfast and they could lie around, maybe go for a walk later. Maybe even go house hunting—though they weren't quite there yet, the time would be soon. She wouldn't be able to skip work today, too much to do, but she could go in after lunch if she wanted.

The apartment was still when she entered. Had she riled him up so much last night, handling his hard dick through the car window, that even though she was late, he still lay in bed waiting for her? Probably naked and erect and nerves cinched tight as a shipyard knot. She would reduce him to a jiggling puddle of orgasmic jelly. She toed off her sneakers in the hall, enjoying for a moment the idea of Josh's existential orgasm. The sound of

his sexual whimpers had begun to arouse her recently. She chuckled, and palmed her forehead, her stomach tight with anticipation, the gray morning light beginning to fill the apartment enough she could make out the Lungshan Temple in her father's framed photograph hanging over the stand.

"Wow," she whispered to the silent apartment, feeling the aching stretch of her nipples. The buds pressed out her cotton top enough to cast long shadows. She squeezed her own breasts, and when she did, could feel pressure and heat between her legs, her body already beginning its preparation.

The kitchen was quiet, and she padded past it in sock feet, for the first time disconcerted by the apartment's pure stillness, heading down the narrow hall, wondering in what manner she would find Josh. It was almost five-thirty. Either he was in the shower, or he was in bed, tormented and touching himself. She would deliver him the greatest thrill.

At the door, she paused and listened, but heard nothing. Thought of perhaps stripping down and entering the bedroom naked. But that would be for her own enjoyment. The anticipation was driving her wild. But how would she lure from him his dark thoughts if she entered too far into the game? She needed room to maneuver, to bargain, and removing garments would be antes. She turned the door knob and eased the door open. Josh wasn't in bed. He wasn't in the room. In the bathroom, having a shower.

But he wasn't there, either.

She turned and regarded the bed. It was loosely made, looking much the same as when she'd left for work yesterday morning. Was it possible he hadn't slept in it? She pulled down the covers and put a palm on the bedsheet. No collected warmth from an overnight sleeper; it was cold.

Josh wasn't home, and he hadn't slept here?

The first thought that came to her was terrifying: he'd been injured. He'd been in a car crash. Someone had beaten him up at a bank machine; he was in trouble, he was hurt, he was alone.

Her mind raced and her heart galloped. She lay a hand on her chest, eyes wide and staring at the floor as she wrestled with anxious, fearful thoughts, and sought a plan of action. He'd left Hyun's last night at about what, nine-thirty? Where would he go? Steve's? Meyer's? Someone else's? Did he fall asleep playing video games? That had to be it.

She quick-stepped back to the hallway, seeking her phone left on the hall stand. Swiped it open and checked again for messages. Nothing from Josh. No word at all.

She typed a quick and simple message.

Kimmy: Where are you?

Then right away flicked open her Find My Phone, saw for a second Josh was in Ajax. Her heart soared, then crashed. It was from yesterday, and now her phone changed its mind on showing her where Josh was, giving her the message, The user hasn't shared their location with you.

"What the fuck?"

Josh had removed permission for her to see where he was.

"Wow," she sighed, eyelashes fluttering, her temples beginning to throb.

What did that *mean*? That was direct action.

She backed toward the bed and sat down on it, swirling disappointment clouding the sexual tension that had tautened her insides.

"So you're not missing," she said aloud. He wasn't in the hospital, a John Doe with no ID on him. Josh had chosen to exclude her digitally.

Now the disappointment combined with concern and darkened her interior skies. She rested her phone on a thigh and put her hands on her cheeks.

This was not what she had expected to find when she came home.

Then the thunderheads of guilty foreboding galloped over her shoreline and drenched the landscape.

Josh knew what she'd done last night with Hyun.

But how? How the hell would he know?

She grabbed a handful of sweater fabric over her heart and closed her eyes, bracing against a blood pressure vertigo that seized her.

Horror, shame, guilt, and bottomless mortification seized her.

Josh screaming in her head: *With Sophie's fucking mom?*

"It's not like that, Josh," she said, then whimpered. She hid her face in her hands. "And how do you *know*?"

Eyes darting all over the carpet, her mind riffled through potential weaknesses in her spy craft. How did Josh see them in bed together? She'd looked up at the window standing next to the car, making fun of him for

being a voyeur. He'd taken her up on it like a challenge. Or what? A nanny cam. Meyer? Did Meyer have access to a nanny cam? But no, not in Hyun's bedroom. He'd end up in jail for that.

"Hyun?"

Once she said it, she shook her head. *No way*. Hyun had no reason, and Hyun would never betray her.

But what did it matter *how*? What mattered was the devastation. How would she manage it?

She couldn't.

Hands trembling to practical impotence, she struggled to lift the phone from her leg, then slid off the bed to sit on the floor, eased to her side and lay on the rug. It took great effort to move the phone where she could see it, her arms—her whole body—aching and seized like she'd been infected with rabies.

Rabies made her think.

If she could manufacture a tragedy, she could save herself. Bitten by a dog, an infection. No, worse.

As the tears rimmed her eyes, she let the phone fall from her grasp and lay a hand over her stomach. This was Josh's baby. Josh's baby grew inside her.

Could *that* save her?

What kind of man would abandon his wife and child?

Was her crime worthy of excommunication?

She nodded and cried, sniffing and sniveling.

This was how it ended. This was her demise.

She saw it coming a mile away but thought she had control, thought she had a good grip on the wheel.

All those wild and foreign things she did with lovely Hyun soured on her mind's palate. She was a degenerate. Degeneracy had been the thrill; she was tall and sexy and smart and successful, yet inside she was dark and rotten. But she was commanding. The confidence and her beauty were the armor she wore every day that licensed it all. Her privilege.

The nameless weight that had crushed her when Josh had gone to Rome returned now, heavier still by her insoluble depravity. That's what it was. Deep down, all she considered to be her command was only a lacquered

veneer over the stone effigy erected in honor of her anomie; the gray state where the miscarriage's tragedy had exiled her.

Resentment.

Blame.

These were her iniquities. Her true deepest, darkest vice.

Not domination, not humiliation. Those were her sin's pressure valves.

"That's not true," she said, her jaw muscles constricted.

But it was true, wasn't it?

She shook her head no, not wanting to dwell too long in a room with such a bad smell. She tilted the phone toward her face. No return text from Josh. No response.

If it was Josh's fault, then it wasn't hers. *Was that it?*

And, so, if it wasn't her fault, then Josh deserved punishment.

None of it was true. Nothing about *any* of this was true. It was no one's fault. But making Josh suffer made it *truer*. The more Josh suffered, the truer it became.

That wasn't it. It *couldn't* be it. No, she couldn't think that.

She hand-heeled wet from her eyes, sniffing, blinking, her vision going tear-warbled.

Only one thing mattered more than anything else. All her transgressions shrank in proportion.

She wanted to know the only thing that mattered. She typed her message.

Kimmy: Are you okay?

Then she watched and waited, and the longer nothing happened, the more her features shrank, the more worry and hurt creased her brow and sank her heart. No response. She sobbed and drew in a long hoarse and shaky breath.

She typed again.

Kimmy: Please tell me you're okay

AFTERWORD

The twelfth and final book in the Devil In The Waters series will begin soon on my [Patreon](#) and on my [Ream](#) and will be available in the stores right after the last chapter has been posted.

Sign up for my newsletter on my website to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two!

ktmorrison.com

On my [Patreon](#) and on my [Ream](#) you can have access to chapters as they are written, and see artwork from the KT universe of stories—even NSFW ones!

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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